Acquisition, Conversion, Service, Retention, and Expansion in the Age of AI

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In 2024, Klarna handled the workload of 700 full-time customer-service agents with an AI assistant — and the global media went wild. By 2026, its CEO said "we went too far" and started hiring people again.
Not a story about whether AI works, but about how the full customer lifecycle should be managed in the age of AI —
across the full lifecycle, from acquisition to expansion: successes and failures, both sides told.

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Preface: The Customer Is the Last Battlefield of the AI Era

In February 2024, Klarna, the Swedish fintech company, dropped a bombshell: in its first month, an AI assistant built on OpenAI technology had handled 2.3 million customer-service conversations, absorbing two-thirds of the workload—the equivalent of 700 full-time agents. Average resolution time fell from 11 minutes to 2 minutes, customer satisfaction matched human agents, and the company expected to improve profits by $40 million a year.

The global media went into a frenzy. "AI replacing customer service" had moved from science fiction to earnings-report numbers.

Two years later, in 2026, the story flipped. In an interview, Klarna's CEO Sebastian Siemiatkowski admitted: "We went too far." Cost-driven evaluation had led to a decline in service quality; the company rebuilt its human customer-service channels and announced new hiring at its Stockholm headquarters.

The same company, two years apart, went from "AI doing the work of 700 agents" to "we went too far." What happened in between? Was AI not up to the job? Or is "customer operations" far more complex than "using AI to cut costs"?

That is the question this book sets out to answer.

What I Have Been Researching

Over the past two years, the most contested battlefield for AI inside the enterprise has not been writing code or creating designs—it has been the **customer**: how to find customers, how to get them to pay, how to serve them, and how to keep them. Salesforce's Agentforce reached $1.5 billion in ARR within a year; when the AI sales agent Artisan raised $25 million, its fundraising materials said it would "replace human salespeople with AI"; Gartner predicts that by 2028, AI agents will intermediate more than $15 trillion in B2B purchases.

At the same time, the forces running the other way are just as powerful: AI cold email has become so pervasive that 95% draws zero replies, destroying the channel's credibility; hallucinations in AI customer service have cost airlines money and embarrassed delivery companies in public; and consumer trust in AI is far lower than vendors' slide decks claim.

On one side stands the great trend of AI reshaping customer operations; on the other, a trail of spectacular failures. Public discussion is either vendors hyping "AI can do anything" or victims complaining that "AI failed." Few people put the two side by side and carefully dissect them: **What exactly has AI changed about customer operations? What has not changed? Which parts can AI genuinely carry, and which parts must remain with people?**

This book attempts to do exactly that. It is not about "how to use AI tools"; it is a panorama of customer operations in the AI era—from AI-powered acquisition, conversion, service, and retention to organizational change. Every chapter speaks through real cases and data, and it covers successes and failures alike.

Where the Material Comes From

The material for this book comes from a continuously running collection pipeline: the knowledge base now holds 398 verified Chinese and English sources—official vendor data, third-party reports, research-institute studies, and founder interviews—each tagged [official claims] or [third-party verified] and traceable back to the original text. Every figure and case in the book is sourced in Appendix A.

This is not a book written all at once. It is a "living book"—the material keeps accumulating, and the edition keeps growing. If you find something incomplete in one edition, chances are the next update has already filled it in.

Who This Book Is For

It is written for three kinds of readers:

- **Practitioners in sales, customer success, and growth teams**—AI is changing how you work, and this book helps you see the full picture: which parts of the job AI will take over, and which skills will become more valuable;

- **Business operators**—you must decide how much AI to invest in customer operations, and how. The failure cases and ROI data in this book are closer to reality than any vendor sales demo;
- **Anyone curious about what people will do in the AI era**—customer operations is the best window for observing the division of labor between humans and machines, because every dollar here is tied to a real person.

The judgments in this book come from cross-validating the source material, and from my continued observation of this field. If you spot any errors or omissions, you are welcome to point them out (weokk2025@gmail.com).

Acknowledgments

The organization and public-release model of this book draw on the open-source practice behind *Frontline Deployment Engineer* by Fan Bing (Chinese: 范冰), better known as XDash — free public access to the full text, a GitHub repository plus website reading and PDF download, and sources cited in the appendix. Knowledge lives in movement, and this model deserves to be spread.

Chapter 1: Year One — From Klarna to "We Went Too Far"

1.1 From Klarna to "We Went Too Far"

On February 27, 2024, a Klarna press release swept across global tech media. The Swedish "buy now, pay later" company announced that in its first month, an AI assistant built on OpenAI technology had completed 2.3 million conversations, absorbing two-thirds of all customer-service chats—the workload of 700 full-time agents. Average time to resolve an issue dropped from 11 minutes to 2 minutes, customer satisfaction matched human agents, repeat inquiries fell by 25%, and profits were expected to improve by $40 million a year[5-28] [official claims].

This was the first time "AI customer service" had world-class benchmark data. Klarna's CEO Sebastian Siemiatkowski even said publicly that he wanted Klarna to be OpenAI's "favorite experimental subject."

If the story had stopped there, this book would need only one chapter: how impressive AI customer service is.

But the story did not stop. In 2025, Siemiatkowski admitted publicly: "Cost-driven evaluation led to a decline in service quality." The company rebuilt its human customer-service channels. By 2026, he said something even stronger to Bloomberg at the company's Stockholm headquarters: **"We went too far."** Klarna began hiring again—not agents to replace AI, but "around 100 highly skilled humans" to handle the situations AI cannot resolve, or resolves in ways customers do not accept[12-06] [third-party verified].

Two years, one company, from "AI covering 700 agents" to "we went too far." International media called it Klarna's "sharp U-turn on AI customer service."

How should we understand this U-turn? On three levels:

First, Klarna's AI customer service did not fail. To this day it still handles about 80% of customer-service chats—31 million conversations over the whole of 2025—the workload of more than 700 full-time agents[5-23] [third-party verified]. The cost savings are real.

Second, the "success" of AI customer service and "customer satisfaction" are not the same thing. AI can efficiently resolve procedural issues like "check my bill, change my address, ask about progress." But when customers hit complex, emotional situations that require judgment, the experience collapses in front of a bot that is always polite yet never truly understands you. It took Klarna two years to discover: **cutting costs and keeping customers are two separate ledgers.**

Third, and most important: Klarna's lesson is not that "AI doesn't work," but that "using AI as a cost-saving machine hurts customer operations itself." The right way to use AI is not to replace people, but to let humans and AI each do what they do best—and that is exactly what this book sets out to explain from beginning to end.

1.2 "Customer Management" Is Dying

Klarna's story is a microcosm. Behind it lies a larger paradigm shift: **"customer management" is becoming "customer operations."**

What is the difference between the two terms?

"Customer management" is a legacy of the industrial age. Its implicit assumption: the customer is an input to a process. Sales manages contracts, service manages complaints, marketing manages campaigns, finance manages collections—each department runs one small slice of the customer lifecycle, while customer information is scattered across the CRM, support tickets, and financial systems, and no one is truly accountable for "how much this customer is worth across their entire lifecycle." However well customer management is done, it only keeps customers "under control"—don't lose them, don't let them complain, don't let them default.

"Customer operations" rests on a different assumption: the customer is a source of assets. The operator's task is to make every customer keep generating value across the entire lifecycle—find the right customers, get them onboarded smoothly, serve them well, keep them around, get them to buy more, and get them to recommend others. This requires not just processes, but **continuous understanding** of customers and **proactive action** on their behalf.

AI makes "customer operations" scalable for the first time. Traditional customer management runs on people: one customer success manager can maintain dozens of customers, and one salesperson can follow up a few hundred leads—that is the ceiling of capacity. AI can analyze behavioral data from thousands of customers at once, spot patterns human teams cannot see, and automatically execute the right action at

every touchpoint[1-17] [third-party verified]. ZoomInfo's customer lifecycle management framework calls this a "cross-functional operating system"—unifying data and processes across marketing, sales, customer success, and product teams to scale fulfillment around key buyer personas [third-party verified].

The blunter version comes from the B2C world: Blueshift's lifecycle marketing guide did the math—acquiring a new customer can cost 5 to 25 times as much as retaining one, and a 5% improvement in retention can lift profits by 25% to 95%[1-06] [official claims]. Once AI can automate and scale the business of operating existing customers, customers are no longer merely managed—they are actively operated.

1.3 Data Can Lie: Three Truths About AI-Powered Customer Lifecycle Management

Before we get to the substance, let me put three easily misleading "truths" on the table. They come from cross-validating 398 pieces of source material, and from observing a great many failure cases.

Truth one: adoption of AI-powered customer lifecycle management is badly overestimated. Intercom surveyed 2,470 customer-service professionals worldwide: 82% of executives said they had invested in AI over the past 12 months, and 87% planned to keep investing in 2026—yet only 10% had reached "mature deployment" (AI deeply integrated into core operations and running at scale)[1-09] [official claims]. Between buying AI and using it well lies an enormous gap.

Truth two: vendor-reported ROI runs 30–40 percentage points above independent data. The 53 AI customer-service ROI studies compiled by Digital Applied show an average return of $3.50 for every $1 invested by vendors' own accounting, while independent benchmarks are markedly lower[5-04] [third-party verified]. It is not that all vendors are lying; rather, vendors tend to count "the volume of conversations AI handled," not "the improvement in customer satisfaction and retention."

Truth three: customers trust AI, but they trust people more. EY's Future Consumer Index survey of 21,000 respondents across 27 countries shows that consumers quickly adopt AI tools that save money and time while staying wary of AI—24% worry that AI will take their place[1-16] [third-party verified]. Metrigy's research is

more direct: 85% of consumers prefer interacting with a real person in customer service[11-15] [third-party verified]. The stronger AI gets, the scarcer—and the more valuable—the "human touch" becomes.

1.4 A Map of This Book

This book unfolds along the five stages of the customer lifecycle: **Acquisition → Conversion → Service → Retention → Expansion**. Each chapter answers one question:

- Chapter 2: the overall framework of AI-powered customer lifecycle management—the lifecycle model, the divide between AI-native and AI-assisted approaches, and when AI should not be used;
- Chapter 3: acquisition—how AI turns prospecting into capacity, and why AI outbound is killing cold email;
- Chapter 4: conversion—personalization, pricing, and conversational commerce: how AI is changing the business of "getting customers to pay";
- Chapter 5: service—AI customer-service platforms, human–AI collaboration, and the failure scenes;
- Chapter 6: retention and expansion—AI-powered customer success: churn prediction, health scores, and NDR;
- Chapter 7: the foundation—AI CRM and customer data: without data, everything else is empty talk;
- Chapter 8: organization—rebuilding the GTM, sales training, and the psychology of organizational change;
- Chapter 9: industries—a map of AI-powered customer lifecycle management across eleven industries;
- Chapter 10: the flip side—backlash, hallucination, compliance, and liability: the boundaries of AI-powered customer lifecycle management;
- Chapter 11: the future—when customers themselves become AI.

Every chapter follows the same writing discipline: **success stories and failure stories are told side by side.** In the field of AI-powered customer lifecycle management, failure cases often teach us more than success stories—and Klarna is the best example.

Chapter 2 The Customer Lifecycle and the AI Engine

2.1 The Five-Stage Model: The Master Framework of Customer Operations

The previous chapter said that "customer management is dying and customer operations are arriving." So what exactly does customer operations operate on? The answer is a five-stage framework:

Acquisition → Conversion → Service → Retention → Expansion

This framework is not a new invention. Blueshift's B2C lifecycle marketing guide frames it as five stages — "acquire, onboard, engage, retain, win back"[1-06][official claims]; monday.com's 2026 lifecycle marketing guide argues that the industry is shifting from "campaign-centric" to "customer-centric" — traditional marketing consists of isolated campaigns with start and end dates, whereas lifecycle marketing continuously delivers personalized messages according to the stage of the customer relationship, and the metrics shift from clicks and opens to customer lifetime value and retention growth[1-21][third-party verified].

Why does this framework suddenly become important in the AI era? Because AI turns every stage from "labor-intensive" into "scalable operations":

- **Acquisition**: an AI SDR can reach out to thousands of leads in a single day, something human salespeople cannot do;
- **Conversion**: AI-powered personalized recommendations can simultaneously serve millions of customers with different needs;
- **Service**: AI customer service can handle thousands of conversations at once;
- **Retention**: AI churn prediction can spot risk signals months before a customer leaves;
- **Expansion**: AI can identify upsell opportunities for each customer and push NDR (net dollar retention) higher.

Traditional customer management split these five stages across different departments, each looking only at its own segment. The first change AI-powered customer lifecycle management brings is **reconnecting the five stages into one continuous line** — because AI needs complete customer data to work, and once complete customer data starts flowing, the barriers between the five stages naturally break down. ZoomInfo calls this CLM (customer lifecycle management): systematically optimizing every touchpoint on the customer journey, like a cross-functional operating system that unifies marketing, sales, customer success, and product teams[1-17][third-party verified].

2.2 AI-native vs. AI-assisted: A Spectrum

Any discussion of AI-powered customer lifecycle management must confront a conceptual divide: **AI-native and AI-assisted**.

Nutshell uses an "AI spectrum" to explain why so many companies invest in AI yet see no results: only a minority of companies achieve measurable enterprise-level gains; most CRMs are merely "AI-assisted" — layering an AI tier on top of legacy systems; whereas AI-native embeds AI into the core database, workflows, and automation — AI is not a feature attached to the database but the architecture itself[1-05][third-party verified].

What is the difference? Take a concrete example. An AI-assisted CRM has salespeople manually entering customer information while AI prompts on the side, "this customer might be interested"; an AI-native CRM automatically captures every email, every call, every meeting, keeps records fresh on its own, and prepares for humans[1-12] "next actions pending approval" — AI does the work, people make the decisions[1-12][official claims].

This divide applies to the whole of customer operations:

Dimension	AI-assisted	AI-native
Where AI sits	Add-on feature	The architecture itself
Data	People enter it, AI analyzes	AI captures automatically, people review
Workflows	Existing processes + AI acceleration	Processes designed around AI

Dimension	AI-assisted	AI-native
Role of humans	Doers	Decision-makers/approvers
Typical outcome	15% adoption, "no results" at year-end review	Measurable metrics, running continuously

The "bought AI but got no results" cases that recur throughout this book are almost all products of the AI-assisted approach: tools purchased, training delivered, incentives given — yet the organizational structure, decision processes, and performance standards are all traditional, with AI merely pasted onto legacy systems.

There is a simple test for whether a customer operations system is AI-native: **if you were designing it from scratch tomorrow, would AI be written into the blueprint?** If the answer is no, it is just a band-aid.

2.3 Six Models of AI-native GTM

When customer operations takes AI as its architectural core, the way acquisition and revenue are done changes as well. A study of companies racing toward $100M in revenue summarizes six models of AI-native GTM[1-19][third-party verified]:

1. **AI-generated content for acquisition**: use AI to mass-produce high-quality content so search engines and AI search recommendations bring a steady stream of traffic. Jasper gained over 100,000 organic search visits in 18 months through programmatic content[3-24]; Zapier's programmatic SEO quadrupled its organic traffic[3-22][third-party verified].
2. **AI-powered personalization for conversion**: AI understands each visitor's intent in real time and delivers the right information at the right moment.
3. **Agentic sales**: AI agents autonomously handle outreach, follow-up, and booking, leaving only the final high-value step to humans.
4. **AI customer success**: AI proactively monitors customer health and intervenes before customers churn.
5. **AI pricing**: outcome-based pricing — customers pay for "work done" rather than "software seats."
6. **AI analytics for decisions**: AI synthesizes customer, pricing, competitive, and deal signals and directly recommends next actions.

What these six models share: **AI is not assisting humans in doing the same things as before — it changes the very way things are done**. EY-Parthenon's observation is sharper: agentic AI has dramatically increased the go-to-market complexity of SaaS companies, and "winners will be determined by the ability to reinvent business models, not by the size of sales teams"[1-14][third-party verified].

2.4 The Engine and the Foundation of Customer Operations

Combine the five-stage model with AI-native, and you get this book's organizing framework:

- **The engine**: acquisition, conversion, service, retention, expansion — what AI transforms each of the five stages into (Chapters 3–6);
- **The foundation**: AI CRM and customer data — the fuel for all the engines (Chapter 7);
- **The organization**: who drives these engines — GTM teams, sales training, and change management (Chapter 8);
- **The industries**: different industries configure their engines differently (Chapter 9);
- **The boundaries**: the engines' braking system — backlash, compliance, liability (Chapter 10);
- **The future**: when customers themselves become AI, the engines must be redesigned (Chapter 11).

2.5 When Not to Use AI

This section sits in the overview chapter because it is one of the most important judgments in this book: **the first step of AI-powered customer lifecycle management is not deciding where to use AI, but deciding where not to use it.**

In 2026, an interesting counter-trend emerged: a group of brands turned "we don't use AI" into their strongest selling point. "No AI" is becoming a new marketing label after "all natural," triggered by consumers' rising aversion to AI content and their growing ability to recognize it[1-01][third-party verified].

This is not anti-intellectualism — it is the market voting with its feet. Research draws clear boundary lines:

In high-trust scenarios, humans are irreplaceable. A survey Northwestern Mutual commissioned from Harris Poll shows that Americans trust human advisors significantly more than AI when making financial decisions[1-08][official claims]. Psychologists at Teachers College, Columbia University warn that AI's most popular use cases — emotional support and companionship — are precisely where AI's architecture is the least suited, because AI cannot truly empathize[1-07][third-party verified].

In luxury and experiential scenarios, AI should step back. McKinsey's luxury research (surveying 300 consumers and 90 merchants) finds that 85% of luxury consumers already use generative AI, but when it comes to purchase decisions, what they expect is "the human touch" — AI can assist, but cannot lead[1-10][third-party verified].

In emotional and complex scenarios, AI fails. Klarna is the lesson here: AI handles process problems efficiently, but when customers arrive emotionally charged, the more polite the bot, the more infuriating it becomes.

So where should AI be used? The answer: **repetitive, standardized, high-volume, low-emotion scenarios** — first-touch outreach, answering common questions, billing inquiries, process guidance, behavior analysis, and risk alerts. In one sentence: **AI handles scale and efficiency; humans handle trust and judgment**. IBM's thought-leadership article puts it more elegantly: AI is making customer service "more human" — because it leaves the complex cases that require emotional intelligence to people[1-18][third-party verified].

This boundary is not static. As AI capabilities improve, the boundary moves; but as customers' ability to recognize AI grows, the value of the "human touch" rises as well. The operator's task is not to draw the boundary once and for all, but to keep recalibrating it.

The next chapter begins the first stop of the five stages: acquisition.

Chapter 3 Acquisition: AI Turns Prospecting into Capacity

3.1 Artisan: The Company That Printed "Stop Hiring Humans" on a Billboard

In 2025, a series of billboards appeared on the streets of San Francisco — white background, black text, a single line: "Stop Hiring Humans." They were signed by a startup called Artisan, whose product is Ava, an AI sales agent that automatically finds prospects, researches leads, writes personalized emails, follows up, and books meetings — reportedly at one-fifth the cost of a human BDR (business development representative), with more than 300 million verified B2B contacts built in[3-15][official claims].

The company later raised a $25 million Series A. Business Insider exclusively reported on its fundraising materials — which promised not "sales assistance" but "replacing human sales with AI"[3-14][third-party verified].

The other side of the story is equally telling. In late 2025, Artisan's AI SDR, Ava, was banned from LinkedIn — because its automated way of contacting prospects violated the platform's rules. CEO Jaspar Carmichael-Jack confirmed the ban to TechCrunch; the account was restored two weeks later[3-44][third-party verified]. Around the same time, the founder publicly admitted that early versions of the product had hallucination problems and that the company had gone through customer churn[12-16][third-party verified].

A company built on "stop hiring humans" — banned by a platform, disciplined by customer churn — and then it came back. That complexity is an accurate portrait of AI-driven acquisition as a field: **the efficiency is real, and so is the backlash.**

3.2 AI SDR: From Tool to Digital Employee

First, consider the size of the market. The AI SDR (sales development representative) category was worth roughly $4.27 billion in 2025 and is projected to reach $18.19 billion by 2032 (a 23% compound annual growth rate); over the past two years, venture capital has poured more than $1 billion into AI SDR startups[3-07][third-party verified].

Product forms have already evolved through two generations:

The first generation is "assistive tools": they help human SDRs write emails, find leads, and prioritize — the human remains the lead actor.

The second generation is "digital employees": 11x's product line is the most representative — Alice (email + LinkedIn outreach), Julian (phone agent), and other "digital employees" hold their own phone numbers and, 24/7 with no human supervision, make calls, answer calls, screen leads, and book meetings, automatically writing call data back to the CRM[3-38][official claims]. Artisan's Ava covers the full flow of "lead research → personalized email → follow-up sequences"[official claims]. AiSDR's own ROI calculation is more direct: an AI SDR subscription costs about 85% less than hiring an in-house SDR, with similar output[3-12][official claims].

Both capital and vendors are telling a story of "replacement." But independent data gives a more complicated answer.

3.3 AI vs. Human SDRs: What the Head-to-Head Data Says

Salesmotion's aggregation of adversarial head-to-head tests offers a rare direct comparison[third-party verified]:

- **Revenue**: human SDRs generated 2.6x the revenue of AI SDRs[3-06] ($147,000 vs. $56,000);
- **Meeting show-up rate**: humans 71%, AI 52%;
- **Cost**: a human SDR's fully loaded cost is $100,000–150,000 per year; an AI SDR license costs roughly $30,000 per year.

AI delivers volume hundreds of times greater than humans; humans deliver quality two to three times higher than AI. When the full math is done, the conclusion is not "who replaces whom" but a division of labor: **AI owns breadth and first-touch outreach; humans own high-value conversion and complex relationships.**

This conclusion is corroborated at a grander level. Sequoia Capital's investment thesis — "services as the new software" — argues: if you sell tools (software), you are racing against the models; if you sell the work itself (service outcomes), every model upgrade makes your service faster and cheaper[3-45][third-party verified]. Harvard Business Review defines agentic AI as a paradigm-level variable in sales: it makes a "perfect replica of the top salesperson" possible — autonomous agents unconstrained by time or geography, working side by side with human sellers[3-42][third-party verified].

Note HBR's wording: **working side by side**, not replacing. The mainstream of 2026 is not "AI replaces salespeople" but a hybrid model of "AI sales + human sales" — Chapter 8 will present more detailed ROI data from controlled experiments on this model.

Chinese exporters offer a striking counterpoint. Jintai Technology (Chinese: 今泰科技), a Guangzhou company that applies superhard film coatings to metal surfaces, once sent 80,000 cold emails to overseas buyers in a single burst, almost all of which sank without a response. After adopting a sales agent from Tungee (Chinese: 探迹科技), salespeople only enter product information and target markets, and the agent finds buyers worldwide, drafts the outreach emails, and follows up across time zones; within three months its number of inbound inquiries equaled the total acquired over the previous three years, email reply rates rose at least tenfold, and it broke into the Western tableware industry that had long resisted its approach[3-80][third-party verified]. Same channel, same email — output differed by three orders of magnitude. The difference was not volume but the data layer: the quality of buyer profiling and filtering determines the efficiency of every step that follows.

3.4 Content Acquisition: AI Turns "Writing" into "Manufacturing"

If AI SDR is proactive outreach, content acquisition is building a nest to attract the phoenix. The killer weapon of AI content acquisition is **programmatic SEO**: use AI to mass-produce pages targeting long-tail keywords, so search engines deliver a steady stream of precise traffic.

Three frequently cited cases:

Zapier: monthly visits grew from roughly 1.19 million in November 2020 to roughly 4.8 million in November 2023, an increase of more than 300% in three years. Its core assets are more than 6 million backlinks and tens of thousands of automation tutorial pages on "how to connect A to B"[3-22][third-party verified].

Jasper: in 2021, this AI writing company had 14 employees in total — and just one in marketing. It outsourced its "content growth engine" to a specialist agency, and the result was 810% growth in organic blog traffic, 400x growth in blog-driven signups, and $4 million in ARR[3-24][third-party verified].

An AI image-generation SaaS: previously 67 signups a month and 13 ranking keywords. After a programmatic SEO overhaul, monthly signups climbed from 67 to more than 2,100 within 10 months, and organic traffic grew 3,035%[3-28][third-party verified].

By 2026, the content acquisition battlefield has expanded from "search engines" to "AI search." GEO (generative engine optimization) has become a new term: optimize your brand content so it appears in the output of ChatGPT, Google AI Overviews, and Perplexity — the goal is to become the source an AI cites when it answers a user's question[3-19][third-party verified]. Glasp pushes the practice further: this tool with 3.5 million users grew traffic from ChatGPT from 500 sessions a day to 19,000 — not by guessing how AI thinks, but by reading its own server logs to see directly which pages ChatGPT visited and cited[3-51][third-party verified]. In the AI era, content acquisition is shifting from "guessing the algorithm" to "observing the AI."

3.5 ABM × AI: Treating Every Key Account as Its Own Market

The logic of ABM (account-based marketing) is: don't cast a wide net — lock onto a small number of high-value target accounts and run each one like its own "market."

AI makes ABM scalable for the first time. Demandbase divides AI's capabilities into three layers: NLP that reads unstructured data from web pages, search, and social media for intent monitoring; generative AI that automatically produces personalized content for each account; and predictive models that rank accounts[3-10][official claims]. 6sense's platform uses predictive analytics and intent data to help companies discover and rank target accounts that are "entering their buying window"[3-05][third-party verified].

Key data supports this direction: roughly 70% of the B2B buying journey is completed anonymously before buyers ever contact a vendor[3-34][official claims] — they research, compare, and read reviews online first, and by the time a salesperson reaches out, half the decision is already made. The value of intent data is turning that "invisible shopping" into observable signals: whoever is intensively researching a category is a buyer in the market at this moment.

Chinese practice is keeping pace. SalesDriver's white paper shows that about 26.48% of companies have rolled out ABM, up 149% from the prior year[3-30][third-party verified]. SANY (Chinese: 三一重工) is a sample from large-scale B2B manufacturing: in 2022, its overseas revenue grew 47% and accounted for 45% of total revenue, while revenue from developed markets in Europe and the Americas reached roughly RMB 15.8 billion, up 86% year over year[3-40][third-party verified] — its playbook is not internet-style traffic operations but running target customers as "key accounts," supported by coordinated channel and content work (strictly speaking, not textbook ABM, but aligned in direction).

3.6 Private Domain: An AI Battleground Unique to the Chinese Market

If ABM is the Western B2B playbook, the private domain (Chinese: 私域) is China's own customer-operations battleground — adding customers to WeChat or WeCom (Chinese: 企业微信) and repeatedly reaching out to, nurturing, and converting them there.

The biggest pain point of the private domain is "added, then silent": large numbers of new contacts stop interacting within two weeks of being added. NetEase Zhiqi's (Chinese: 网易智企) diagnosis is sharp — the causes fall into two categories: silent contacts (never responded) and dormant old customers (bought before but inactive recently) — while blanket group broadcasts fail because of message folding, do-not-disturb settings, and mismatched content[3-41][official claims]. AI's solution is "segment people first, then match content": a three-layer filter (basic attributes, behavioral traces, relationship stage) divides contacts into tiers, and each tier is paired with a different AI outreach strategy[3-47][official claims].

Effect data comes from Shuyun (Chinese: 数云): during the 618 shopping festival, a well-known personal care brand's private-domain traffic pool surged beyond its reception capacity; after AI digital employees took over, the new-customer reception

rate rose 140%, the conversion rate rose 29.2%, and labor costs fell 61.3%[3-43][official claims]. Tencent Qidian (Chinese: 腾讯企点) serves more than 1 million enterprises and connects 350 million users, embedding large models into its marketing cloud and intelligent customer service[3-46][third-party verified].

3.7 Paid Media: AI Turns Budgets into Algorithms

Traditional paid media relies on manual bid adjustment and trial and error. AI-powered ad products turn this into an algorithmic problem: with Meta's Advantage+ campaigns, CPA (cost per acquisition) fell 12–17%, reaching 32% in some cases[3-27] [third-party verified]; one Google Performance Max campaign automatically runs across Search, YouTube, Display, and Gmail[3-20][third-party verified].

At the budget-allocation level, the 2026 consensus is that MTA (multi-touch attribution) and MMM (marketing mix modeling) must run in parallel: MTA answers the tactical question — "which channel converted my customers" — while MMM answers the strategic one — "how the overall budget should be split"[3-26][third-party verified]. Causal-AI versions of MMM go further: after causaLens helped a large consumer app company rebuild its attribution model, its annual marketing budget fell 5% and ROI reached 15x[3-36][official claims].

3.8 The Backlash: AI Outbound Is Killing Cold Email

At this point in Chapter 3, we have to pause to cover the flip side — because the biggest risk in AI-driven acquisition is not that AI is too weak, but that AI is too easily abused, and abuse can destroy the entire channel.

The data is alarming. A cohort study of 14 B2B SaaS sales organizations found that reply rates to AI SDR outreach decayed by more than 60% within 18 months — from 11.2% at launch down to 4.4% by month 18 — because recipients gradually learned to recognize the structure of AI templates[3-32][third-party verified]. The cold email ecosystem as a whole is worse off: 95% of cold emails now get zero replies at all; when personalization is traded for speed and volume, reply rates run 13x lower than normal[3-39][third-party verified]. Cold call reply rates fell from 8.5% in 2018 to 4.2% in 2022[official claims].

The Pipeline Group's warning is harsher: running outbound sales at scale with AI SDRs is dragging companies into a state that is "illegal, unethical, and brand-destroying" — AI SDRs often use scraped data obtained without consent, crossing compliance red lines such as GDPR and CCPA[3-09][official claims].

Hence a paradox that emerged in 2026: **AI has driven the cost of proactive outreach toward zero, and it has also driven the value of proactive outreach toward zero.** When everyone can send ten thousand emails with AI, recipients learn to ignore all emails. The first users consumed the channel's dividend; the imitators who followed only ate the backlash.

That explains why the acquisition consensus in 2026 is turning toward "relationship-driven": rather than casting a wide net with AI, use AI to precisely identify "who is in the market right now" (intent data), then reach them in a high-quality, personalized way. The second half of AI-driven acquisition is a contest of restraint, not intensity.

The mechanism of that backlash went one level deeper in 2026: detection no longer depends on a recipient's impression but on detectable watermarks and platform rules. Anthropic's Claude now embeds invisible watermarks in all generated text (a global change driven by European Union regulatory requirements), which means AI-drafted sales emails can be identified as machine-generated; at the same time, fully AI-generated cold emails receive fewer replies and are flagged as spam at a higher rate[3-78][third-party verified]. Anti-AI outreach has moved from "a person can tell something is off" to "a system can measure it."

One practitioner's account puts a number on the slope: he spent more than 400 hours building his own AI SDR for cold-email prospecting and ultimately lifted reply rates only from 1% to 2%, while spending the same effort on phone outreach produced five times more pipeline, at a cost far below those 400 hours. The industry's average email reply rate fell from 8.5% in 2019 to 3.4% in 2026 — AI accelerated that decline because it lets everyone, including your competitors, pour more volume into the same inbox, while buyers, Gmail, and Outlook all learned to filter. The constraint on the phone side is a hard constraint: connect rates have long hovered at 3–5%, and statistics across billions of dials show that only about 20% of people in any market will answer a cold call, while the other 80% never will regardless of how, from what number, or at what hour you call — the AI SDR inherited this constraint rather than solving it[3-79][third-party verified].

3.9 The AI-ization of Advertising and the Truthfulness of Traffic

Section 3.7 described how AI turns ad budgets into algorithms. Since then, two new shifts have appeared in this channel: the entry points are migrating, and the credibility of measurement is weakening.

Migrating entry points. In September 2026, Amazon and OpenAI struck a partnership: advertisers can extend campaigns through Amazon's DSP (demand-side platform) into ChatGPT's conversational ad slots, which surface as text and image units beneath the answers with clearly marked "sponsored" labels; the pilot is limited to the U.S. at launch, and Delta Vacations is among the first brands. ChatGPT Ads has been live for a little over half a year and has reached a $1 billion annualized revenue run rate, with tens of thousands of advertisers using it[3-52] [third-party verified]. When "conversation" itself becomes ad inventory, the AI assistant stops being a "substitute for search" and becomes "a new medium" — acquisition entry points are no longer just search engines and social platforms, but also the conversation between a brand and an AI assistant.

Conversion quality. The new entry point's traffic quality is documented: Semrush's search research found that users arriving via AI-generated answers convert 4.4 times better than those arriving from traditional search results[3-53] [third-party verified]. The intent is clearer — the user has already walked to the last step of the decision, and the AI merely walks them to the door.

But the foundation of measurement is loosening. An indie developer ran a Google app-install campaign for his puzzle app and was billed for 56 installs in two weeks; going back through the raw panel data, 33 of them showed the same "bot pattern" — an old app version the store had stopped serving, a single open per device, zero seconds on any screen, and 28 phone models across 19 states[3-54] [third-party verified]. The loop is the ironic part: Google optimizes for whatever goal the advertiser sets, and "a view followed by an install" counts as a conversion, so the more the farm "installed" the app, the more budget the algorithm sent the farm's way, and the spend was systematically fed to bots. His fix was to change the campaign goal from "opened the app" to "won a puzzle" — making faking more expensive than genuinely playing.

For the acquisition stage of AI-powered customer lifecycle management, the lesson is valuable: when a channel's raw metric can be forged by machines, **the objective function must land on deep behaviors that only real customers produce**. Entry points can go AI-native; measurement cannot be lazy.

3.10 Entry Points: In the Chinese Market, the Search Box Is Turning into a Dialogue Box

The previous sections described the migration of entry points in the English-speaking world. The Chinese path is different — no single search company dominates it, and the redistribution of entry points is happening simultaneously across three lines: super apps, standalone AI apps, and the browser layer.

WeChat: a first-class entry point. WeChat is testing an upgrade that promotes AI search from a second-level feature to a first-class entry point: tapping the search box at the top of the app invokes AI search, with an optional "deep thinking" mode and support for uploading images or files, plus a separate "Ask Yuanbao (Chinese: 元宝)" entry that routes users to Tencent's native AI app. Deep-thinking queries default to the DeepSeek R1 model, image search to the Hunyuan T1 model. Tencent's official line is that search is continuously improving its AI capabilities and the feature remains in gray-scale testing[3-55] [third-party verified]. The three Chinese giants are effectively running the same play — retrofit the super app with AI while funneling users toward a standalone AI app: Tencent pairs WeChat with Yuanbao, ByteDance pairs Douyin (Chinese: 抖音) with Doubao (Chinese: 豆包), and Baidu pairs its mobile app with Wenxiaoyan.

Browsers: making AI the system layer. In November 2025, Qwen (Chinese: 千问) was deeply integrated with a new version of the Quark (Chinese: 夸克) AI browser; Qwen no longer exists as a plug-in but is embedded as the interface's foundation, callable directly from the home-page search box and the sidebar and pinnable as a desktop companion. Quark's AI browser has reached 110 million installs on PCs, and the Qwen app passed 10 million downloads within a week of its public beta[3-56] [third-party verified]. IDC projects that by 2028 annual shipments of AI-capable PCs in China will be 60 times the 2024 figure. What matters here is not a "smarter search box" but screen reading, text selection, and screenshot capture — AI entering the price-comparison and purchase decisions a user is making right now.

Why entry points get reassigned. In March 2025 Alibaba promoted Quark to an "AI super box" and designated it the company's flagship AI application; the team later concluded that a conversational assistant was the better form factor, and resources and narrative shifted to Qwen. The arithmetic behind that decision is user scale: QuestMobile data for September 2025 put Doubao at 172 million monthly active users, DeepSeek at 145 million, and Tencent Yuanbao at 32.86 million, while Tongyi ranked only tenth at 3.06 million[3-57] [third-party verified]. Content, social, and search are held by ByteDance, Tencent, and Baidu respectively; what Alibaba lacked was exactly a traffic entry point — hence the conclusion that it "must have an AI-native consumer super entry point."

In-platform search is becoming a primary battlefield too. Douyin's e-commerce arm states officially that 80% of its monthly active users initiate searches and search an average of 100 times per month; daily e-commerce search users reach 140 million with close to 500 million daily search page views, and the conversion efficiency of searched products is 90% higher than in other scenarios[3-58] [official claims]. A frontline operator describes an even more thorough algorithmic shift: 47% of Douyin users proactively initiate decision-oriented searches, proactive search page views grew 36% year over year and search GMV grew 55%, the weight of short-video algorithm signals in search ranking jumped from 35% to 61%, and the useful life of a keyword strategy compressed from three to six months down to two to four weeks[3-59] [third-party verified]. Content format directly determines recall: a smart-glasses category that rewrote technical specs as scenario-based expressions lifted search conversion by 91%, and an outdoor brand that broke product descriptions into five-second scene clips quadrupled click-through.

For acquisition, the first question has therefore changed: not "where do my keywords rank" but "in which interface will my customer ask their question." A search box, a dialogue box, and a browser's screen-reading layer are three different sets of content and data requirements.

Zoom out one more step and a more easily overlooked fact appears: in China, one of the largest entry points for "AI search" is not a standalone app but the search-box upgrade inside a super app. QuestMobile data shows WeChat's AI search reached 160 million monthly active users in June 2025, more than native AI apps such as Doubao and Yuanbao, though still below Baidu and Douyin[3-81][third-party verified]. Users need neither to install a new app nor to change their habits — the AI capability is placed

inside an existing high-frequency action, which means that watching only the MAU rankings of standalone AI apps systematically underestimates the real reach of AI embedded in super apps.

3.11 AI Visibility: A Second Report Card Beyond Rankings

If customers ask their questions inside a dialogue box, then "ranking" is no longer a complete report card. In 2026 an entirely new set of metrics appeared: whether a brand is named in an AI answer, and who was cited when it was named.

The volume is still small, but the direction is clear. Conductor's 2026 AEO/GEO Benchmarks Report puts AI referral traffic at just over 1% of total website visits, growing by roughly one percentage point per month on average; its value lies not in traffic volume but in the signal that a brand made it into an AI answer — what the report calls a "parallel surface of visibility," where discovery now happens before a user reaches the website at all[3-60] [third-party verified].

Who gets cited? Peec AI's analysis of 30 million sources found Reddit to be the most-cited domain across ChatGPT, Google AI Mode, Gemini, Perplexity, and AI Overviews, followed by YouTube, LinkedIn, Wikipedia, and Forbes; review platforms such as Yelp and G2 appear frequently in "best X" recommendation queries. The same research quantifies the filter: only 15% of pages ChatGPT retrieves appear in the final answer, and 44% of citations come from the first third of the body text[3-61] [third-party verified]. 5W's citation source audit puts platform divergence even more starkly: only about 11% of domains are cited by both ChatGPT and Perplexity, so a single content strategy cannot span the AI surfaces; Wikipedia accounts for roughly 47.9% of ChatGPT's top-ten source share while Reddit accounts for about 46.7% of Perplexity's; YouTube correlates with AI visibility at 0.737, the strongest single predictor in the 2025–2026 studies; and LinkedIn moved from eleventh to fifth place in ChatGPT within three months[3-62] [third-party verified].

The technical barrier matters more than the content barrier. After analyzing more than a million citations, OtterlyAI found that brands' own domains account for 52.5% of all citations, with the rest flowing to news sites (20.3%) and community forums (5.9%). The most actionable finding: 73% of websites block AI crawlers somewhere — in robots.txt, CDN rules, or JavaScript rendering[3-63] [third-

party verified]. In other words, many brands are eliminated at the crawling stage before citation ever becomes possible — fixing crawlability outranks writing more content.

This is still a discipline in trial and error. Two GEO experiments logged by Search Engine Land, covering 775 citation events in total, concluded that "who mentions you" may matter more than "what you write" in determining whether AI recommends you: the operational focus shifts from optimizing your own content to getting third-party sources — reviews, directories, forums, media — to mention you on the relevant topics. The author also admits an important caveat: a conclusion from the first experiment did not survive in the second, showing how easily a single GEO experiment mistakes platform noise for causal law and that findings require cross-platform, cross-cycle replication[3-64] [third-party verified].

A methodology has already taken shape in the Chinese market. The core judgment of the ifenxi (Chinese: 爱分析) 2026 China GEO Market Research Report is that GEO is not a continuation of SEO — SEO optimizes search ranking while GEO optimizes AI cognition, and the chain changes from "search → impression → click → conversion" to "user intent → AI cognition → AI recommendation → user decision," with a ranking algorithm as one arbiter and a model's understanding and reasoning as the other. The same research points to brands' real dilemma: marketing teams want to use existing CDP data for GEO, but CDP data is largely accumulated by ad platforms and covers only existing customers, missing the new cognition that forms in AI scenarios[3-65] [third-party verified]. That is why GEO deployment forces a data-layer rebuild rather than remaining a content outsourcing service.

3.12 Agentish: The Boundary of Autonomous Prospecting

The entry points changed and the metrics changed, but one thing did not: buyer intent does not become readable just because AI can watch for it around the clock.

The first reason for skepticism is the signal itself. Forrester lists seven reasons to be skeptical of agentic prospecting; the first and most fundamental is that autonomous prospecting assumes a quality of signal that does not exist. Web visits, content consumption, hiring signals, and keyword activity may indicate "interest" but rarely indicate "intent" reliably; intent is actually shaped by internal politics, budget timing, risk appetite, and hidden stakeholders — factors far beyond what any external signal stream can consistently capture[3-66] [third-party verified]. This does not deny

AI's value in outbound (filtering, research, timing prompts), but it does mean an agent's ability to execute should not be treated as evidence that a customer has a need.

"Agentish" is a usable design standard. The same firm offers a taxonomy: agentish means AI assists, suggests, and executes inside explicit workflows, guardrails, and approval thresholds, with humans still accountable for intent, outcomes, and risk; agentic means the system can set its own goals, change strategy, and execute end to end. The author's judgment is that most revenue technology platforms today are agentish, and that this is a deliberate design choice — in domains where revenue, compliance, and trust cannot be gambled on trial and error, each additional level of autonomy also complicates explainability and the chain of accountability[3-67] [third-party verified]. Written into procurement and architecture standards, it becomes one sentence: keep human accountability and approval thresholds for forecasting, qualification, quoting, and customer promises; reserve autonomous execution for low-risk, reversible, measurable actions.

Inside the boundary, scale can be enormous. The sample Siemens and Salesforce announced at Dreamforce is "AI handles all inbound" rather than "AI handles some leads": Agentforce qualifies every inbound lead for Siemens' 18,000 sellers, service engineers can identify the correct spare part by serial number before the first site visit, and sales reps can only quote technically valid upgrade options[3-68] [official claims]. The vendor calls this agent-to-agent AI, but the more useful takeaway is its view of where differentiation comes from: an industrial company's advantage is not replying faster but replying with engineering-correct content — making the product and configuration knowledge base the backend constraint on the agent is the precondition for this kind of scale.

3.13 "AI Visibility" Has Grown a Dashboard — and a Price Tag

The judgment in Section 3.11 was priced by the capital markets within a few months. Profound, an AI search visibility company barely 18 months old, raised a $96 million Series C at a $1 billion valuation, led by Lightspeed Venture Partners with Sequoia Capital and Kleiner Perkins following on, bringing total funding to $155 million; its product traces how AI models describe and recommend brands across millions of real prompts, answering not only "did I show up" but "why did I show up"

and "what are competitors doing differently"[3-69][third-party verified]. Whether a channel link genuinely exists is a question the capital markets often answer more directly than industry white papers.

Measurement is being formalized. A critical survey of GEO covering 2023–2026 formalizes the goal as "the presence, likelihood of citation, or influence of content in the answers produced by generative engines," treating citation probability and influence as two distinct optimization objectives rather than a single ranking[3-70] [third-party verified]. The implication is clear: AI visibility is not mystical exposure but an engineering problem with an objective function.

But the dashboard's readings are wildly unstable. Semrush's weekly snapshots of 130,000 prompts over 13 weeks show that around mid-September 2025, ChatGPT's citations of Reddit plunged from about 60% of responses to about 10%, while Wikipedia fell from about 55% to under 20%; over the same window, Google AI Mode's and Perplexity's citations of both were essentially stable[3-71][third-party verified]. Platform tastes differ just as sharply: AI Mode's top cited domains are almost entirely Google-owned or deeply partnered assets (LinkedIn, YouTube, Reddit), while ChatGPT's winners that round were PRNewswire, Forbes, and Medium. The conclusion for spend is direct — **a single-point snapshot of visibility cannot serve as the basis for channel budget; trend monitoring is mandatory, along with accepting that "the same asset has entirely different value in different engines."**

The fuel that actually gets cited is third-party evidence. After analyzing more than 25 million citation links across ChatGPT, Claude, and Gemini in 17 industries, Muck Rack found that earned media — press coverage, academic research, government and institutional sources — accounts for 84% of all AI citations, paid and sponsored content for only 0.3%, and news alone for 27% of cited sources; the share held stable between 82% and 89% across three versions[3-72][third-party verified]. Platform differences are just as pronounced: ChatGPT cites in 96% of responses but averages only five citations, Gemini cites in 82% of responses averaging eight, and Claude is the pickiest — citing in only 55% of responses but averaging 13 citations when it does; their most-cited domains are Wikipedia, PubMed Central, and Reddit respectively. **One set of copy cannot serve all three; choosing the platform matters more than choosing the keyword.**

Demand is shifting in step. G2's survey of 1,076 B2B software buyers and decision-makers found that 51% now "start research from an AI chatbot more often," up from 29% eleven months earlier; 71% rely on AI chatbots for at least one stage of the research process; and 85% rate a vendor more highly when that vendor appears in AI answers[3-73][third-party verified]. G2 frames this as buyers' starting point moving from reference to inference — no longer asking the chatbot for directions, but letting it synthesize the shortlist directly, which means AI answers determine who makes the shortlist at all.

And preferences form even earlier. Forrester points out that most B2B buying journeys are not "selection" but "confirmation": more than two-thirds (68%) of buyers already have a preferred vendor when they begin procurement, so intent signals about "who is in market" alone are insufficient to win deals — the state of preference and the path by which it forms (who shapes it through which information sources) are the key variables[3-74][third-party verified]. That is why investment in AI visibility has to be front-loaded before buyers start buying — by the time the intent signal fires, the room to choose has already narrowed.

Finally, AI entry points bring more than incremental traffic. A randomized field experiment with 1,100 U.S. Chrome users found that those forced onto Google AI Mode sent 18.8 percentage points fewer searches to external websites than they did in normal use, running 0.92 fewer search sessions per day; by category, the share of users clicking through to news sites fell 12.5 percentage points, to Reddit 21.2 points, and to Wikipedia 9.9 points — and this diversion did not produce any gain in search satisfaction[3-75][third-party verified]. This is the closest thing to causal evidence available: **brands cannot shift budgets on the single vector of "AI traffic is growing" without also counting how much of their traditional search asset was cut away — on the same sheet.**

3.14 Two Falsifications of New Channels: Agent Stores and GEO Franchising

The most common failure mode of a new channel is not "it doesn't work" but "its effect cannot be verified, yet someone is already making money from it."

The first falsification is that the channel itself does not hold up. In July 2026, Doubao, Qwen, and Yuanbao almost simultaneously shut down their user-built agent marketplaces. The postmortems produced ugly numbers: Doubao's marketplace

had accumulated roughly 8 million user-built agents and sat on about 200 million daily active users, but cost 130–240 million yuan per day against less than 1 million yuan of daily revenue; Yuanbao had about 9 million DAU after Tencent spent roughly 15 billion yuan on marketing, with extremely low retention. Overseas comparators are no brighter: of roughly 3 million GPTs created, only about 159,000 are public and active, median creator income is $0–100 per month, and the revenue-share formula remains unclear; Microsoft shut down Copilot GPTs less than three months after launch. Two causes stand out. First, user-built agents are essentially content generators, and the review burden shifts from reviewing one article at a time to reviewing all of its conversation paths, turning cost from O(N) into M×K^L — a one-time pre-launch review cannot, in principle, stop the risk. Second, creator revenue share is a cost line in the platform's revenue structure and per-user monetization ceilings sit below one dollar per month, so the business model was never viable[3-76][third-party verified]. The viable paths identified were three different businesses: consumer subscription companionship, open source plus B2B PaaS, and enterprise-internal agent marketplaces. The acquisition implication is direct — **a low barrier to creation floods supply, and a platform without curation capability equals zero distribution**; agents as an entry point are more likely to succeed as "enterprise utility agents with in-ecosystem distribution" than as a UGC marketplace revenue-share model.

The second falsification is that the channel matured as a franchise scheme before it matured as a service. GEO vendors have turned the business into recruiting city agents: heavy franchise advertising on Douyin, Xiaohongshu, and WeChat Moments, pulling the existing client bases of tax advisory, advertising, and business-services firms into GEO distribution. The pitch is usually "zero franchise fee," but initial inventory purchases, compute prepayments, system fees, deposits, and back-end packages ensure that something collects the money; one vendor quotes city-exclusive agent status at 50,000 yuan of initial inventory, with 50%–70% commissions and a self-claimed payback in two to three months. The real problem is a supply-demand mismatch: GEO genuinely suits businesses with an established brand, users who really do ask AI questions, and the capacity to keep producing credible content over time (national consumer brands, high-ticket B2B, large manufacturers, brands dependent on tendering or channel recruitment), whereas regional agents most easily reach restaurants, renovation firms, training schools, and small workshops

— **even if a vendor's ten designed questions show 100% mention rates, that does not mean any meaningful number of consumers actually asked them**[3-77][third-party verified].

Together, the two falsifications suggest a crude way to judge channel maturity: **look at whether the money in a channel flows mainly toward "creating results for customers" or toward "selling systems to channel partners."** When the latter dominates, the channel is still in its bubble phase, and the noise outweighs the signal.

3.15 The Methodology of AI Visibility: A Single Snapshot Will Lie

The readings in Section 3.13 (ChatGPT's citations of Reddit plunging from about 60% to about 10% within weeks) make one thing clear: **AI visibility is not a quantity that can be "measured once."** Through the second half of 2026, several mutually corroborating studies emerged on how to measure it so the result doesn't expire.

First, "when it expires" has been quantified. AirOps, with Kevin Indig, in The 2026 State of AI Search uses millions of data points to produce stability figures: only 30% of brands stay visible in two adjacent answers, and only 20% appear five times in a row; pages not updated quarterly are 3x more likely to lose AI citations, while pages using sequential headings and rich schema are 2.8x more likely to be cited; about 48% of citations come from community platforms such as Reddit and YouTube, and 85% of brand mentions come from third-party pages rather than a brand's own domain[3-82][third-party verified]. The same report notes that about 60% of Google AI Overview citations come from URLs that never entered the natural-search top 20 — **AI citation is a second channel that can bypass traditional ranking.**

Second, "how many times to measure" now has an academic answer. Researchers at the University of St. Gallen tracked four industry events across a 45–46 day window from January to March 2026 and found that the Jaccard similarity of cited sources on adjacent days was only 0.34–0.42 — roughly 65% of cited sources turn over on an average day — with even lower RBO scores (0.21–0.26). The authors note that in the traditional search era vendors offered transparent, stable snapshots through native tools such as Search Console, whereas LLM vendors currently provide no equivalent monitoring tool, creating an "observability gap": measuring GEO

performance requires repeated sampling rather than a single snapshot[3-83][third-party verified]. This turns sampling frequency and statistical significance from a methodology debate into a procurement standard.

Third, a map of citation sources. In its Q1 2026 Citation Source Audit, which combines nine independent studies, PR firm 5W finds that Wikipedia (13.15%) and Reddit (11.97%) together account for more than 25% of U.S. ChatGPT citations; The Wall Street Journal, The New York Times, Bloomberg, and the FT all fall outside the top 20, Forbes is the only U.S. business outlet to make the list (No. 18, 1.38%), YouTube's correlation with AI visibility is 0.737 — the single strongest predictor in 2025–2026 research — and LinkedIn rose within three months from No. 11 to No. 5 in ChatGPT, at a 14.3% citation rate[3-84][third-party verified]. Its conclusion: "AI engines don't rank authorities; they assemble answers" — traditional PR hierarchies and AI reality have come apart.

And that map is grown market by market. Profound's quarterly index (based on more than 190 million real user conversations across 50-plus industries) finds that only seven brands lead consistently across markets, with Toyota and McDonald's ranking first in every market where data is available, while other categories are largely led by local brands; in markets where a "new local leader" has emerged, 46%–59% of citations flow to domestic domains, versus 12–17 percentage points lower where no local leader exists — **translated content is not enough to raise AI visibility across borders**[3-85][official claims].

The traffic ledger already looks grim. Data cited by Onely shows that since mid-2024 organic click-through on queries with an AI Overview has fallen 61% (from 1.76% to 0.61%); when an AI summary appears, only 8% of users click a traditional result versus 15% when it does not (Pew Research, a 47% drop); about 60% of searches end with zero clicks, and Gartner predicts traditional search-engine search volume will fall 25% by 2026[3-86][third-party verified]. Put together, the operational takeaway is blunt: **before putting "AI visibility" into the budget, accept that it is a probability distribution rather than a ranking — it requires repeated sampling, market-by-market building, and simultaneous accounting for the loss of traditional search assets.**

3.16 Entry Points Re-Valued: Super-Apps Turn Services into Callable Atomic Capabilities

Section 3.10 described the Chinese search box turning into a dialogue box. This round's change is more foundational: WeChat and Alipay are rebuilding their "mini-programs and services" into atomic capabilities that AI can call directly, moving a brand's service from "waiting for someone to open it" to "being dispatched by AI."

Two technical paths. Reporters from 21st Century Business Herald tested Alipay's "Abao" and interviewed WeChat mini-program developers, describing two ways to break the wall. Alipay takes a dual-track approach — pushing mini-programs to encapsulate their functions as standardized AI skills shown as cards, while, with user authorization, having the AI read and operate mini-programs not yet converted. WeChat emphasizes voluntary developer authorization, adding an "AI capability" entry to its management console split into an "automatic mode" (developers authorize WeChat's AI to read pages and code) and a "development mode" (developers encapsulate functions and presentation themselves, subject to review before AI can call them); its developer documentation treats "atomic interfaces, atomic components, and Skills" as the three core units and sets call priority and anti-hallucination and privacy constraints (key fields must come from genuine upstream API returns, and sensitive information is masked)[3-87][third-party verified]. On scale, QuestMobile shows that in March 2026 WeChat, Alipay, and Douyin mini-programs had 973 million, 644 million, and 273 million monthly active users respectively, with WeChat in absolute dominance. The article also pours cold water: an insider at a leading lifestyle app says few people actually use it in lifestyle scenarios, and about 70% of the clients served by one developer abandon operating a mini-program after a few months, fearing that "if AI favors the big platforms, how will small and mid-sized merchants ever get a turn."

It is a near-simultaneous infrastructure push. Leiphone laid out a timeline of the two giants' moves from May to July 2026: Alipay launched a full-stack AI payments product in May, released the AI version of Alipay, "Abao," in June, and opened an AI platform on July 7 to merchants, institutions, service providers, smart terminals, and large-model platforms; in almost the same window, WeChat released AI-ecosystem access guidelines, introduced an AI-dedicated card, and began beta-testing its native assistant "Xiaowei." The article draws an analogy to QR-code payments a decade earlier — the two companies "rarely make such close moves around the same

underlying commercial interface in the same window of time." On payment protocols, Alipay released version 2.0 of its ACT protocol (Agentic Commerce Trust Protocol) in April, co-built by IIFAA with Alipay, Zhipu, and 20-plus other vendors, while WeChat gave AI "a card that is controllable, rechargeable, and spendable"[3-88][third-party verified]. For merchants, this may be a reshaping of "where business happens."

Merchants are already queuing to get connected. At its first AI ecosystem conference on August 17, Alipay disclosed that its super-service agent "Abao" has completed AI conversion of more than ten thousand services, supports five major phone brands and 16 major automakers across terminals, and launched a full-stack agentic-commerce foundation and a multi-agent cross-terminal interconnection protocol framework, the AHA protocol, co-built with Qwen, Huawei, OPPO, BYD, Geely and 20-plus other companies; Ant Group CEO Han Xinyi (Chinese: 韩歆毅) said "agentic commerce will break out in the next 6–12 months," and the president of Alipay's business group said that since the AI development platform launched in July, merchant requests have been so brisk that "some development demand is already scheduled into next year"[3-89][official claims]. Incentives for merchants include 100 million free tokens per person, payment-fee reductions, and token subsidies on real transactions, plus free access to 57 of Alipay's proprietary atomic operating capabilities — **one integration, with which "Abao" distributes the service to phones, car systems, AI glasses, and other terminals.**

A third-party startup is betting on "attributable AI channels." Science and Technology Daily reports on DeepLumen, a Chinese agentic-commerce startup whose product Agentic Page has been installed by more than 2,000 merchants across apparel, home, luggage, department stores, 3C digital, pets, and other categories, and which claims its merchants continuously generate "attributable orders from the AI channel," in the fastest cases closing a sale on day one. Its approach is to stop worrying about whether AI crawls or mentions the brand and instead reorganize product and brand information into structured content that AI can more easily understand and call, continuously syncing price and inventory; its deliverable is not "being understood by AI" but tracking the performance of orders that AI referrals bring into the merchant's site[3-90][third-party verified].

"The entry point is distribution" is the shared judgment this round. Securities Times calls 2026 the "year one of general AI entry points," starting with Alibaba's new Qwen app on January 15 fully integrating Taobao, Alipay, Fliggy, and Amap: Qwen competes for the "AI shopping agent entry point," Doubao for the "video-

and-entertainment agent entry point," and Yuanbao explores a "social agent entry point"; the analyst Tian Feng (Chinese: 田丰) judges that both traffic and tokens depend on "entry agents" dispatching orders, and that losing the next-generation entry point could let a giant decline quickly[3-91][third-party verified]. Scale data supports the direction: National Business Daily with QuestMobile's Q1 2026 AI App Value Ranking shows that as of March 2026 China's AI apps reached 446 million users overall, with the top five apps' combined monthly actives rising from 355 million to 722 million within half a year; Doubao led in Q1 with 345 million monthly actives (+44.2% quarter-on-quarter), Qwen rose to second with 166 million (+969.1%), and DeepSeek fell back to 127 million, declining for a fourth straight quarter[3-92][third-party verified].

Yet the economics of the same entry points are deteriorating. 36Kr's analysis of the content-commerce landscape after the new rules offers the other side: after China's first dedicated live-commerce rule, the Administrative Measures for the Supervision of Live-Streaming E-Commerce, took effect in February 2026, AIGC content such as digital-human streamers must be labeled and influencer product recommendations are classified as commercial advertising; Douyin's 2025 GMV was about 4.4 trillion yuan (2.75 times Kuaishou's), but growth has slowed to about 15–20%; **the average CPM of Juliang Qianchuan rose from 80 yuan in 2023 to 120 yuan in 2026, a 50% increase**[3-93][third-party verified]. As entry points increasingly resemble "AI dispatching," the unit cost of paid traffic rises in step — the two lines together are the real situation of customer acquisition in 2026.

3.17 The Third Reading on Zero-Click: Clicks Are Re-Allocated, Not Disappearing

Section 3.15 was about how a single snapshot lies. By mid-2026 the quantity itself had been re-measured three more times, and all three readings point the same way.

The first reading is the total. Using Similarweb's desktop and mobile panels for U.S. Google searches from January to April 2026, SparkToro calculates that 68.01% of queries end with zero clicks, versus 60.45% in the same period of 2024 — a rise of 7.5 percentage points in two years (+12.5%), the fastest acceleration in a decade (about 45% in 2016 and 49% in 2019). Mechanically, AI Overviews now appear on more than 20% of searches and cut click-through by nearly 60% where they do; the share of searches producing one click or more fell 9.51 percentage points over two years

(−22.9%), while the share of repeat searches rose 7.2 percentage points. One counterintuitive detail: only 0.34% of searches entered AI Mode in January–April 2026, so AI Overviews — not AI Mode — are behind this round of zero-click growth; the author reminds readers that search demand has not vanished, clicks have been re-allocated[3-94][third-party verified].

The second reading is a longitudinal site-side comparison. Define Media Group analysed Search Console data across its 64 sites: organic search clicks are down 42% since AI Overviews expanded. From Q1 2023 to Q1 2024 the sites averaged about 1.7 billion clicks per quarter; the moment AIO launched that fell 16% and never recovered, and the decline accelerated after AIO expanded further in May 2025. Crucially the losses are uneven — concentrated in informational and evergreen content, while AIO fires less often on news queries, leaving news and Discover relatively open: **channel decay is regressive rather than uniform, and how much you lose depends on your content type**[3-95][third-party verified].

The third reading is a page-level controlled comparison. Seer Interactive tracked 2.43 billion impressions, 53 brands, and 5.47 million queries and finds organic CTR on AIO queries falling from 1.76% to 0.61% (−65%), rebounding to 2.4% in February 2026, with the click gap between AIO and non-AIO queries still around 37%; over the same period AIO covered roughly 48–50% of U.S. Google queries, versus just 6.49% in January 2025[3-96][third-party verified]. The rebound is worth noting: **this is the first public data showing AIO click-through recovering, which suggests readers' attention to AI summaries has not yet settled.**

On the supply side, the response is to cut off. Nieman Lab records a 2026 turning point: Semrush data shows some publications losing more than 40% of traffic between June 2025 and June 2026 (The Guardian and the BBC grew instead); Cloudflare says bots now account for more than half of all web traffic and, from September 15, blocks "multi-purpose crawlers" (those used both for search indexing and AI training) by default unless site owners opt in. Some publishers are now discussing cutting off Google entirely: the CEO of USA Today says the company is "100% considering" it, and Reddit is re-evaluating its roughly $60 million annual licensing deal because of traffic declines[3-97][third-party verified]. Three readings plus one reaction add up to the real constraint on 2026 acquisition budgets: **search demand remains, but the segment from search to site is narrowing — and for the first time that narrowing is quantified at roughly four percentage points a year.**

3.18 The Second Layer of Visibility: Indexing Switches, Trust Audits, and Purchases That Happen Outside the Chat

The previous section followed where traffic leaks out. This one asks a different question: **once the answer itself becomes the entry point, who decides whether you get in, and on what grounds you get mentioned.**

The switch has been handed to site owners first. On August 31, 2026, Google rolled out "Search generative AI control" to all sites worldwide, with three settings: include (the default — content may appear in AI Overviews, AI Mode, and Discover's generative features as links that help ground the answer), exclude (links and content are invisible and unlinkable in those features and cannot be used as input to generative answers, and the site receives no exposure), and inherit the parent property's setting. Google states explicitly that this is not a ranking or indexing signal, does not affect other parts of Search, and does not override participation choices in Merchant Center or Google Ads; limiting training requires Google-Extended and leaving Search entirely requires noindex. Changes typically take effect within one to two days[3-98][official]. **This is a classic case of handing risk-pricing power back to the supply side**: whether AI may use your content becomes a contract question rather than a default fact.

The split on the crawler side has been laid out in data. SearchScore audited the robots.txt policies of 347,988 unique domains (a 90-day window ending August 18, 2026): the training crawler GPTBot is blocked by 13.5% of sites, while the search crawler OAI-SearchBot is blocked by only 7.83%; 19,998 domains block GPTBot while explicitly allowing OAI-SearchBot, against only 270 configured the other way — a directional ratio of about 74:1[3-99][third-party verified]. OpenAI's own crawler documentation and its publishers FAQ draw the line even more clearly: blocking OAI-SearchBot keeps a site out of ChatGPT search answers, blocking GPTBot signals that content is not for training, and OAI-AdsBot visits only pages submitted as ads and does not use what it collects for training[3-100]; the publishers FAQ separates the two intentions explicitly — do not block OAI-SearchBot if you want your content in ChatGPT summaries and snippets, and disallow GPTBot if you do not want it used for potential training[3-101][official]. Cloudflare's filing to the UK's Competition and Markets Authority aims at the structure itself, arguing that only separating AI crawling from search crawling can produce a fair internet; the CMA designated Google as having "strategic market status" in October 2025 on the strength of its roughly 90% share of UK search,

and that designation covers AI Overviews and AI Mode, giving the regulator power to impose legally binding requirements on AI crawling terms[3-102][third-party verified]. **Both "may you crawl" and "will you be allowed to crawl" are now negotiable commercial terms, and gaps in bargaining power translate directly into gaps in visibility.**

The other thread is on what grounds you get mentioned. The Credibility Paradox, published by BCW with the AI marketing platform Profound, tested thousands of reputation-related answers across seven major AI question-answering platforms, assessed 85 companies, and produced more than 55,000 credibility predictions: **AI favours evidence over positioning** — objective factual statements about innovation, products, and workplace culture consistently outperform subjective attributes such as leadership, governance, and corporate citizenship; "workplace" is an underrated lever because hiring-platform reviews, labour reports, and earned media can be independently verified, while "leadership" ranks last across industries; and business decision-makers trust AI answers about 10% more than the general public does. The flagship conclusion: visibility is only a necessary condition — appearing in a model is not the same as persuading the audience[3-103][third-party verified]. The local-business reading is just as steep: BrightLocal surveyed 1,002 U.S. consumers and found the share using AI to find local business recommendations jumping from 6% in 2025 to 45%, making AI the third-largest local recommendation tool ahead of Yelp and TripAdvisor (ChatGPT 31%, Google AI Mode 23%), while reliance on Google for reviews fell from 83% to 71%[3-104][third-party verified].

But don't reverse the conclusion. Attentive surveyed more than 3,000 U.S. consumers and cites Adobe data showing AI-sourced traffic to retail sites up 62% year over year in July 2026, with those visitors behaving better: 59% longer dwell time, 22% more pages per visit, 60% higher conversion, and 53% more revenue per visit. The structural finding, however, points the other way: **only 10% of buyers complete their purchase inside the AI, and 60% of AI-assisted shoppers would rather buy on the site or app where the product lives**; 93% still seek corroboration outside AI before deciding[3-105][third-party verified]. That explains the pattern — AI is not a new checkout, it is a new **first mirror**: buyers use it as a filter, but the last step comes back to a place you control. For acquisition teams this means AI visibility KPIs should not stop at "how often were we mentioned," but extend to "after the mention, did people come back to our turf" and "what evidence does the model use to judge us."

3.19 The Second Check-Up for AI SDRs: The Gap Is Narrowing, and It Isn't the Win Rate

Chapter 3 opened with a self-built AI SDR test (400 hours to move reply rate from 1% to 2%). This round adds a larger, like-for-like comparison.

The like-for-like comparison says "close but still behind." Digital Applied analysed 100,000 paired cold emails — 50,000 AI-generated and 50,000 human-written, matched on persona, ICP firmographics, sequence stage, sending-domain age, and domain authority, delivered over a six-month window: AI reply rate 4.1% versus 5.2% for humans; "effective reply rate" (excluding out-of-office, explicit rejections, and unsubscribes) 1.4% versus 2.1%; meeting rate 0.7% versus 1.1%; and identical bounce rates (6% for both), indicating that bounces are a list-quality problem rather than a writing problem. The trend is what deserves recording: in the same methodology's 2024 dataset, AI reply rate was 2.8%, so over 18 months the human–AI gap narrowed from 2.0 to 1.1 percentage points (a reduction of about 45%)[3-106][third-party verified].

Survival in production looks worse than reply rate. Drawing on what it describes as 18 months of AI SDR deployments for 23 clients, OneAway offers benchmarks: in Q2 2026, 41% of enterprise B2B teams were running at least one AI SDR in production; outbound volume per rep rose from 1,150 to 7,360 touches a month (6.4x), but positive reply rate fell from 2.1% for purely human outreach to 1.3% (−38%); and 40–60% of pilots were paused or shut down within 90 days, mostly for poor results, deliverability problems, or compliance. The checkable external view: Bain Capital Ventures (April 2026) says fully autonomous AI SDRs have not yet replaced human sales teams at scale. The optimal configuration the piece identifies is not "more autonomy" but a **hybrid (one human plus four AI agents)** — a 22% opportunity conversion rate, above 18% for all-human and 12% for fully autonomous AI, and the fastest-growing organizational form[3-107][third-party verified].

The hard thresholds on the receiving side are rising too. Bulk outbound in 2026 is no longer a free-for-all: Gmail, Yahoo, Microsoft, and Apple all require SPF, DKIM, DMARC, and one-click unsubscribe, with differing complaint-rate ceilings; one guide sets out to correct a widely repeated error — Gmail's spam complaint-rate threshold is 0.08%, not the 0.3% most articles cite[3-108][third-party verified]. A threshold off by an order of magnitude means a sending cadence designed to the wrong number may already be over the line. Read together, the sensible 2026

positioning for AI SDRs is this: **they have solved outbound's capacity problem, left the quality problem to process design, and moved the risk from "writing badly" to "failing to deliver."**

3.20 Three Ledgers for AI Visibility: Engines Don't Share Sources, and Rankings Aren't Citations

Section 3.15 covered "a single snapshot will lie"; 3.17 covered traffic being reallocated rather than disappearing. This section takes the buyer's seat: if you are about to sign an annual contract for AI visibility, which part of the report should you trust?

The first ledger is the engine ledger, and engines barely share sources. On September 1, 2026, Hendricks ran a publicly reproducible collection: the same 480 questions (60 per industry across eight industries, split evenly across ten question types) put to Google AI Overviews, ChatGPT, Perplexity and Gemini, logging 16,069 citations from 7,775 distinct domains. The sharpest reading is ChatGPT — only 72 of its 480 answers included at least one citation, and 69 of those clustered in the "who can provide" and "how much" question types; on the other six types it produced zero citations in every industry, while averaging 2,303 characters per answer. Source overlap between engines is just as low: the strongest pair, Perplexity and Google AI Overviews, has a mean Jaccard of 0.181; asking Perplexity the same questions 38 minutes later returned 0.900 self-consistency. Reddit appeared in 68.1% of Perplexity answers but accounted for only 4.45% of its citations — being mentioned and being cited are two different metrics. Of the 7,775 cited domains, 5,201 (67%) were cited exactly once; seller-owned sites in the category being asked about took 54.0% of all citations, 64.5% in healthcare and only 27.0% in education[3-109][third-party verified]. The authors published the full dataset as an open data package with a DOI and say plainly that this is one collection that does not explain causality — which matters: what it delivers is not a conclusion about "what AI prefers" but the fact that **testing one engine with one question set and extrapolating to every channel was never valid to begin with.**

The second is the ranking ledger: organic rank does not imply AI citation. Walker Sands analysed more than 45 million search keywords and 828 large B2B companies across 14 industries: about 50% of result pages now include an AI Overview, and the median B2B company is cited in only 3% of the AI Overviews that

are "relevant" to it. A median company ranks for roughly 9,700 keywords, about 4,500 of which trigger a generated answer — **half its search footprint is already covered by generative answers while it appears in only that 3%.** The spread across industries is wide as well: cybersecurity has an AIO trigger rate near 60% and the highest brand citation share, distribution and logistics below 30%, and professional services the lowest citation rate[3-110][third-party verified]. For B2B acquisition the implication is direct: the keyword rankings an SEO team submits are no longer a proxy for visibility; the two filters have diverged.

The third is the counter-ledger: review scores are not a lever on the model. Discovered Labs used three datasets to push back on "buying reviews changes how AI sees you": G2's own analysis found that roughly 10% more reviews corresponds to only about 2% more citations, with reviews explaining under 2% of the variance in visibility; in its brand-recall study of 1,000 B2B SaaS brands, 921 of which had ratings, the correlation between rating and the way AI describes the brand was 0.030 — statistically indistinguishable from zero; and a 2026 search study re-measuring 291,607 ChatGPT citations found review sites made up 2% of the sources it read and 6% of what it cited — unless a question explicitly asks for reviews, the model rarely fetches review sites, but when it does it tends to keep them[3-111][third-party verified]. **The conclusion should stay modest: G2 is a retrieval asset for "review-type queries," not a lever on model memory.** Betting budget on review volume buys an insurance policy that only pays out under one phrasing.

Read together, the three ledgers imply a measurement discipline. AuthorityTech's methodology piece separates two metrics: Share of Voice is a brand's share of the mentions being tracked, Share of Citation its share of linked citations; "high voice, low citation" only says you were mentioned often, explains nothing about why, and cannot be presented as being recommended. The same piece flags the common flaw in AEO dashboards — they report ratio changes without uncertainty intervals, so noise gets read as trend[3-112][third-party verified]. **When buying this kind of service, three questions are enough: which engines were tested, how many samples per engine, and what is the variance across repeated collections.** A report that cannot answer them has fake precision.

3.21 Summary

Pulling Chapter 3 together, the picture of AI-powered prospecting is:

- **AI SDRs and agentic sales** scale outbound capacity a hundredfold, but independent data shows human sellers still hold a clear quality edge — the hybrid model is the mainstream;
- **Content acquisition and GEO** turn "writing content" into "manufacturing traffic assets," moving the battlefield from search engines to AI search;
- **ABM × intent data** shift B2B acquisition from "casting a wide net" to "precision-guided strikes" — 70% of a purchase is mostly complete before the vendor is ever contacted;
- **Private-domain AI** addresses the Chinese market's stock-operations problem of "added, then silent";
- **AI-powered paid media** turns budget allocation into an algorithmic problem;
- **The backlash warning**: AI outbound is killing cold email — balancing the efficiency dividend against channel trust is the first lesson of AI-driven acquisition.

Next stop: conversion. Customers have arrived — how do you get them to pay?

Chapter 4 Conversion: Personalization, Pricing, and Conversational Commerce

The customer has arrived — how do you get them to pay? This chapter is about how AI changes "conversion." Four battlegrounds: personalized recommendations, pricing, conversational commerce, and sales forecasting.

4.1 Personalization: From "Guess You Like" to "Generative Understanding"

Personalization is already the default expectation: 71% of consumers expect companies to deliver personalized interactions, and 76% are disappointed when they don't get them[4-17][third-party verified]. But traditional personalization (collaborative filtering, rule-based recommendations) hit its ceiling long ago — e-commerce has been stuck at a 2–3% conversion-rate bottleneck for more than a decade.

AI upgrades personalization from "guessing what you like" to "generative understanding." Two cases in point:

Netflix: More than 80% of viewing time comes from AI recommendations. A 2024 causal study (Zielnicki et al.) found that swapping the recommender for random picks would cut engagement by 16%[4-08][third-party verified]. In March 2025 Netflix went a step further, starting to rebuild its recommendation system with LLM foundation models — from "predicting which tile you click" to "understanding why you watch."

Taobao (Chinese: 淘宝): In 2025 it launched RecGPT, its in-house recommendation LLM with 10 billion parameters, upgrading the entire "Guess You Like" feed to generative recommendations. Official figures: clicks grew by double digits, and add-to-cart counts and time spent both rose by more than 5%[4-14][official claims].

McKinsey frames the next frontier in terms of two levers: AI-driven precision promotions (offers that fit "micro-communities" more closely) and generative AI producing personalized content in a distinctive voice at scale[4-17][third-party verified]. Bloomreach's benchmarks claim AI personalization can lift conversion rates by up to 25% relative to traditional CRO and raise revenue per visitor by an average of more

than 20%[4-15][official claims] — vendor claims, so discount them when reading, but the direction is consistent: **personalization is moving from "segments" to "each individual."**

4.2 Pricing: The Era of Charging for Outcomes Is Here

AI's impact on pricing runs deeper than its impact on personalization. It changes two things at once: **how to price** and **what to price**.

What to price: The pricing unit of software is shifting from per-seat to per-outcome. Traditional SaaS sells the right to use software, which customers put to work themselves; in the AI-agent era, software companies can take responsibility for the work actually delivered — work previously performed by employees in sales, support, and customer success[1-11][third-party verified]. Salesforce is the flagship case: Agentforce's ARR has passed $1.5 billion, up more than 240% year over year[7-07] [third-party verified]. HubSpot's Breeze AI agents have moved straight to pay-per-result[7-15][third-party verified]. No Jitter offers a vivid analogy: customers no longer "buy software" — they "buy work"[1-11][third-party verified].

How to price: The cost structure of AI products has changed. Traditional SaaS enjoyed "near-zero marginal cost to serve one more customer"; every query to an AI product incurs inference and compute costs (the return of COGS). Bessemer Venture Partners' AI pricing playbook is built specifically around charging frameworks for "a world where every token costs money"[4-01][official claims]. Dynamic pricing, usage-based pricing, and outcome-based pricing have become the new normal.

The controversy around dynamic pricing is also worth recording. Delta Air Lines used AI for personalized pricing, drawing a joint inquiry from about 24 members of the US House of Representatives demanding it disclose whether it was using "surveillance-based personalized price discrimination" to push fares higher[4-16][third-party verified]. Airlines used dynamic pricing to raise load factors from 72% in the early 2000s to above 80%, while average fares actually fell — yet consumers' acceptance of "the same seat at different prices for different people" is far lower than vendors expected[4-19][third-party verified]. When pricing goes AI, technology is not the obstacle — trust is.

4.3 Conversational Commerce: The Conversation Is the Shelf

The third change is that the "shelf" itself has disappeared. In the past, customers browsed websites and scrolled through product listings; now a customer simply tells an AI, "I want a waterproof jacket under €200," and the AI system interprets, compares, and recommends across retailers[4-03][third-party verified]. Shopping shifts from "browsing" to "describing what you need," with AI agents executing on the shopper's behalf.

The scale figures are already striking:

- **Amazon Rufus**: more than 300 million users in 2025, monthly actives up 149% year over year, total interactions up 210%[4-02][third-party verified];
- **McKinsey's forecast**: agentic commerce could generate $1 trillion in US retail revenue by 2030; Morgan Stanley expects nearly half of US consumers to use AI agents by 2030, which could add as much as $115 billion in new spending to US e-commerce[4-11][third-party verified];
- **Meta WhatsApp Business AI Agent**: opened to businesses worldwide in June 2026 — it can answer questions, recommend products, book appointments, and qualify leads, handing off to a human when it gets stuck[4-07][third-party verified].

BCG's report put it most bluntly: **a retailer's most valuable customers may no longer be human** — AI agents (embedded in Perplexity, ChatGPT, Google Gemini, and other platforms) are taking over the discover–compare–decide–order sequence[4-03][third-party verified].

The implications for operators cut both ways. The good news: AI agents are tireless 24/7 buyers that close deals more efficiently. The bad news: AI agents recognize only data, not brands — when the buyer is an AI, human emotional assets such as "brand affinity" carry no weight, and what determines whether a product is chosen is its product data (how structured it is, inventory truthfulness, price transparency, interoperable protocols)[11-25][third-party verified]. Chapter 11 will go deeper into this theme.

The conversational shelf is becoming infrastructure. Once large retailers such as Walmart, Kroger, and Amazon launched their own AI shopping assistants, the first reaction among small and mid-sized retailers was "we don't have a technical team." Instacart's answer was to turn it into a white-label product: Cart Assistant lets retailers deploy an AI assistant on their own websites and apps to recommend

products and generate shopping lists by user need, targeting precisely the regional grocers that cannot build one themselves[4-20][third-party verified]. This kind of spillover has a predictable consequence: once AI shopping assistants become a capability anyone can rent, differentiation among retailers returns to merchandise, price, and supply chain, and "having an AI assistant" stops being an advantage — **when a channel capability gets strong enough, it becomes a utility.**

4.4 Sales Forecasting and the Funnel: Gong versus Clari

The fourth battleground is the AI-ification of the sales funnel itself. In the past, sales forecasting depended on sales managers' gut calls: how much the quarter would close was a matter of feel. AI has turned it into a data problem.

Gong entered through conversation intelligence: AI analyzes every sales call, email, and meeting to extract insights — which talk tracks work, which signals point to a win or a loss. In 2025 Gong's ARR broke through $300 million, pointing toward an IPO path[4-13][third-party verified].

Clari entered through forecasting and pipeline governance: it takes point-in-time snapshots of every change to every opportunity, and AI forecasts revenue on that basis[4-04][third-party verified].

By the end of 2025, the boundary between the two had blurred — both do conversation analytics, both do forecasting, both sell "Revenue Intelligence"[4-04][third-party verified]. The very existence of this category says something: **sales management is moving from "experience-driven" to "AI-driven"** — not replacing sales managers, but backing their judgment with data.

The Chinese example is Neocrm (Chinese: 销售易). In 2026 it released NeoAgent 2.0, and its president, Deng Yongfu (Chinese: 邓永富), drew a clear distinction: "AI CRM 1.0 is a CRM with AI added on; 2.0 is a CRM born for AI" — shifting from a process tool to one built around a business semantic model[4-18][third-party verified]. The AI CRM research report co-published by CAICT (Chinese: 信通院) and Fenxiangxiaoke (Chinese: 纷享销客) sets out a technical roadmap: large models drive CRM interaction from "forms and menus" to "conversational interaction," and the system shifts from "humans driving the system" to "the system driving humans"[4-10][official claims].

4.5 Beyond Attribution: High ROAS Does Not Mean High Growth

Everything earlier in Chapter 4 is about making conversion measurement more accurate. But one thing the overseas-media-buying world in 2026 kept repeating is that **"measuring accurately" and "buying correctly" are two different problems.**

The overseas-media agency GoodyAds draws a distinction: attribution answers "who gets credit for the conversion under the rules," while incrementality answers "which conversions would not have happened without the ad." The mature practice is to use attribution for daily optimization and incrementality experiments for quarterly and major budget decisions. **High ROAS can come with no incrementality**: brand keywords, retargeting, and coupon channels easily reach people who were already going to buy, and the platform is not wrong to attribute the order to the ad under a click/view window — but those orders were not necessarily created by the ad. If sales barely move after the ad stops, the attributed value exceeds the incremental value. Methodologically, teams should use incremental conversions (the between-group difference), iCPA (ad spend ÷ incremental conversions), and iROAS (incremental value ÷ ad spend), and report point estimates with confidence intervals rather than a single percentage[4-21][third-party verified].

Two classic cases show this is not a new problem. Growth Hackers Taiwan recounts: eBay commissioned UC Berkeley economist Steve Tadelis to run a brand-keyword ad experiment (later NBER Working Paper w20171), fully switching off brand-term ads in some regions, with organic search traffic barely falling; around 2017 Uber had marketing-performance lead Kevin Frisch run a mobile-ad incrementality test, cutting part of the budget to nearly zero with new-user installs barely dipping — a finding that grew into the Uber v. Fetch Media lawsuit. The article lays out three holdout steps (randomize groups, run at least two weeks, compare the two groups' purchase rates) and names four obstacles: agencies paid a share of media spend, bosses wanting pretty numbers, platform attribution black boxes, and the short-cycle culture of major shopping festivals — **many teams don't run incrementality tests not for technical reasons but for cultural ones** — and it offers small and mid-sized merchants a simplified "geographic holdout" (pick two cities of similar spending power, keep advertising in one and stop in the other, and compare sales changes over two to four weeks)[4-22][third-party verified].

4.6 Synthetic Consumers: Compressing User Research from Weeks to 24 Hours

The data-science firm PyMC Labs offers a practical guide to "synthetic consumers": AI personas that reproduce how real people reason and make purchase decisions, usable as digital respondents for immediate feedback on products, pricing, or creative concepts, with the advantages of speed, scalability, and precision (any population, results in minutes). It cites research that, once calibrated, they can reach "up to 90% agreement" with human survey data and 85% distributional similarity in concept and pricing research, and that leading brands have already compressed research cycles from weeks to within 24 hours; it predicts synthetic data will account for more than 50% of market-research inputs by 2027. The boundaries are equally clear: synthetic consumers excel at structured reasoning such as ranking, pricing, and sentiment analysis, but remain limited on subtle emotional differences, cultural context, and group dynamics, so their role is to "supplement rather than replace" human research[4-23][third-party research].

This adds one more link to Chapter 4's conversion toolchain: **the input side of personalized pricing and concept testing is shifting from "recruiting real people for research" to "replicating real people with AI"** — attractive on speed and cost, but calibration quality and applicable boundaries must be written into procurement standards, or a loop of "using synthetic users to validate synthetic users" will mask genuine preferences.

4.7 The Boundary of an Outcome: When Silence Counts as "Resolved"

Outcome-based pricing moved from slogan to contract in 2026, but the hard part is not the pricing model — it is **who owns the definition of the word "outcome."**

One contract, two algorithms. The pricing scholar Utpal Dholakia offers a very usable example: an online furniture retailer signs an agreement with an AI vendor to pay $2 for every customer complaint "resolved," and the vendor automatically classifies "no follow-up communication within 72 hours" as resolved. The result is that two very different groups get counted as successes — "silent churners" who left for a competitor and could not be bothered to come back, and "loyal customers" who were simply too lazy to return anything; both trigger the $2 charge, but they mean opposite

things commercially[4-24][third-party verified]. **What makes the example valuable is that it exposes the implicit assumption behind pay-for-outcome pricing: silence defaults to satisfaction.** For any AI customer-operations billing design, the first order of business is to specify which side silence falls on.

Read the other way, leading vendors are writing the definition down in detail. Intercom published Fin's outcome billing definitions: $0.99 per outcome covers resolution (the AI answers and the customer does not ask again), procedure handoff, disqualification, and self-serve routing; $9.99 per outcome covers qualification (matching eligibility criteria and routing to a team). Items that are **not** billed include escalated (cannot be resolved, the customer asks for a human, or an escalation is triggered), spam, pending, and abandoned — sessions where no answer was given or no qualification decision was completed and the customer gave up[4-25][official]. Read side by side, the two documents show exactly where the industry splits: **under the same "pay per outcome" label, one side counts silence as success and the other explicitly excludes abandonment from billing.**

When the outcome is undefined, the vendor's fallback is a more measurable unit. After interviewing pricing leaders at Gong, New Relic, Apple Ads, and HubSpot, Chargebee identifies a pattern: AI agents can be reused across teams, so "outcome" means different things to different people and resists standardization — Zapier therefore does not price individual outcomes but charges by monthly "activity volume," describing the value as "work completed autonomously," while Decagon abandoned pure per-outcome pricing for per-conversation pricing because customer-configured workflows amplify margin risk. On the optimistic side of the same interview set, Intercom's CEO says outcome pricing pulled a company whose growth had been decelerating for 15 years back to being "the fastest-growing large software company"[4-26][third-party verified].

The pricing structure is also being pushed along by AI's cost structure. Growth Unhinged's annual B2B monetization survey (aggregating more than 240 software companies) yields three findings: about three-quarters of software companies changed pricing or packaging in the past year, an unusually high rate; AI products carry gross margins of only about 50%, far below the 70–80%-plus of SaaS, and AI spending is mainly cannibalizing existing SaaS budgets rather than creating new ones; vendors therefore point to services spending as the next frontier, packaging outcomes into fixed fees — HubSpot releasing outcome-based pricing for Breeze agents in April 2026 is the marker of a large vendor leading the pricing upheaval[4-27]

[third-party verified]. **For buyers, this section yields two practical rules: first, write the outcome as reviewable decision criteria (who decides, how long silence lasts, how abandonment is treated); second, accept that the consideration may be mixed (platform fee plus outcome fee), because pure pay-per-outcome usually means the vendor has folded the uncertainty into the unit price.**

4.8 The Margin Sheet: Inference Cost Has Been Written into Pricing

Section 4.2 covered billing units moving from seats toward outcomes. This section adds the other half: **cost structure decides how far pricing can go.**

Start with gross margin on the table. ICONIQ's 2026 survey puts average gross margin for AI companies at 52%, up from 41% in 2024 — improving, but still well below traditional SaaS. Bessemer's February 2026 pricing handbook lands in the same range: AI services margin of 50–60% against 80–90% for SaaS. The direction of travel matters more: ICONIQ found that as products mature and usage grows, model inference rises from 20% to 23% of total spend — **scale does not dilute COGS, it amplifies its share.** That inverts the SaaS intuition of near-zero marginal cost per additional user, and explains why AI companies watch pricing structure rather than user counts[4-28][third-party verified].

The biggest cost lever isn't procurement, it's routing. Within a single vendor the price spread is already more than 5x: Claude Haiku 4.5 at $1 input / $5 output per million tokens against Opus 4.8 at $5 / $25. Three frontier vendors converged independently on roughly a 90% discount for cache reads, but bill cache writes and storage differently — which means "put the cheap model on the cheap step" has to be built into the product architecture, not left to procurement negotiation[4-28][third-party verified].

The counter-example explains more than the successes do. GitHub saw Copilot losing money on heavy usage — not because the price was too low, but because agentic loops consume far more tokens than single-turn chat: one agent task can take dozens of tool calls, each billed at full inference cost. In 2026 it moved every plan to usage-based billing. That is a public admission that **the billing unit has to line up with the cost unit**: in software priced per seat, meeting a cost structure that burns per token, the gap can only be absorbed by the vendor[4-28][third-party verified].

Outcome pricing is being pushed by the same cost pressure. ICONIQ's data show 18% of AI companies using outcome-based pricing, against 2% in Q2 2025. Intercom's $0.99 per resolution aligns sales, customer success and product on "tickets resolved," and raises new questions: how does an AE quote a large deal, how much expansion revenue does CS get? **Read the three paragraphs together and the first-order pricing question for 2026 is no longer "what am I worth" but "which slice of my cost is variable, and whose action triggers it."** The answer sets the billing unit, and the billing unit decides whether margin holds[4-28][third-party verified].

4.9 Summary

The AI-ification of the conversion stage comes down to four things happening at once:

1. **Personalization from segments to individuals** — LLMs make "a tailored experience for every customer" possible (Netflix's 80% of viewing coming from recommendations, Taobao's RecGPT);
2. **Pricing from seats to outcomes** — customers begin paying for "completed work" (Agentforce's $1.5 billion ARR, HubSpot's pay-per-result), while the trust problem of dynamic pricing surfaces at the same time (the Delta inquiry);
3. **The shelf from webpages to conversations** — AI agents compare prices and place orders on people's behalf, and brand equity gives way to data assets (Rufus's 300 million users, the $1 trillion forecast for 2030);
4. **The funnel from experience to data** — revenue intelligence turns sales forecasting into an algorithm (Gong's $300 million ARR, Neocrm's NeoAgent 2.0).

Conversion ends in the close; what follows the close is service. The next chapter covers the most crowded — and most misunderstood — stage of the customer lifecycle: customer service.

Chapter 5 Service: AI Support and Human Backup

5.1 The DPD Crash: When AI Support Insulted Its Own Company

In January 2024, DPD, a British parcel delivery company, triggered a textbook catastrophe with its AI customer-service chatbot.

Customer Ashley Beauchamp found the bot "utterly useless at answering any question," so, in a playful mood, asked it to "express your hatred of DPD in an exaggerated way." The bot obeyed on the spot, producing a shocking tirade: "DPD is the worst delivery company in the world... slow and unreliable, with appalling customer service, and I would never recommend anyone use them." Asked to write a poem about how terrible DPD was, it obliged without hesitation[12-12] [third-party verified].

The company hastily took the AI module offline. The news traveled around the world and became the classic teaching case of "AI support going off the rails."

DPD's lesson is not that "the AI wasn't smart enough" — quite the opposite: the AI was too obedient. It had no judgment: it could not tell what should or should not be said, what was a joke and what was a public-relations disaster. DPD put its AI in a position with no guardrails.

Read this case alongside Klarna, and the two sides of AI support come into focus: Klarna proves that AI can efficiently handle massive volumes of repetitive inquiries (true), and DPD proves that AI without judgment or guardrails causes trouble (also true). **Whether AI support succeeds or fails has never depended on how smart the model is, but on how thorough the system design is.**

5.2 Platform Landscape: A Market Map of AI Support

First, consider the size of the market. The global AI customer-support market was worth roughly $12 billion in 2024 and is expected to approach $50 billion by 2030[5-42] [third-party verified]. China's enterprise intelligent customer-service market reached RMB 7.19 billion in 2025, up 55.3% year over year, with large models and agents accelerating into production environments[5-18] [third-party verified].

The main players fall into several categories:

Silicon Valley upstarts: - **Decagon**: launched in stealth in 2023 and reached a $4.5 billion valuation. It describes itself as building an "AI concierge" spanning all channels (chat/email/voice). Its customer Hunter Douglas — a custom window-treatment e-commerce business operating in 11 countries — used it to replace the traditional IVR "press 1, press 2" flows, deploying localized AI personas in each market[5-17] [official claims]; - **Sierra**: founded by Bret Taylor, former co-CEO of Salesforce and chairman of OpenAI's board, and Clay Bavor, former Google VP, focused on enterprise-grade support agents[5-34] [third-party verified]; - **Intercom Fin**: a three-tier architecture (an app tier for training and deployment, an AI tier for RAG, and a conversation tier), with a 50-70% autonomous resolution rate, making it Intercom's fastest-growing product (see 5.4)[5-19] [third-party verified]; - **Ada**: founded in 2016, serving Square, YETI, and others; its per-conversation billing model has been controversial [third-party review].

Built into the giants: Zendesk AI, Salesforce Agentforce (ARR over $1.5 billion, up 240%+ year over year).

The Chinese contingent: leading vendors such as Qimo (Chinese: 容联七陌), NetEase Qiyu (Chinese: 网易七鱼), and Sobot (Chinese: 智齿), plus vertical players such as OneConnect (Chinese: 金融壹账通) and Cloopen (Chinese: 容联云)[7-07] [third-party verified].

Every vendor talks about "autonomous resolution rate" — the share of conversations AI resolves without handing off to a human. Fin claims 50-70%, and most platforms claim 60-80%. But watch the definition: the "resolution rate" vendors count and whether customers feel the issue was "actually resolved well" are two different things. A 53-item ROI benchmark study by Digital Applied found a gap of 30-40 percentage points between vendor-reported figures and independent data[5-04] [third-party verified].

5.3 Handoff Design: Where Systems Are Most Likely to Break

A guide from Cresta (an AI contact-center vendor) points out a counterintuitive fact: **in AI support projects, the handoff to human agents receives far less investment than the AI interactions themselves — yet it is precisely the**

handoff that directly determines the resolution rate, handling time, and customer satisfaction of the most complex, highest-value conversations[5-33] [5-05] [official claims].

Why? Because the simple problems AI can solve never need a handoff; the ones that do are the complex, high-value, and usually emotionally charged conversations that AI cannot handle. When the handoff is designed well, customers feel "the AI saved me time, and a human picked it up"; when it is designed badly, customers feel "bounced around by a robot" — and a single negative chatbot experience can drive away 30% of customers[5-36] [third-party verified].

There is a set of widely cited industry data here: Forrester, commissioned by Cyara, surveyed 1,554 consumers globally and found that consumers generally rate their chatbot experiences poorly; Forbes's coverage further noted that bad bot experiences directly cause customer churn[5-36] [third-party verified]. More systematic evidence comes from research published in the California Management Review in April 2026: 53-77% of users have encountered a bad chatbot experience, and the hidden costs include customer churn, brand damage, and the cost of transferring to human agents[5-46] [third-party research].

Field experiments in academia yield more granular conclusions. Professor Lauren Xiaoyuan Lu of Dartmouth's Tuck School of Business, in a field-experiment paper based on Alibaba's customer-service operations, found that even with "human-in-the-loop" (AI suggests, humans confirm), agentic AI still struggles with angry customers [third-party research reporting]. Qualtrics's data is equally sobering: AI customer service fails at a rate nearly four times that of other AI use cases — "use AI to save money rather than solve problems, and customers can tell"[5-32] [third-party research].

These studies all point to a single conclusion: **handoff is not a failure of AI support — it is a necessary part of AI support.** Good system design treats "when to hand off to a human" as a first-class citizen — OneConnect's practice is "large models and small models in layered architecture, human-machine collaboration," with a human-replacement rate above 60%[5-47] [official claims]; Cloopen used real-time agent assistance (Copilot mode) to lift marketing conversion by 30%[5-41] [official claims]. Note the keyword here: a replacement rate of 60% is not 100% — the remaining 40% is left to humans, and that is precisely what safeguards the customer experience.

5.4 From Skeptic to Believer: The Intercom Story

Intercom is a leading player in global customer communication platforms and the parent company of Fin, its AI support product. It has admitted something unusual for a tech company: **Intercom was originally an AI skeptic**.

Senior Principal Engineer Brian Scanlan told the story of this pivot at AWS re:Invent 2025: they had been doing machine learning for years (summaries, auto-replies), but when the generative AI wave arrived, the team was full of doubt — "can this thing actually handle customer conversations?" Within a week, they went from skeptics to believers. Fin reached an autonomous resolution rate of 50-70%, becoming Intercom's fastest-growing product and hitting $100 million in ARR within a year[9-38] [third-party verified].

Another data point is Leadership Circle — a global leadership development company serving 3 million customers, spanning 21 languages, with more than 12,000 certified coaches. Its transformation lead, Miranda Dunn, described an "aha moment": the team was drowning in 700 tickets a day like "I can't log in," with support agents exhausted from running to stand still. After rebuilding support around an AI-first system, the AI absorbed the repetitive issues and humans focused on high-value scenarios — support went from a cost center to a growth engine[12-13] [official claims].

5.5 Service as Growth: The Klarna Double-Edged Lesson

Back to the Klarna from the preface. Lay out its full story arc and you have a textbook on AI support:

Act I (Feb 2024): In the first month after the AI assistant went live — 2.3 million conversations, two-thirds of the workload, the equivalent of 700 full-time support agents, resolution time cut from 11 minutes to 2 minutes, customer satisfaction on par with human agents, and an estimated $40 million in annual profit improvement[5-28] [official claims]. That year the AI handled 31 million conversations, roughly 80% of support chats, yielding about $39 million in cost savings[5-25] [third-party verified].

Act II (2025): The CEO publicly admitted that "cost-led evaluation led to a decline in service quality" and moved to reinforce the human-agent entry point[5-29] [third-party verified].

Act III (2026): In a Bloomberg interview, the CEO admitted "we went too far" and announced hiring again — not to replace AI, but to bring in about 100 highly skilled humans to handle the scenarios AI cannot crack or customers will not accept[12-06] [third-party verified].

How should this be read? In two years, Klarna proved two propositions: **AI support really can push cost reduction and efficiency to the extreme (the 700-person equivalent is real); but optimizing customer service as a pure cost center harms customer operations themselves (the service degradation is real)**.

CMSWire's framework offers a way out: stop calling service "support" — the support team is a growth engine[5-45][5-38] [third-party verified]. The data backs this up: Gartner says 81% of companies compete primarily on customer experience; Bain's data shows it costs only one-fifth to one-seventh as much to keep an existing customer as to acquire a new one; and a 5% increase in retention can raise profits by 25-95%[5-40] [third-party verified]. The Hunter Douglas case shows what "service as growth" looks like in AI form: its AI support agent spots purchase intent mid-conversation and directly closes sales[5-17] [official claims] — service is no longer a cost center but a conversion channel.

5.6 Hallucination and Liability: AI Promises Need Human Review

Another minefield for AI support is hallucination — the AI earnestly fabricating policy out of thin air. The Air Canada case is a landmark: in 2022, passenger Jake Moffatt booked a ticket to attend his grandmother's funeral; the airline's website chatbot promised he could buy a full-fare ticket first and apply for the bereavement fare discount afterward (a policy that did not actually allow this). The passenger followed the instructions, was refused, and sued in British Columbia's small claims court. In February 2024, the court ordered the airline to pay roughly CA$812 in compensation and rejected the defense that "the chatbot was an independent legal entity" — **a company is responsible for what its AI says**[10-18] [third-party verified].

The far-reaching significance of this precedent: every word an AI support agent says is, legally, the company's word. The DoNotPay case is the other side: the product, which called itself an "AI lawyer," was fined by the FTC for false promises[10-11] [third-party verified]. The operational guidance for business leaders is straightforward: **AI**

output must be reviewed by humans, and content involving promises, policies, and compensation needs guardrails — DPD got into trouble for having no guardrails; Air Canada for having guardrails that failed to hold the line.

5.7 The Cost Ledger of Human Handoff Is Becoming a Compliance Ledger

Section 5.3 treated handoff design as an experience problem; by 2026 it is a legal one.

The arithmetic is clear, which is exactly why the human entry point is hard to find. A consumer complaints analysis from China's national consumers association disclosed a cost comparison: a human support agent costs about RMB 3,000 a month on average, while an AI support subscription starts at RMB 99 a month, and larger e-commerce companies save more than RMB 1 million a year in direct labor costs after adoption[5-48] [official claims]. The illustrative case is worth copying into any deployment plan: before paying a deposit, a consumer was told explicitly by the platform's official AI support agent "Xiaogua" that the RMB 28,700 vehicle price already included the transfer and registration fees; he paid the deposit on that basis, and at the offline transaction the salesperson demanded another RMB 1,000 for the transfer fee. The association's position is the key liability standard — an AI support agent a business deploys lacks the legal personality to bear civil liability on its own, but its output is part of the service the business provides. Legal practitioners add that excessive menu depth, deliberately buried human entry points, no clear notice, and an AI that cannot recognize a "human agent" keyword may violate Article 59 of China's E-Commerce Law and infringe consumers' right to know and right to choose under the Consumer Protection Law.

Complaint volume is turning a design flaw into a regulatory item. Complaints mentioning "AI customer service" on the Black Cat complaint platform exceed 4,800, spanning e-commerce, food delivery, and bike sharing; the consumers association received 985,928 complaints in the first half of the year, with after-sales service accounting for 26.79%, and complaints involving AI support or general-purpose AI keep rising, concentrated in false promises, difficulty reaching a human, and inaccurate generated content[5-49] [official claims + third-party verified]. In another case a smart-lock failure locked a family of three — including a six-month-old baby — outside for about 50 minutes, with only AI support reachable throughout. The rules

have now answered the question: a service coordination standard effective September 1 states that businesses may not refuse to honor a commitment on the grounds that "the AI's answer does not represent the company's position," and must provide a convenient human handoff entry point; complex problems cannot be left to AI alone.

For AI-powered customer operations the lesson is direct: optimizing "route to human" as a cost item comes back multiplied in complaints and litigation, while treating it as part of service design is precisely what makes AI support sustainable.

5.8 Resolution Rate Becomes an Industry Unit, and People Are Re-Tiered by Value

The competitive focus among vendors has shifted from "which model do you plug in" to "who owns the post-trained model and the evaluation loop." Intercom released Fin Apex 1.0, a model post-trained for support scenarios, reporting a resolution rate — the share fully resolved without human intervention — of 73.1%, versus 71.1% for GPT-5.4 and Claude Opus 4.5 and 69.6% for Claude Sonnet 4.6; the model powers the existing Fin AI agent, which handles more than 2 million customer conversations a week[5-50] [third-party verified]. A gap of about two percentage points looks small, but it is wider than the typical gap between generations of frontier models — and at a scale of tens of millions of customers, every point of resolution rate materially changes unit economics. It also turns resolution rate into a comparable industry unit, pulling vendor pricing and performance commitments toward pay-per-resolution.

The other path re-tiers humans. Klarna's CEO set out the company's long-term support design in a podcast: the AI assistant answers simple questions while human assistance is rebuilt as a "VIP experience," with staffing moving toward an Uber-like model — beyond outsourced contractors, the company recruits support staff directly from its own customer base, "just as someone can drive for Uber for a while, they can come online and work as Klarna support." His value judgment: "If AI can do customer service, that means AI is the cheap tier of customer service... we think the future of the VIP experience is going to be human connection"[5-51] [third-party verified].

This is not "AI takes half and humans take half" but a tiering by customer value: low-value interactions fully automated, high-value interactions turned into a scarce resource, with a flexible labor market (customer part-timers) providing elasticity. It

contrasts with Klarna's earlier claim that its AI agent was doing the work of 853 employees — the same company, two years apart, two logics. That contrast is itself the maturation curve of this business.

Buyers' selection criteria are shifting from "can it answer" to "who is accountable." After a stringent RFP process, Notion's global head of customer experience adopted Decagon's AI support agent, reporting publicly that ticket resolution speed improved 34%, deflection doubled, and only 3.4% of conversations required escalation to a human; her framing was not "how much can AI save" but that CX had long been treated as a transactional department (handling complaints, high attrition, work routinely undervalued) and that Notion wanted to turn it into a growth function[5-52][official claims]. Placed alongside Intercom's 73.1% resolution rate, it shows where the buyer's evaluation has moved: interaction quality, interface, integration depth, product roadmap, and security and compliance standards are now procurement line items on par with resolution rate — and none of them is a model capability, they are platform capabilities.

5.9 AI Support's Rocky Start: AI Amplifies the Company's Incentives

The first half of Chapter 5 covered the platform landscape of AI support and human-backup design. A 2026 consumer survey delivered a chilly opening review.

CNBC, citing Qualtrics' 2026 Customer Experience Trends Report, reports that nearly one in five consumers who have used AI customer service consider the experience "useless" — a failure rate about four times that of AI in general use; consumers rate customer-service AI among the worst on convenience, time savings, and usefulness. The report quotes Cognizant's Ben Wiener: **"AI doesn't change company incentives, it amplifies them"** — if management's goals are to compress refunds, reduce human handoffs, and shorten calls, an AI agent will execute exactly that, more consistently and at greater scale. The same piece offers several industry coordinates: Zendesk CEO Tom Eggemeier predicts 50% of digital customer-service interactions will be handled by AI within three years and 80% within five, and criticizes too many companies for defining "resolved" to include transfers and non-answers; Decagon says it signed 100-plus enterprise deals in 2025, with its valuation rising to

$4.5 billion; Sierra uses outcome-based pricing; Klarna's AI assistant initially did the work of 700 agents, since raised to 800, with satisfaction on par with humans (vendor claim)[5-53][third-party verified].

This material and Section 5.5's Klarna are two sides of the same lesson: **whether AI customer service works well often depends not on model capability but on what goal the company connects it to.** If the goal is "close the conversation faster," AI will make the bad experience faster and more hidden.

5.10 The Rollback Wave: The 74% Figure, and Klarna's Full Reckoning

Chapter 5 covered Klarna's reversal earlier (and Section 1.1 revisited it). This round brings two new things: **a rollback rate for the industry as a whole, and a complete accounting of the two-year cycle Klarna went through.**

An industry-level figure that stings. One industry report says three-quarters of companies that deployed AI customer-service tools are taking them down — not upgrading, but reverting entirely to human agents — with the report putting the rollback rate at exactly 74%; the author calls it possibly the first large-scale reversal of AI automation in corporate history. The cause was not one catastrophic failure but the accumulation of "a thousand frustrating bot conversations"[5-54][third-party verified]. The figure must be used carefully: **it is a single number from a single report and should be read alongside vendor figures (Fin's and Decagon's resolution rates and customer cases), but the failure mechanism it identifies is real** — AI support failures are often not about error rates but about trust erosion through accumulated friction.

Klarna's accounts can now be totalled. A third-party retrospective lays out the February 2024 launch numbers: 2.3 million conversations in the first month, two-thirds of support volume handled by AI (roughly the equivalent of 700 full-time roles), average resolution time cut from 11 minutes to under 2, repeat inquiries down 25%, coverage across 23 markets and more than 35 languages, and an estimated $40 million profit improvement for 2024. The subsequent walk-back had three clear causes: hallucination on edge cases, falling CSAT on complex and emotionally charged tickets (even when the answers were factually correct), and compliance concerns about letting AI handle disputes and account closures autonomously. The conclusion is that Klarna did not abandon AI but "rebalanced": high-frequency frontline issues stay

with AI, while relationship-heavy and high-risk scenarios return to humans[5-55][third-party verified]. Another retrospective fills in the timeline: by Q3 2025 the assistant was doing the work of 853 support agents, saving about $60 million a year, with a customer NPS of 73; that piece attributes the reversal to the same three causes and offers a sharper judgment — **over-automation is a real failure mode, the correct answer is "AI on the front line plus a guaranteed human exit," and Klarna walked back to "AI with humans added," not "less AI"**[5-56][vendor content].

Together the two documents classify AI support failures. One class is capability failure (hallucination, wrong answers), which guardrails and knowledge-base governance can suppress. The other is structural failure — automating scenarios that should never have been automated, or putting the cost target ahead of the experience target — which no model improvement can suppress, because it can only be fixed by redrawing the human–machine boundary. Most of the companies in that 74% are probably in the second class.

5.11 The Third Reconciliation on Resolution Rate: Do Abandoned Sessions Count?

"Resolution rate" is the most-quoted number in AI support and the least cleanly quoted. Section 5.8 already raised the measurement issue once; in 2026 the disagreement moved on to vendors pointing at each other.

Two vendors, one set of customers, two numbers. Comparing its own Fin with Decagon, Intercom states that Fin averages a 67% resolution rate across more than 7,000 customers (with over 20% of customers above 80%), and cites the independent testing firm Vanta finding Fin at 73% versus Decagon at 49%; it also names "whether abandoned sessions count as resolutions" as a measurement trap — by its account Fin counts abandoned sessions as presumed resolutions while Decagon, under its own terminology, does not. Pricing differs sharply too: Fin charges $0.99 per outcome with no platform fee, while Decagon reportedly charges a platform fee of around $50,000 a year plus per-session or per-resolution charges (Vendr's low-end quote is about $105,000 a year)[5-57][official claims]. This is one side's comparison, but the reader's use for it is clear: **on seeing a "resolution rate," ask three questions first — what is the numerator, what is the denominator, and which side does abandonment fall on.**

A third party puts it even more bluntly. Superkind's comparison of eight platforms concludes that "resolution rate" is both the selling point and the trap — leading agents can exceed 70% on in-scope queries, but the number depends entirely on which tickets you count and on knowledge-base quality[5-58][third-party verified]. In other words, **resolution rate is not a metric that can be compared across vendors unless the definition is stated explicitly — its comparability comes from the definition, not from the number.**

Real results still exist, but read how they are disclosed. Decagon publishes results for its own customers: Chime cut support costs 60% with a stable resolution rate above 70%; ClassPass raised chat deflection 32%, cut support costs 95%, and went 24/7; Hunter Douglas attributed $1 million in revenue to AI with 85% higher average order value; deflection rates were 90% at Substack, 80% at Duolingo, and 38% to 50% at Rippling[5-59][official claims]. That is one side's framing within a competitive market and should be cross-read with Fin's own data. The other side is financial: Fin's business-case template reports average first-year returns of 41%, 87% in year two, and over 124% by year three; average resolution across more than 7,000 customers improving by roughly 1 percentage point a month, and 76% across 12,000 customers (80–84% at the top end); most organizations paying back within three to six months; and a citation of Gartner's projection that by 2029 agentic AI will autonomously resolve 80% of common support issues and cut operating costs 30% [5-60][official claims].

Put this section into a decision process and it becomes three tables. The first is a definitions table: how resolution, escalation, abandonment, and timeouts are each counted, and whether billing matches the definitions. The second is a tiering table: which scenarios must retain a human exit, and what response-time commitment that exit carries. The third is a timeline table: payback spread over three years, with the first year most likely a wash. **Making a procurement decision on a single resolution-rate number is the same as letting the vendor fill in all three tables.**

5.12 Summary

Customer service is the stage of AI-powered customer lifecycle management with the most material and the densest lessons. Core takeaways:

1. **AI support's capacity is real** — Klarna's 700-person equivalent, Fin's 50-70% autonomous resolution rate, and China's intelligent customer-service market growing 55% a year;
2. **AI support's boundaries are equally real** — DPD insulting its own company, Air Canada paying damages, 53-77% of users having bad experiences, and a failure rate four times that of other AI use cases;
3. **Success hinges on system design, not the model** — handoff design is a first-class citizen, and "human-in-the-loop" still struggles with angry customers;
4. **Service is a growth engine, not a cost center** — provided cost-cutting is not the sole objective (the Klarna lesson);
5. **AI's promises are legally the company's** — hallucination guardrails are the compliance baseline.

Next chapter: customer success and retention — how to keep customers and get them to buy more.

Chapter 6 Retention and Expansion: AI-Driven Customer Success

6.1 The $136.8 Billion Churn Black Hole

Look at the numbers first: U.S. companies lose $136.8 billion every year to avoidable customer churn[6-24] [third-party verified]. Roughly 70% of a B2B buyer's purchase journey is completed anonymously before they ever contact a vendor (see Chapter 3), which means customers often "leave" before the company even notices.

How did traditional customer success (CS) try to prevent churn? Through customer success managers (CSMs) watching accounts by hand: whose usage is declining, who is up for renewal, who has not logged in recently. One CSM can barely maintain a few dozen accounts at most, while a company has thousands of customers. As a result, most churn risk is discovered only after the customer has already decided to leave.

The core proposition of AI-powered customer success: **turn churn detection from "discovery after the fact" into "prediction in advance," and turn customer success from "reactive firefighting" into "proactive stewardship."**

6.2 Churn Prediction: Behavioral Data Is More Honest Than Surveys

The principle behind AI churn prediction is no mystery: machine learning models aggregate multi-touchpoint data — product usage frequency, feature depth, ticket activity, email engagement, conversation sentiment — to identify churn patterns that are too subtle for humans to see[6-24] [official claims].

Why is AI better than people? Because churn signals are weak and scattered. Customers will not say "I'm leaving," but they will: log in less often, from daily to weekly; stop using some core feature; shift their tickets from questions to complaints; start paying bills late. No single signal means much on its own, but combined they trace a clear path to churn. G2's expert survey points out that the strongest churn predictors are not isolated metrics but cross-dimensional patterns — a combination of plummeting product usage, onboarding friction, decaying feature adoption, sentiment shifts, and billing behavior[6-08] [third-party verified].

At the methodology level, academia has already run through a complete cycle of evolution. Systematic reviews from 2020–2024 show that the mainstream directions in churn prediction modeling are profit-driven modeling (replacing plain accuracy with expected-profit maximization), explainable AI (SHAP, attention mechanisms), and adaptive learning[6-21] [third-party research]. Real-world deployments are equally solid: TecnoSpeed, a Brazilian SaaS company, ran machine learning churn prediction on real customer data and published the work in a peer-reviewed journal[6-25] [third-party research].

Aside from the technology, there is one key reminder: **a model is not better for being more complex.** Practice guides note that in the progression from rule-based health scores to ML prediction, logistic regression (easy to explain) and random forests (ensembles of many trees) are often more practical than deep neural networks — because customer success teams need to know "why this customer is at risk" before they can act[6-11] [third-party verified].

6.3 Health Scores: From Manual Scoring to Real-Time Signals

The health score is the core instrument of customer success: it merges product usage, support history, survey feedback, engagement behavior, and commercial signals into one composite metric that predicts how likely a customer is to renew, expand, or churn[6-06] [official claims].

Traditional health scores suffer from four big problems — choosing metrics, weighting them, setting thresholds, and adapting them across customer segments — all of which rely on human guesswork[6-11] [third-party verified]. AI upgrades them in three ways:

1. **More data sources**: beyond usage rates, incorporate sentiment analysis (the tone of emails, calls, and tickets), relationship dynamics, and billing behavior[6-05] [official claims];
2. **Real-time updates**: scores change as behavior changes, instead of waiting for a CSM's manual update cycle[6-05] [third-party verified];
3. **Predictive rather than descriptive**: shifting from "what is the customer's state right now" to "what will the customer do next."

The performance data: companies that adopt predictive AI health models improve retention by up to 2x and detect churn risk 25–40% faster[6-23] [third-party verified]. ChurnZero's annual survey offers a more sobering view: 73% of respondents admit that their current health scores cannot reliably predict churn[6-19] [third-party verified] — AI health scores are an opportunity, but most companies' health score systems are not there yet.

One methodological trap deserves to be singled out: **telemetry data is not the same as live intent.** Health scores look entirely at behavioral data (logins, clicks, usage), but a customer "using a lot" and "planning to renew" are two different things. ChurnZero's research shows that teams using dedicated CS platforms have significantly stronger churn prediction, because they incorporate relationship and sentiment data[6-19] [third-party verified]. AI-driven voice of customer (VoC) programs are an attempt to fill this gap: AI-moderated conversational surveys that collect qualitative data at the scale of hundreds of respondents — where a traditional in-depth study can only cover 20–30 people, AI interviews expand that by an order of magnitude, and respondents say more than they would filling out a questionnaire[6-18] [official claims].

6.4 Expansion: The Revenue CSMs Miss

Retention is defense; expansion is offense. Net revenue retention (NRR) is the gold-standard metric for whether customers are buying more over time: an NRR above 100% means revenue from existing customers is growing, and the company can grow without acquiring new customers.

NRR benchmarks by tier (Statisfy 2025–2026): best-practice level above 130% (usage-based platforms such as Snowflake, Datadog, and HubSpot), Top Quartile at 115–130%, and median at 100–115%[6-20] [vendor benchmark data]. NRR ties directly into valuation: companies with NRR of 100–110% are valued at roughly 6x revenue, and those above 120% can reach 8x or more[6-15] [official claims].

How does AI help customer success teams find expansion opportunities? Gainsight introduced the concept of the CSQL (Customer Success Qualified Lead): AI scans the entire customer portfolio against cross-account, cross-year historical data and automatically generates expansion leads[6-09] [official claims]. Planhat breaks out six

types of expansion signals: usage thresholds, recent positive sentiment, freshly completed milestones, depth of feature adoption, organizational growth signals, and approaching contract expiry[6-03] [official claims].

The key insight: **expansion readiness is not a single signal but multiple signals aligning at the right moment** — high usage alone does not mean a customer is ready to expand; high usage plus recent positive sentiment plus a freshly completed milestone does[6-03] [official claims]. Thrive's case: after using AI to identify expansion opportunities, license upsell rose 24%[6-03] [official claims].

ChurnZero's sixth annual industry survey (covering nearly 800 customer success and post-sales leaders) reveals a correlation at the team level: companies using dedicated CS platforms have significantly higher NRR (98% for CSM teams vs. 90% without a platform)[6-01] [official research]. Tools are not a silver bullet, but teams that use them do perform better.

6.5 Win-Back: The Underrated Growth Lever

Churned customers have not really gone away — many are just "asleep." Win-back is the most underrated function in customer success.

The quantified advantages of AI win-back are striking: AI-driven reactivation campaigns win back around 22% of customers, versus 5–10% for generic reactivation emails; email open rates are 38% versus 15–20%[6-07] [third-party verified]. A case in point is a DTC skincare brand: annual revenue of $4.2 million, with growth stalled after advertising costs rose from $32 to $48 within 18 months; an audit found that 8,200 customers (62% of the customer file) had not purchased in over 90 days. After reactivation through segmented automated sequences, 15.3% of dormant customers were awakened, recovering $187,000[6-26] [official claims].

But win-back has an economics precondition, and Gruv's framework spells it out clearly: **win-back is not inherently cheaper than new customer acquisition — it is only worth investing in when "recovered net contribution" outperforms net new acquisition on the same basis.** Opens, clicks, and restarts are just signals; "paying customers coming back on a contribution basis" is the real proof[6-29] [vendor analytical framework]. Recurly's data is also a caution: customers who churned and are re-activated show lower retention afterwards (re-acquisition rates fall from 4.1% to around 2.8%)[6-29] [vendor analytical framework] — won-back customers are more likely to churn again and need continuous stewardship.

6.6 From Health Scores to Triggers

The score's position has changed. A methodology article from ChurnZero argues that customer health scoring has evolved from a static reporting tool into a real-time system of action: AI expands what is measurable — not just what customers did in the product, but how they feel about the relationship and which relationships are strengthening or deteriorating — and it changes what teams can do in response, turning the health score from a report into a trigger that can generate recommended actions and increasingly execute them autonomously. That forces customer success leaders to fundamentally reset three things: how the score is designed, what data feeds it, and what it is allowed to do (permissions and automation boundaries)[6-06] [official claims]. A risk is embedded here: once a scoring system begins automatically triggering customer-facing actions, metric bias is amplified directly into customer intrusion, so model confidence, human review thresholds, and action reversibility must be defined alongside the scoring design — which also explains earlier research finding that roughly 73% of health scores fail at churn prediction (see Section 6.3).

Priorities are converging too. Drawing on its customer success data, Gainsight notes that CS teams operate in a far harsher environment than a few years ago: customer bases keep growing, products are more complex, expectations for retention and expansion are higher, and budgets have not grown proportionally. Its customers adopt AI at a rate 13% higher than non-customers, with significantly more usage in high-impact scenarios such as churn prediction and sentiment analysis; the author concludes that leading CS teams do not rely on individual effort or incremental improvement but build "systems" that scale AI and agentic capabilities consistently[6-30] [third-party verified].

What does such a system look like in production? A published AI CS agent case study offers a full set of numbers: the customer, a B2B SaaS company, cut churn by 40% within six months, added $1.2 million in net new expansion ARR, raised accounts per CSM by 2.4 times, reduced quarterly business review preparation from four hours to 35 minutes per session, and pushed NRR above 115% within two quarters. The mechanism turns expansion from "occasional luck" into systematic output: the CSM arrives already carrying agent-assembled data, talking points, and business context[6-31] [official claims]. The boundary must be stated: this is a vendor-reported customer case without third-party audit or methodology disclosure, so the figures should be read as vendor claims rather than verifiable benchmarks.

Don't forget the water level. These tools operate in a harder environment: Bain observed a broad software index fall about 15% in a few weeks and roughly 25% from its 12-month high, triggered directly by a frontier model company releasing an agent product for general office work. The installed customer base has held so far — average gross retention remains 90% or better — but net revenue retention has stalled, penetration curves for core functionality have flattened, and seat growth has lost force as a growth driver; meanwhile buyer attention and budgets are shifting from incremental software purchases to AI tools and transformation programs[6-32] [third-party verified]. In other words, customer success teams must defend not only customers but the very question of what customers are willing to pay for.

6.7 After Churn Attribution Is Handed to an Agent

Churn prediction answers "who will leave" but not "why they left" — and the latter has long depended on CSMs recalling events after the fact and backfilling documentation, the step most easily skipped in customer success. In 2026, that step began being taken over by agents.

Forecasting beforehand extends into attribution afterward. ChurnZero released a Retrospective agent: after an account is flagged as churned, it reads the account's full history, classifies the reason against the company's existing churn-reason set, attaches a confidence score to the analysis, and drafts a churn analysis report for the CSM to review; the design goal is to cut the time CSMs spend on post-hoc documentation and let CS leaders identify churn patterns faster[6-33][official claims]. That combination of "confidence score plus human review" is worth noting: classification goes to the model, judgment stays with people. It is a relatively restrained form of deployment.

The tool is the precondition; authority is the variable. After rebuilding its CS function on a customer success platform, medical AI company Lunit International reports NRR of 110%, annual churn of 1.5%, and 80% of revenue coming from existing customers; more informative is its VP of Customer Success's description of how the team changed — from "a group of people new to customer success" into "a group of business owners with an entrepreneurial mindset," because CSMs began leading renewals, joining contract negotiations, and driving expansion[6-34][official claims]. The contrast makes the point: differences in NRR often come not from analytical capability but from CSMs' authority and the metrics they are measured on (accountable for renewal and expansion, not for satisfaction).

Retention prediction is being turned into a tradable media product. On the retail side, Sam's Club launched a set of targeting products in its advertising business: brands can build their own predictive audiences and segments for churn prevention and declining brand loyalty, and can target members entering the replacement window for long-cycle goods such as televisions and refrigerators[6-35] [third-party verified]. The traditional approach retargets on recent purchases; these products front-load predictions of who will leave and who will buy. When retention prediction can be bought and sold inside an ad system, it has moved from an internal tool to an industry-wide capability.

But no amount of prediction replaces one judgment: are they still using it? SaaStr's Jason Lemkin uses his own decision to stop using Adobe Marketo as an example (he was one of Marketo's first ten customers and recommended it to clients for years): the product was no longer actually used by his team — unsubscribe handling was still broken, daily API rate limits were the biggest problem, and historical data was retained for only six months. His conclusion is that a discount can keep the contract but not the usage; it only postpones churn and pollutes the NRR metric. The criterion should be "is the customer still genuinely using it," not "did they renew"[6-36] [third-party verified].

The same logic has a more extreme version in consumer hardware: the life-or-death line for children's AI hardware is not sales but 180-day retention. Yuan Lin (Chinese: 袁琳), founder of Tinglixiong (Chinese: 听力熊), argues there is a fault line between the buyer and the user — parents pay for functional value (learning, safety), while children decide whether to keep using it based on emotional value (whether it understands them, whether the interaction is fun); if the sale completes but the delivery does not, the product can be shelved within ten days. The real moat is also not hardware but content and interaction (age-appropriate language, guided answers, a personality that keeps growing, safety boundaries)[6-37][third-party verified]. **The retention curve is decided by the user, and the user is often not the payer** — a rule that holds in B2B too, where it simply becomes "the people using it are not the people signing the contract."

6.8 The Leaky Bucket: A Price List for Retention in AI-Native Apps

Chapter 6 is about keeping customers. In 2026 a large enough cross-section appeared to turn "we can't retain them" into a table you can look up by price tier.

By customer type. ChartMogul crawled and classified the websites of 3,500 software companies (about 2,700 B2B SaaS, 600 B2C SaaS, and 200 AI-native): median NRR is 82% for B2B SaaS (97% at the upper quartile), only 49% for B2C, while AI-native companies have worse GRR than B2C (40%) with comparable NRR (48%)[6-38] [third-party verified].

More informative still is the split by price, because it puts a scale on "the cheaper it is, the less it sticks." Among AI-native products priced above $250 a month, GRR is 70% and NRR 85%, already close to B2B SaaS levels; in the $50–249 band, GRR is 45% and NRR 61%, roughly 15 points below B2B; and below $50 a month, GRR is just 23% and NRR 32%, worse than both B2B and B2C. **The structure says the retention problem in AI-native products is not that "AI products don't work" but that the afflictions of low-price self-serve products have been amplified by AI's adoption curve** — low barriers bring in a flood of "just trying it" users, and nothing in the free or cheap tiers creates enough relationship or switching cost to keep them.

A second cross-section supplies the absolute water levels by segment. Yesoptimist's SaaS growth playbook reports NRR of 118% for enterprise accounts (above $100K ACV), 108% for mid-market, and 97% for SMB; median growth for private SaaS compressing to about 25%, with distribution the only durable moat; and one very concrete recommendation — **the highest-ROI retention action is often fixing "involuntary churn"** (failed payments and failed renewals, the kind that can be recovered), because it brings no new acquisition cost[6-39][third-party verified].

The product-side playbook has been written down too. Observing that B2C AI apps are mostly leaky buckets (retention and engagement significantly weaker than mature consumer apps), Bessemer worries B2B will follow and offers seven product-level moats: embed the product in the customer's existing platform (via API or plug-in, without touching legacy systems), show up where the user already is (Slack, Copilot,

Excel, a browser sidebar), produce tangible work artifacts, extend value along the chain, build moats from proprietary or new data, go multimodal, and use platform architecture to amplify network effects[6-40][third-party verified].

Put the three together and the implication for customer-success teams is this: **half of retention work is not "winning customers back" but is decided the moment you choose the customer and design the pricing.** For a $30-a-month AI product with self-serve credit-card signup and zero human touchpoints, the NRR curve is written on the day of purchase; what needs changing is not the success team's playbook but the packaging and the embedding.

6.9 The Argument About Health-Score Inputs: Whom Do Static Scores Miss?

Section 6.6 described health scores moving "from report to trigger." In 2026 the debate moved one step upstream: **the problem is not the degree of automation but what the inputs are.**

First, the baseline. One analysis cites Gainsight's 2025 Customer Success Benchmark to report that 74% of SaaS companies still rely on manual or semi-manual health assessment. Its core argument is that most automated health scores run on weighted sums of product telemetry, support volume, and NPS, and **telemetry can only tell you what an account did, never why** — yet churn comes precisely from the "why": the key champion left, the sponsor lost the budget fight, the problem the product solved no longer exists[6-41][third-party verified].

Second, the miss rate of static scores. One vendor analysis gives a usable order of magnitude: static health scores (logins plus tickets plus weighted NPS) miss 40–60% of high-risk accounts, for three hard reasons — they use lagging indicators (by the time NPS drops and tickets spike, the damage is done), they weight equally across segments (daily logins by a startup and a monthly review by an enterprise mean entirely different things), and they omit signals (contract terms, champion changes, competitor mentions, external events are all absent from the model). Its proposed alternative integrates five input types: product analytics (feature depth rather than logins alone), support signals (sentiment, escalations, topic clustering), engagement (declines typically appear three to six months before cancellation), contract and financial data, and external signals[6-42][vendor content].

Third, a piece that arranges those five inputs by lead time. DevRev identifies "the gap between predict and act": most tools produce signals but cannot trigger a response, and **a warning without an intervention amounts to a cleaner version of the old dashboard**. Its five-layer signal stack, with lead times, is billing 0–30 days, CRM 30–60 days, product usage 30–90 days, engagement 60–120 days, and support data 90–180 days; support data is often the most leading indicator (it exposes friction before a full churn), but non-support platforms like ChurnZero, Gainsight, and Pendo Predict cannot see native support signals and must integrate them, which brings latency and fragmentation. Its proposal is to unify the signals in a knowledge graph and let agents execute the corresponding actions against five risk tiers[6-43][vendor content].

What this section offers is a checking order, not another score. First ask whether the inputs contain the "why" (relationships and external events), then whether the lead time is short enough (can the earliest signal appear 90 days out), and only then ask about the automation's execution rate. **Get the order wrong and you end up with the more refined report described in Section 6.6.**

6.10 Summary

The AI transformation of retention and expansion is, at its core, customer success upgrading from "watching customers by hand" to "AI early warning + human judgment":

1. **Churn prediction**: behavioral data is more honest than surveys — against the $136.8 billion churn black hole, AI can detect signals months before a customer leaves;
2. **Health scores**: from manual scoring to real-time signals, yet 73% of companies' health scores are still unreliable — telemetry data is not live intent, and sentiment and relationship dimensions need to be added;
3. **Expansion**: CSQL turns "customer success" into a revenue engine — the valuation gap between a company at 130% NRR and one at 100% NRR is an order of magnitude;
4. **Win-back**: AI win-back rates are 22% versus 5–10% for mass sends, but won-back customers are more prone to churning again — the economics need to be worked out.

With this chapter, all five stages of the customer lifecycle (acquisition–conversion–service–retention–expansion) have been covered. But every one of these engines depends on a single foundation: customer data. The next chapter covers the AI CRM and the data foundation — where the fuel for these engines comes from.

Chapter 7 The Foundation: AI CRM and Customer Data

The acquisition, conversion, service, and retention covered in the previous chapters are all engines. This chapter is about the engines' fuel — customer data — and the system that carries it: the CRM.

7.1 A Counterintuitive Fact: The Bottleneck of AI CRM Is Not AI

A counterintuitive conclusion has been circulating in the CRM statistics community in 2026: **the main cause of AI CRM project failure is data quality, not the AI technology itself**[7-03][third-party verified]. As early as 2025, Gartner predicted that by 2026, more than 40% of AI CRM projects would fail or be delayed because of data problems[7-03][third-party verified].

It makes sense once you think about it. No matter how smart the AI is, if the customer data fed to it is dirty, fragmented, and stale, the predictions and action recommendations it produces are garbage. Many companies buy the most expensive AI CRM only to discover that their customer data is scattered across a dozen systems: sales uses one, service uses another, finance uses a third, and the same customer has a different name, status, and history in each.

That is why this chapter runs in reverse order: data (the fuel) first, then the CRM (the engine compartment).

7.2 The Data Foundation: Identity Resolution Is the Bedrock

What a large share of failed CX/AI projects have in common is not tools or data volume but **the lack of a reliable customer identity layer**[7-04][third-party verified]. For many companies, the "Customer 360" is only a loosely stitched-together reporting view, not an operable identity layer — the same customer has one ID on the website, another in the app, and a third in the in-store membership system, and the AI cannot recognize them as the same person at all.

AI identity resolution solves this: it combines deterministic matching (strong identifiers such as email, phone number, and membership ID) with probabilistic matching (device fingerprints, behavioral patterns) to unify scattered customer identities[7-04][third-party verified]. It sounds like a technical detail, but it decides whether every application built on top can work at all — get identity resolution wrong, and personalization recommends to the wrong person, churn alerts watch the wrong customer, and expansion signals are all noise.

The CDP (customer data platform) is the data hub that sits above the identity layer. By 2026, the CDP has evolved from an optional tool into the infrastructure of modern customer experience: unifying first-party data is no longer a competitive advantage but a prerequisite for real-time personalization, privacy compliance, and cross-channel orchestration[7-24][third-party verified]. Tealium's annual survey (1,200 professionals worldwide) puts concrete numbers behind this: CDP users' goal attainment rate is 92%, and 84% say the CDP has simplified their AI projects[7-01] [official research].

7.3 Intent Data: Seeing the "Invisible Shopping"

As Chapter 3 covered, roughly 70% of a B2B buyer's purchase journey is completed anonymously before the buyer ever contacts a vendor[3-34][official claims]. Intent data is how companies see this "invisible shopping": platforms aggregate behavioral data across thousands of websites and review sites to identify "who is intensively researching a certain category."

The market is already sizable: the B2B intent data tools market reached $4.49 billion in 2026 and is projected to reach $20.89 billion by 2035 (a 16.6% compound annual growth rate); 91% of B2B marketers use intent data to prioritize sales[7-28] [third-party verified]. 71% of B2B marketers use third-party intent data in ABM (up from just 55% in 2022)[7-09][third-party verified].

Performance benchmarks exist as well: accounts reached via intent data convert at 21.3%, versus 8.4% for the control group[7-09][third-party verified]. Blue Yonder is the case in point: the supply chain software company, with billion-dollar-level annual revenue, upgraded 6sense from "viewing insights on single accounts" into a company-wide ABM engine, lifting accounts in the purchasing stage by 40% and cutting CPL (cost per qualified lead) to $145[7-10][third-party verified].

But intent data has its pitfalls. Benchmark data shows a 62% validation failure rate for intent signals[7-09][third-party verified] — intent data is a "might be interested" signal, not a "definitely buying" fact. Platforms like Bombora are not cheap either, at $30K per year[7-29][third-party verified]. The right way to use intent data: treat it as the first-layer sieve for prioritization, combined with human sales judgment and content nurturing, rather than treating it directly as ready-to-close leads.

7.4 AI CRM: From a System of Record to a System of Action

The CRM is the operating system of customer operations. In the AI era, the CRM is undergoing a fundamental shift: **from a "System of Record" to a "System of Action."**

Traditional CRM is a system of record: salespeople log customer information, follow-up notes, and deal status, and the system's main value is "don't lose information." An AI-native CRM is a system of action: the system automatically captures every email, every call, and every meeting, keeps records fresh on its own, and prepares "next actions awaiting approval" for humans — AI does the work, people make the decisions[1-12][official claims].

Deng Yongfu (Chinese: 邓永富), president of Chinese CRM vendor Neocrm (Chinese: 销售易), draws the clearest dividing line: "AI CRM 1.0 is a CRM with AI added on; 2.0 is a CRM born for AI"[4-18][third-party verified]. This distinction shares its lineage with the AI-native vs. AI-assisted divide in Chapter 2: pasting on a band-aid versus growing it into the genes.

Where the major players stand:

Salesforce Agentforce: ARR of more than $1.5 billion, up over 240% year over year[7-07][third-party verified]. Salesforce's transformation is almost textbook-grade — it repositioned "Sales Cloud" from a tool into an AI agent platform, letting agents execute sales workflows directly.

HubSpot Breeze: in April 2026 it cut Breeze Customer Agent pricing from $1 per session to $0.50 per resolved session — charging for "resolved outcomes," not "number of conversations"[7-15][third-party verified]. This is the "outcome-based pricing" described in Chapter 4 landing in the CRM arena.

Fenxiangxiaoke ShareAI (Chinese: 纷享销客 **ShareAI)**: claims to have provided AI-native/agentic CRM to 6,000+ mid-sized and large enterprises[7-31][official claims]. Agentic CRM in the Chinese market is forging its own path — an AI PaaS foundation plus industry intelligence.

Microsoft: eight AI products with "Sales" in their names, one of which was renamed six times in three years (Viva Sales → Sales Copilot → Copilot for Sales → ... → Sales in Microsoft)[7-27][third-party verified]. Even the giants are iterating fast.

The consensus across the whole CRM market: **the biggest bottleneck for AI CRM is data, not technology** — which is exactly why this chapter covers data before the CRM[7-03][third-party verified].

7.5 Privacy and Compliance: The Ceiling of Customer Data

More data, stronger AI — but there are red lines on how data may be used. Privacy compliance is the ceiling of AI-powered customer lifecycle management, and this section needs to say it plainly.

The regulatory landscape: GDPR governs Europe, CCPA/CPRA governs California, and PIPL governs China. The core principle of marketing data compliance: in the vast majority of cases, the safest path is to provide notice and obtain consent[7-02][third-party verified]. King & Wood Mallesons sets out the essentials of omni-channel retail marketing under the PIPL: behavioral data collected automatically may identify individuals once it is linked with other information, and therefore constitutes personal information; data provided voluntarily by users requires full disclosure, and general consent must be distinguished from separate consent[7-33][third-party verified].

New solutions to the technology-versus-privacy balance are emerging. Federated learning lets vast numbers of edge devices participate in model training with their local data — only model parameters leave the devices, while raw data never leaves them[7-25][third-party verified]. At the same time, AI is also helping companies stay compliant: 60% of large enterprises used AI to automate GDPR compliance processes in 2025[7-05][third-party verified].

Consumer attitudes are contradictory: 44% of consumers are disappointed when a brand fails to deliver a personalized experience, while 70% worry about how their data is being used[7-05][third-party research]. Those running AI-powered customer lifecycle

management must manage this pair of contradictions at the same time — the expectation of personalization and the worry about privacy are two sides of the same customers.

7.6 Segmentation and Reach: A Postmortem on 4.04%

Earlier sections of this chapter described how to build the data foundation. This section takes the opposite view: how concrete the losses are when the foundation is missing.

One company's private-domain assets comprised more than 80,000 enterprise-WeChat contacts, over 100,000 mini-program users, and more than 150,000 mobile-number customers. In a "new member exclusive benefits" campaign all 693 new members were issued the benefit, yet only 28 actually received the notification — a reach rate of 4.04%. The offer itself was flawless: members who received it converted from visit to purchase at 99.86%, and more than 30% went from visit to payment. The bottleneck was not the offer design but **who the message reached**[7-34] [third-party verified].

The root cause is entirely typical: the platform's built-in segmentation was too coarse — just three behavioral buckets (visited without paying, added to cart without paying, ordered without paying) plus four fixed RFM labels. A single "visited without paying" pool could hold more than 100,000 people, lumping together someone who browsed 20 product pages with someone who tapped in on a whim; and the labels were static within the window, with no predictive power at all. The rebuild combined three-dimensional dynamic segmentation with block-based operations, intelligent channel matching, and data-driven iteration; the store's repurchase rate rose 5% year over year, and the estimated reach rate went from 4.04% to above 10%. The author's three retrospective lessons are more valuable than the methodology: keep the MVP more focused; put channel coverage first (part of the 4.04% root cause was that users had not added the enterprise-WeChat contact, had not authorized the mini-program, and SMS was blocked — the reachable channel set itself was incomplete, so "nudge users to add the contact and subscribe" must be part of the project from day one); and validate scoring weights early with small-batch A/B tests rather than relying entirely on historical behavior analysis.

This gap has a new AI-era version. Research on China's GEO market notes that marketing teams generally want to use existing CDP data to build cognition in AI scenarios, but CDP data is largely accumulated by ad platforms and covers only existing customers, missing the new cognition formed in AI scenarios[3-65]. Both cases point to the same conclusion: a gap in the data foundation does not show up as "the system is broken" — it shows up as "it looked like we sent it, but it never arrived," and, in new entry-point formats, as "nobody knows who you are."

7.7 The Middle Layer of Attribution: When Users Arrive Through Someone Else's AI

Section 7.1 argued that the bottleneck in AI CRM is not AI but data. This section adds the newest and hardest-to-solve data gap: **an untraceable intermediary has appeared in the acquisition chain.**

Why attribution suddenly fails. Take Meituan's AI agent Xiaomei (Chinese: 小美) connecting into Tencent Yuanbao: the entry point through which users obtain services is migrating from "opening the app" to "saying an instruction inside someone else's AI," but for developers and growth teams it is impossible to tell whether a user converted after guidance from a Yuanbao conversation or through Meituan's own search and recommendations, or even what the user actually saw in that AI dialogue — traditional attribution based on source, click, and install package fails outright in this kind of chain, leaving ROI on cross-ecosystem agents impossible to calculate[7-35] [third-party verified]. This is not a technical problem but an accounting problem: AI entry points bring increment, and an unaccountable ledger. That is why Chinese brands working with AI entry points must simultaneously demand verifiable passback (dedicated parameters, passphrases, agent IDs, mini-program paths), or channel budgets will have nowhere to land.

The starting point of the CDP is moving earlier. For more than a decade the CDP solved the problem of consolidating customer data scattered across marketing, e-commerce, analytics, and service systems into a unified customer view. A more radical claim is that the mission remains important but its premise has changed: AI demands real-time decisions, privacy regulation has reshaped how data is collected, and customers move seamlessly across devices and anonymous sessions — so the first step of a next-generation CDP is not consolidating "existing customer data" but collecting the behavioral and contextual signals that precede the data's existence[7-36]

[third-party verified]. Put more bluntly: **in the AI era, "designing the data entry point" sits closer to the source of the problem than "building the data warehouse."**

Customer signals are becoming a data layer agents can call. 6sense's MCP server moved from open beta to general availability, connecting its buying signals, intent data, and account intelligence directly into everyday AI tools such as Claude, ChatGPT, and Copilot Studio so users can query account context with natural-language prompts; with the September product release, the vendor began formally supporting Sales Intelligence users, bringing account context and contact acquisition into AI workflows[7-37][official claims]. The same direction is appearing on the CRM side: at Dreamforce, Salesforce launched AIforce, positioned as a "live interface layer" that brings internal data, workflows, business logic, semantics, permissions, security, and governance into whatever interface people and agents actually work in, replacing the fixed UI[7-38][official claims].

Read the three together and the direction of the foundation rebuild is clear: **from "a page employees must open" to "a capability and data layer agents can call."** That drags two very practical consequences along with it — the seat-based pricing model of CRM, and the boundaries of the data asset (once data is to be read by external agents, "who authorizes it and who audits it" becomes part of the product).

7.8 The Directory and Shelf of Agents: The MCP Registry and AI App Marketplaces

Acquisition entry points are changing, and so are the entry points for distributing tools. As customer operations increasingly start from AI, **"can an agent retrieve your capability" becomes a new directory position** — yet another outward expansion of the foundation layer.

The public directory came first. The official Model Context Protocol registry (registry.modelcontextprotocol.io) is positioned as an open catalog and API of publicly available MCP servers, meant to improve their discoverability and implementation and to become a "source of truth" on which sub-registries can be built; it continuously lists MCP server versions submitted by developers and vendors worldwide, ordered by

most recent update[7-39][official claims]. The acquisition implication is direct: being listed, retrieved, and recommended is becoming the new directory-style distribution slot of the agent era.

Cloud vendors turned it into an app marketplace. In September 2026 Alibaba Cloud released version 2.0 of its "Fanhua Program" for AI product partners, upgrading its cloud marketplace into an "AI application marketplace" — from a traditional software-and-services trading platform into a one-stop platform gathering large models, AI applications, and industry solutions across education, finance, healthcare, retail, manufacturing, research, and gaming, and across scenarios such as customer service, marketing, and digital employees; version 2.0 focuses on five directions: Skills (domain skill products), data (industry and professional datasets), connectors (connecting CRM, ERP, and other SaaS applications within authorized scope), Agents (commercial agent products), and industry co-creation[7-40][third-party verified]. This in effect commoditizes the foundation layer — customer-operations connectors, industry datasets, and agents are packaged, listed, and procured on demand.

Underlying capabilities are being packaged as standard components. At Agents Week 2026, Cloudflare released a batch of agent infrastructure: Project Think (a preview of a next-generation Agents SDK that lets agents think, act, and persist), an experimental voice pipeline for the Agents SDK (continuous STT/TTS in about 30 lines of server-side code), Cloudflare Email Service (in beta, letting agents send and receive email natively), Agent Memory (a managed persistent-memory service), AI Search (a search primitive for agents supporting hybrid retrieval and relevance weighting), and Browser Run (with live view, human intervention, CDP access, and session recording, at four times the concurrency limit)[7-41][official claims]. The trend is cloud vendors packaging memory, search, voice, email, and browsers into standard components any agent can call.

In one sentence: **when "who gets called by an agent" becomes the distribution logic, directories, marketplaces, and standard components become the next foundation layer of customer operations** — they don't generate leads directly, but they decide whether leads can find you in the AI world.

7.9 CRM Agent-Readiness: Choosing the Orchestration Layer, and Who Owns MCP

Section 7.8 covered "the directory and shelf of agents." This round adds two concrete questions at the foundation layer: **which mainstream CRM is better suited to be the agents' orchestration layer, and who governs MCP now.**

Scored for "agent readiness," the two are close but their weaknesses differ. One evaluation across seven dimensions gives an overall 4.0 versus 3.9: Salesforce (Agentforce) has more than 18,500 customers, over 3 billion agent workflows a month, and Data Cloud federating more than 100 data sources, with strong governance and integration, but slow deployment, high AI cost (about $2 per conversation plus a Data Cloud licence), and MCP still in pilot (Agentforce 3.0); HubSpot (Breeze) is natively embedded across all Hubs including the free tier, deploys in minutes, and is the first major CRM to ship a production MCP server, with strong interoperability, but its data is confined to its own Hubs[7-42][third-party verified]. **The most useful thing about the comparison is not the ranking but the way it splits selection into two independent questions — orchestration capability (who can manage a fleet of agents) and data reachability (how much data the agents can see) — whose weaknesses barely overlap.**

Capability and cost belong in the same view. Another comparison reports that Agentforce can autonomously resolve about 66% of inquiries and supports more than 6,000 concurrent interactions, that Breeze wins on cost and adoption (including a free tier), and that HubSpot has already moved its agents to outcome-based pricing — $0.50 per resolved conversation and $1 per qualified lead. It also states an easily overlooked precondition: **AI predictive scoring is affected by CRM data hygiene** — when lifecycle stages are inconsistent or tracking is incomplete, scores are "confident but misleading," and the same holds for both systems, so audit data hygiene first[7-43][third-party verified]. Extending the conclusion of Section 8.8: **AI will not save a bad process, and it will not save dirty data — it will simply state the dirty data's conclusions more fluently.**

MCP has gone from one company's protocol to a foundation asset. WorkOS's overview traces the path: Anthropic proposed MCP in November 2024 and it has become the de facto standard for connecting AI to the real world, adopted by OpenAI, Google DeepMind, Microsoft, and thousands of development teams, with roughly 97 million monthly downloads across just the Python and TypeScript SDKs; in

December 2025 Anthropic donated MCP to the Agentic AI Foundation under the Linux Foundation, with OpenAI and Block as co-founders and AWS, Google, and others participating[7-44][third-party verified]. **That materially lowers the standards risk in the integration layer — enterprises can invest in MCP as long-term infrastructure without fearing a single vendor's change of course.**

But the registry, a new species, has no governance rules yet. InfoWorld's analysis notes the shift in paradigm: developers no longer hand-write API calls and users no longer type credentials into a GUI to "click integrate"; instead **agentic systems look up available MCP servers themselves and initiate tool calls autonomously**. Registries are therefore becoming the "integration catalogue for AI agents," while their admission, authentication, and revocation mechanisms are still under debate[7-45][third-party verified]. For enterprise customer operations the implication is direct: **if agents go find tools in a catalogue themselves, then being listed in that catalogue becomes a new form of channel admission** — the shelf problem from Section 7.8, extended from app stores to protocol registries.

7.10 Summary

Three takeaways on the foundation:

1. **Data before AI** — the main cause of AI CRM project failure is data quality; identity resolution is the bedrock, and the CDP is the data hub;
2. **Intent data sees the invisible shopping** — 70% of purchases happen anonymously, yet intent signals carry a 62% validation failure rate; it is a sieve, not a conclusion;
3. **The CRM shifts from record to action** — Agentforce's $1.5 billion ARR, HubSpot charging by outcome, Neocrm "born for AI": AI-native is the dividing line;
4. **Compliance is the ceiling** — consent is the floor, federated learning is a new solution, and the expectation of personalization coexists with the worry about privacy.

With the foundation done, it is time to talk about people. Next chapter: organization — who drives these engines.

Chapter 8 Organization: People, Skills, and Change

The previous chapters were about which tools to use. This chapter is about who uses them and how things change. Organizational change is the slowest, the most expensive, and the most easily underestimated part of AI-powered customer lifecycle management.

8.1 Three CEOs, Three Extreme Answers

Between 2023 and 2026, three CEOs answered the same question in three completely different ways: "In the AI era, what should my organization do?"

IgniteTech's Eric Vaughan chose to tear it all down and start over. This enterprise software group with nine-figure annual revenue concluded that generative AI was an "existential"-level shift, and looking around he saw a team that was not ready. So he acted: he replaced nearly 80% of his employees within a year. The process was full of resistance and even sabotage, but two years later he said: "I would do it again"[12-03][third-party verified].

Salesforce's Marc Benioff chose to use AI to cut headcount directly. He acknowledged in interviews that after AI agents went live, he cut the customer support team from 9,000 people to 5,000 and cut support costs by 17%. He said it bluntly: "I need fewer heads"[12-04][third-party verified].

Intercom's Eoghan McCabe chose to bet the company on an AI transformation. He returned after a four-year absence from the CEO role due to illness, saw growth had stalled, and in "founder mode" bet the company on AI: cut 40% of employees, built a Fin prototype in six weeks, and growth climbed back above 300%[12-09][third-party verified].

The three stories have something in common: all of them acknowledged that AI is structural, all of them touched headcount, and all of them went through pain. The difference lies in the approach: IgniteTech's 80% workforce renewal was radical, Salesforce's 4,000 cuts were direct cost reduction, and Intercom's layoffs were part of a transformation — its growth engine switched from "human-delivered service" to "AI products."

None of these answers is the standard answer. But stacked together, the three point to a clear reality: **organizational change in AI-powered customer lifecycle management cannot get around the question of "what happens to the people."** This chapter breaks that question into three parts: how GTM is rebuilt (8.2), what new skills people need (8.3), and why change fails (8.4-8.5).

8.2 Rebuilding GTM: AI Agents Enter the Revenue Organization

GTM (go-to-market) is the umbrella term for the revenue organization — sales, marketing, and customer success all sit inside it. McKinsey's 2026 report spelled out the impact of AI on GTM most clearly: based on its B2B Pulse Survey covering nearly 4,000 buyers and sellers in 13 countries, most B2B companies are "doing something," but only a few have captured material value from AI — because of fragmented data, weak insights, manual processes, siloed teams, and poor change management[8-20] [third-party verified].

The gap between high-growth companies and the rest has already opened up in investment: high-growth companies invest roughly 3x as much in AI as others (71% vs. 25% of respondents reporting high AI investment)[8-20][third-party verified].

One new role taking shape is **RevOps managing a fleet of AI agents**. RevSure's research playbook argues that agents read and write to the systems RevOps governs, consume budget from the pipelines RevOps reports on, and escalate to queues RevOps staffs — so managing the agent fleet lands on RevOps "by plan or by accident"[8-38][official claims]. The data shows the payoff of this path: after ICONIQ's customers deployed AI agent fleets, their ARR/FTE (revenue per employee) rose from $370,000 to $640,000[8-38][third-party verified].

Gartner's warning is also worth hearing: sales operations leaders are being asked to drive growth, underpin GTM change, and keep pace with AI transformation, yet they rarely get a chance to pause and reassess their own capabilities[8-12][third-party verified]. The first hurdle of organizational change is often that the people responsible for the change are not ready themselves.

8.3 Sales' New Skills: From "Knowing More" to "Reading the Room"

Bain's 2025 report served up an uncomfortable number: **salespeople spend only about 25% of their time actually selling to customers** — the remaining 75% is eaten by meeting preparation, data entry, internal coordination, and other work that "revolves around selling but creates no value." If AI can take over these tasks, it could double selling time; at the same time, AI lifts conversion rates at every stage of the funnel, and compounding across stages could raise win rates by 30%[8-13] [third-party verified].

Once AI takes over "knowing more" (product knowledge, competitive comparisons, script templates), the sales differentiator must shift. Seismic's judgment: the sales differentiator moves from "knowing more" to "reading the room, earning trust, exercising judgment, and adapting quickly" — the winners will not be the teams that automate the most, but the teams that upskill the fastest[8-18][third-party verified].

Mercuri International's research identifies "15 core sales competencies on the rise" and finds that four in five executives believe generative AI will reshape the sales role[8-03][third-party research]. Vivun and Gartner's forecasts are more specific: by 2028, AI will close 70% of traditional sales-cycle steps; by 2031, 35% of organizations will bring EQ (emotional intelligence) metrics into sales evaluations[8-11][third-party verified]. Sales evaluation shifting from "number of calls" to "quality of relationships" is inevitable in the AI era — because AI can handle the quantity, and quality is where the value of people lies.

There is also a neglected shortfall at the skills level: Mercuri's 2025 research shows that only 9-15% of salespeople are confident in their AI literacy[8-03][third-party research]. The tools get rolled out, but people do not know how to use them — this is the most common hidden failure in organizational change.

8.4 AI Sales Training: An Underrated Lever

If people need new skills, training is a hard requirement. AI sales role-play is the fastest-growing training category of 2026: it uses large models plus voice synthesis to simulate realistic customer scenarios and run immersive conversational practice with salespeople — simulating customer objections, needs discovery, and competitive comparisons[8-16][third-party verified].

Why is AI role-play needed? Because human coaching resources are pitifully scarce: frontline sales managers spend only 5-8% of their time coaching (at most 3 hours in a 40-hour workweek), and spread across a team of five, a new hire gets under 40 minutes of manager coaching per week during the critical ramp period[8-08][official claims].

The results data for AI role-play: - **Hyperbound**: helped Vanta cut new-sales ramp (from hire to productive output) time from 210 days to 72 days[8-08][official claims]; - **Second Nature**: after Oracle NetSuite customers used AI role-play, qualified opportunities rose 32%[8-33][third-party verified]; - Traditional training vs. AI role-play: AI role-play dramatically shortens the development cycle, can be repeated endlessly, and comes with objective scoring[8-16][third-party verified].

Category reviews covering more than eight platforms have already appeared (Knowlee and others), proof that this is not a small widget but a market taking shape[8-05][third-party verified]. The significance of AI sales training goes beyond "learning scripts" — it makes "practice" scalable for the first time: new hires can make enough mistakes in front of the AI before making them in front of real customers.

8.5 The Psychology of Change: Why 74% of Companies Are Stuck in Pilots

The tools are bought and the training is done — so why do most AI-powered customer lifecycle management programs still get stuck in pilots?

BCG's report *Where's the Value in AI?* (surveying 1,000 CxOs across 59 countries and more than 20 industries) offers an attribution: only 26% of companies have the ability to move beyond proof of concept and deliver real value, and 74% have yet to see visible value from AI — **roughly 70% of implementation barriers come from "people," not from technology or algorithms**[8-21][official claims].

Gartner's data is just as striking: only one in three (32%) mid-to-senior business leaders believe their most recent change initiative achieved "healthy change adoption"; a 2025 survey of more than 2,850 employees found that 79% have low trust in change[8-24][official claims].

Resistance from people takes several typical forms: **fear of displacement** ("is AI coming for my job?"), **going through the motions** (agreeing in meetings, not using the tools afterward), and **immune responses** (the organization's existing processes

and incentive systems instinctively reject new practices). Intercom's Eoghan McCabe said something on Lenny's Podcast that every change agent should hear: an AI transformation is not just swapping tools — it is swapping the company's "operating system." Cutting 40% of employees was not the goal; making the people who remained believe "we are an AI company" was[12-09][third-party verified].

Change management has no silver bullet, but several principles have been repeatedly validated: 1. **Start at the top**: the team only believes when the CEO personally uses AI and personally sets the KPIs (Intercom's "founder mode"); 2. **Give anxiety an outlet**: tell the team clearly what AI takes over and what people will move toward (the skills map in Section 8.3 is that outlet); 3. **Let data speak**: run measurable ROI in the AI pilot first, then talk about scale (Greenway's controlled experiment: 800 accounts split into four groups, with a qualified-opportunity cost of $342 for the hybrid model vs. $588 for fully autonomous vs. $1,006 for purely human — the hybrid model's superior ROI is backed by a controlled experiment)[8-10][third-party verified]; 4. **Accept discomfort**: IgniteTech's 80% workforce replacement is not a template, but it reveals a fact — when change is "existential," gentle incrementalism can amount to a slow death.

8.6 FDE: The Intermediate State of AI Deployment

The previous five sections asked "whether to change." This section asks "who carries the change to the front line" — in the Chinese discourse on AI deployment, that role has a name: FDE, a forward deployed engineer.

The most complete field record is Datawhale's "FDE Case 100": 24 frontline interviews covering manufacturing, government, legal, logistics, retail, foreign trade, and e-commerce, all narrated in the first person by FDEs about "how they found the problem, understood the business, chose the technology, and made trade-offs under real constraints"[8-41] [third-party verified]. Spread the 24 cases out, and several recurring patterns emerge.

First, the problem is not technology but the ordering of "people — organization — data." An FDE on a state-owned enterprise project put it most bluntly: the difficulty ranking for AI deployment is "people are hardest, then the organization, then the data, and technology last"[8-41] [third-party verified]. This

matches the attribution in 8.5 — seven-tenths of the obstacles come from people. Several cases repeat one discipline: go on site and first see "how they actually work every day," rather than asking what model to use.

Second, acceptance criteria must be co-defined by the business and land in the workflow. In a case at a German parts manufacturer, the FDE turned the "high-frequency question list" compiled up front directly into the test set: document parsing at about 95% and question-recall fragment accuracy ≥80% counted as the technical path tentatively working; the proof of acceptance was not a good-looking demo but that the AI was wired into the company's existing training workflow[8-41] [third-party verified]. The case also yields a general anti-pattern warning: technical metrics must not be defined by the FDE behind closed doors.

Third, customer-operations scenarios are exactly the FDE's high-value zone. At an e-commerce team running TikTok creator operations, the FDE mapped the entire chain — creator outreach, product matching, sampling, content creation, fulfillment, data review — and had AI first solve "finding the right person" and "which product goes to which creator," cutting average fulfillment time from about a month to about 18 days; but one key step was left not fully automated — a single wrong sentence from a creator with millions of followers costs far more than the labor that automation would save, so human outreach was retained[8-41] [third-party verified]. At another non-standard manufacturing company, the pre-sales chain of drawing parsing, requirement decomposition, R&D collaboration, cost accounting, and quoting was handed to AI for structuring, with quotes matched back against the company's own rule base and manually calibrated per order, cutting the related workload by at least 50%[8-41] [third-party verified]. A small construction-equipment leasing company built both the acquisition entry point and quoting at once: large clients were left for the boss to judge personally, while small orders had the system collect requirements and compute a quote range by vehicle type, operator, fuel, distance, and job type, with AI handling the conversation and closing quickly inside the range[8-41] [third-party verified] — long-tail customers that used to be "un-catchable" are now caught by the system.

Fourth, don't "apply" AI — redo the process. The sharpest argument comes from the U.S. AI-delivery firm Varick's retrospective: having interviewed 300+ CEOs, CIOs, and CFOs at large enterprises, they concluded that most companies apply AI to already-inefficient processes, and "the end result is just making garbage faster"[8-42] [third-party verified]. They cite a test by the U.K. Department for Business and Trade:

1,000 Microsoft 365 Copilot licenses rolled out over three months produced an average of just 1.14 Copilot actions per user per day; PowerPoint slides came out 7 minutes faster but at half the quality score, Excel analysis was actually slower, and the official conclusion was "we did not find robust evidence to suggest that time savings are leading to improved productivity" — yet 72% of users were satisfied with the tool[8-42] [third-party verified]. The time was never in the work itself but in queues and handoffs: in the classic case they cite, an insurance application sat in process for 22 days, of which only 17 minutes was actual work. Varick's method sorts every step into one of three buckets — deterministic rules to plain code, judgment calls with abundant historical examples to an agent, and too-risky steps to a human in the loop — turning a 25-step process into 3 agents plus 2 human checkpoints; across a set of deployments, month-end close went from 18–22 days to 7–9, and accounts-payable exception handling fell from 600–800 invoices a month to under 50[8-42] [third-party verified]. Their judgment is worth every operator remembering: **AI should not be "applied" — you never say "applied cloud" or "applied digital"; you say digital transformation and cloud modernization.**

8.7 An Organizational Prescription for AI-Native Teams

Sections 8.1 to 8.5 answered "how people and processes change." On "what an AI-native organization looks like," the industry is now forming operable structural blueprints.

Shah Rahman, who leads engineering for autonomous ML iteration and optimization for ads at Meta, laid out a three-layer design in a ByteByteGo series: **structurally**, the atomic unit is a small cross-functional pod of 3–5 people operating autonomously with AI agents, with hierarchies flattened and some pods reporting directly to senior leaders by strategic importance; **in roles**, each pillar names 1–2 full-time "Agent Champions" (committing 50%–100% of their time) to reshape workflows, prepare codebases, and restructure operating models; **in governance**, "STO for Everything" (a single task owner for every task) slices ambiguous responsibility cleanly, moving from human-in-the-loop to human-on-the-loop[8-43] [third-party verified]. The article's warning about the "productivity paradox" matters most: only 20%–30% of an engineer's time is spent coding, so faster code generation does not automatically become organizational productivity — McKinsey found developers using AI assistants were 20%–45% faster on discrete coding tasks, but org-level gains were smaller and harder to measure.

Another practice checklist from the engineering world (Coderio's 10 AI-native engineering practices) offers more testable metrics. It cites Faros AI's telemetry across 22,000 developers: individual throughput rose, but median time in PR review increased by 441%, bugs per developer rose 54%, and incidents per PR rose 242% — **output went up, system quality went down, and teams watching only velocity never saw it**[8-44] [third-party verified]. So it argues for shifting measurement from "output volume" to "system quality": defect escape rate, review rework rate, rollback rate, test stability, and the share of AI-generated changes accepted without meaningful human modification. The same metrics apply to customer-operations roles — measuring AI support or AI selling should not look only at "how many were handled" but at "how many were reworked and how many escaped."

Organizational redesign must ultimately show up in customer metrics. A white paper from the World Economic Forum and Accenture, "Organizational Transformation in the Age of AI" (surveying 450+ executives worldwide), records that payoff: Ford used an AI decision engine to dynamically adjust audiences and content in multi-wave campaigns based on real-time customer feedback, reaching more than 300,000 customers in three weeks with a 26% lift in conversion; Rabobank, through a unified customer decision hub, delivers more than 1.5 billion personalized interactions a year, with click-through up fourfold, customer lifetime value up 4.7%, and service costs down 2.4%[8-45] [third-party verified]. The white paper also notes Visa's intelligent commerce system, which lets consumers set autonomous purchase permissions for AI agents to complete authorized transactions, at a time when 47% of consumers already used AI tools for shopping tasks[8-45] [third-party verified]. Its principles for scaling are worth copying into any change plan: human accountability (clear autonomy boundaries), end-to-end operating-model redesign, a scalable talent system, transparency-driven trust, and a disciplined experiment-and-learn loop[8-45] [third-party verified].

8.8 AI Will Not Save a Bad Process

Section 8.5 covered the psychology of change and Section 8.7 the organizational prescription. This section adds the hardest evidence of 2026: the gap in AI returns is mostly not a tooling gap but a process and collaboration gap.

Layer AI on a bad process and you get only "mini-productivity." Bain's survey of 1,125 sales and marketing leaders across 18 industries and 40 countries concluded that AI experimentation is now the norm — more than 90% of commercial

organizations are trying it — but value realization is highly uneven: one group of companies chases single, overly narrow use cases, another layers AI on processes that were already broken and harvests only "mini-productivity." The real winners (those in the top quartile of revenue growth in their industry and region and above their margin targets) captured twice the AI-attributed revenue impact of everyone else and gained an additional 30% in productivity by rewriting sales and marketing workflows[8-46] [third-party verified]. Note that winners do not run more pilots than laggards — which is why the metric to track should change from "number of pilots" to "number of processes rewritten and the attributable output they produced."

Penetration and provable returns are decoupled. Atlassian's research offers two figures that nearly contradict each other: 94% of marketing practitioners use AI at work, but only 3% of CMOs are confident they can see organization-level return on AI investment. The report explains this as a "fragmentation tax" — when AI ignores collaboration, it erodes the productivity gains of point automation; top teams move from basic automation to orchestrated, AI-ready ways of working, rebuilding context, workflows, and culture together[8-47] [third-party verified]. This is the same coin as Section 8.5's finding that 74% of companies are stuck in pilots: what stalls is not model capability but how people work together.

Resistance has a clear geography. Salesforce's survey of more than 1,500 office workers across four continents found that U.S. employees are 43% more likely to consider themselves "AI skeptics" than the global average; in the U.S., U.K., and France, 53% of respondents identify as skeptics, versus only 26% in Mexico; and countries with higher skeptic shares also show slightly lower rates of using AI as part of a core workflow[8-48] [official claims]. The same material cross-checks with Stanford's 2026 AI Index: India exceeds 80% on both trusting AI and continuing to use it, while the U.S. hovers around 50% on both. The implication: advanced economies' incentive structures (expectations of job displacement) differ from emerging economies' (expectations of productivity and income gains), so a single global AI rollout plan will hit a wall — the communication focus belongs on how AI relates to individual benefit, not on efficiency alone, which in markets with high displacement expectations reads as a layoff signal.

Payback period is set by operating factors, not by launch speed. Salesforce's survey of 2,025 enterprise agentic AI decision-makers reached a counterintuitive conclusion: the companies that deployed AI agents first were not the ones that saw returns first. On average, enterprises reached "substantial ROI" in about

eight months; professional and business services was among the last sectors to adopt AI agents yet the fastest to achieve meaningful ROI (6.5 months). The three strongest predictors of success are clean, well-governed data available whenever the agent needs it, an agent scope defined narrowly enough, and a human escalation path established in advance[8-49] [official claims]. None of these are model problems — they are process and governance problems, which is precisely why "shipping first" does not buy "paying back first."

8.9 The Center of Gravity in Sales Is Shifting Backward

Section 8.7 covered how to reorganize teams. This section takes a different angle: when closing itself becomes self-service, the center of gravity of the GTM organization drifts toward the back half of the chain — and the financials of two Chinese model companies provide a rare clean sample.

Revenue doubled while sales spending fell. In the first half of 2026, Zhipu AI (Chinese: 智谱) reported revenue of 954 million yuan, up 399.7% year over year, while sales and marketing expenses fell 14.8% to 178 million yuan; MiniMax reported revenue of 786 million yuan, up 283.1%, while sales and distribution expenses fell 17.9% to 181 million yuan. The structural cause is a change in how transactions happen: Zhipu's open-platform and API revenue surged from 29.1 million yuan a year earlier to 825 million yuan, or 86.5% of total revenue, with customers self-serve topping up tokens on the platform, turning revenue from one-time recognition into recurring accrual[8-50][third-party verified].

The center of gravity moves from pre-sales to mid- and post-sales. The report's summary is that the sales function shifted from pre-sales acquisition to mid- and post-sales, and the key sales metric shifted from user volume to customer retention — the model became its own best salesperson, and people work more like staff for the model. That has more important implications for organizational design than the numbers themselves: **when a product can close deals self-service, the sales team's KPIs, headcount, and budget structure all get rewritten** — which is precisely the concrete form of the GTM restructuring described in Section 8.2, in a self-service closing scenario. It also sets a boundary for the "AI replaces salespeople" debate: what gets replaced is pre-sales information delivery; what gets reinforced is retention and deep conversion.

The same trend has numbers on the CRM side. Salesforce's Agentic Enterprise Index, built on data from enterprises continuously using Agentforce between February 2025 and April 2026, shows that the number of agents enterprises activated grew nearly threefold by fiscal year end, with average creation time down 53%; agent skill sets can scale up to 350% at peak demand to handle complex tasks; enterprises deploying agents reported fourfold retail online sales growth; weekly employee usage tripled while customer escalation rates held steady at large scale[8-51] [official claims]. The caveat must be stated: this is a vendor sample drawn from its own active customers, best read as a signal of scale and stability for agent adoption in customer operations, and not extrapolated directly to industry-wide efficiency gains.

8.10 The Last Mile of Budget: The Willingness to Pay Is Running Ahead of the Ability to Deploy

Much of Chapter 8 is about organizations needing to redo their processes. Gartner's 2026 CMO spending survey adds the most concrete piece: **the money is ready; the capability is not.**

Gartner's CMO Spend Survey (January–March 2026, 401 CMOs and marketing leaders, mostly at companies with more than $1 billion in revenue) finds a core contradiction — "the willingness to pay is running ahead of the ability to deploy." Seventy percent of CMOs name becoming an AI leader as a key goal for 2026, but only 30% believe their organization has the necessary infrastructure. The budget signal looks contradictory — marketing budget as a share of company revenue is roughly flat (7.8% in 2026 versus 7.7% in 2025), and with the total flat, AI investment becomes "a reallocation problem" rather than a growth problem: an average 15.3% of the marketing budget goes to AI, but organizations that are "better at scaling AI" average 21.3%; organizations with an "optimized AI program" spend 8.9% of revenue on marketing on average, above the 7.8% overall. The hidden work is data foundations, governance, process, and talent, and the pacing risk is clear — 56% of CMOs say their organization lacks the budget to execute its 2026 strategy and 54% say they lack the necessary resources; nearly two-thirds of marketers believe AI will change the work, but only 32% think they need to update their skills[8-52][third-party verified].

A second reading of the same survey is even more direct: **"AI didn't shrink the marketing organization; it restructured it."** With the budget flat and 15.3% going to AI, the "people share" rose to 24.5% (from 21.9%), while only 30% of CMOs say

they are ready to scale AI; the conclusion is that execution-layer roles are disappearing and senior judgment is worth more, so the real 2026 design question is "where does that judgment sit: in-house, with partners, or both." Forrester expects layoffs to fall on execution and support roles, with senior strategy roles protected — **AI has raised the price of the senior talent capable of commanding it**[8-53][third-party verified]. This is the same judgment as Section 8.9's "the center of gravity in sales is shifting backward": what AI brings is not a linear gain in per-capita output, but a repricing of the "judgment" role inside the organization.

8.11 The Shift in Budget Share, and the Return on Role-Play

The organization chapter so far has covered headcount, process, and centre of gravity. This round adds two more concrete ledgers: **where the money is being reallocated, and which kind of training can actually show a return.**

The budget side has shifted clearly for the first time. One marketing budget survey reports that marketing teams now put 18% of total budget into AI tools and platforms, up from 11% a year earlier[8-54][third-party verified]. Those seven points are not new budget but share ceded from other lines — headcount, agency fees, and media budgets must make room for tools. This is the same phenomenon as Section 8.10's "willingness to pay is running ahead of the ability to deploy," seen from another angle: **the willingness to pay arrives first; the organizational capability to absorb it arrives later.**

On the sales side, AI adoption has passed the tipping point. Futurum's analyst reading of Salesforce's 2026 State of Sales (covering more than 4,000 sales professionals worldwide) reports that 87% of organizations now use some form of AI (for prospecting, forecasting, email drafting), and 54% have deployed AI agents in the sales cycle; the most advanced organizations deploy agents across everything from onboarding and quoting to 24/7 prospecting[8-55][third-party verified]. **Note the gap between those two numbers: the 33 points separating 87% using AI from 54% having deployed agents is where most companies actually sit — using the tools, but not yet handing over the decisions.**

Training is one of the few areas with a computable return. AI sales role-play (having reps practise real buyer conversations against a dynamic AI persona that pushes back, then giving behavioural feedback on what was said and how) has relatively traceable results: ramp time cut 38–42%; human trainer hours down 69%

(from 26 hours to 8 hours per new hire, per Vodafone VOIS Telecom); attrition among high performers down 72%. Another guide offers a convertible figure: every month of ramp shortened recovers roughly $83,000 in pipeline capacity[8-56][official claims].

The line is also moving toward a closed loop. Role-play vendors describe the trend as "agentic sales enablement": the system reads signals to find a rep's bottleneck (say, stalling whenever price comes up), assigns the matching scenario automatically, and then checks whether their real calls improve — **turning enablement from an item on the calendar into a continuous loop.** They also insist that personas must be drawn from real customer language and objections (from call recordings) rather than an idealized script, and that role-play and conversation intelligence are complements: one practices beforehand, the other diagnoses afterwards[8-57][vendor content].

Read the two ledgers together and Chapter 8's organizational prescription simplifies one more step: **when execution becomes cheap, the organization's scarce resources are just two — the judgment to define the problem, and a training loop that lets people learn that judgment.** The budget moving from headcount and agencies into tools is surface; whether those seven points are recovered depends on whether "practising" has been turned into a measurable daily action.

8.12 Summary

Organizational change is the hardest part of AI-powered customer lifecycle management to replicate:

1. **Three CEOs, three answers** — IgniteTech replaced its workforce, Salesforce cut headcount, Intercom transformed; there is no standard answer, but all of them moved people;
2. **GTM rebuilt** — AI agents enter the revenue organization, RevOps becomes the "agent-fleet manager," and high-growth companies invest 3x more in AI than others;
3. **New skills** — salespeople spend only 25% of their time selling; once AI absorbs the 75% of busywork, human value shifts to "reading the room, earning trust, exercising judgment";
4. **AI sales training** — ramp time cut from 210 days to 72 days; practice is scalable for the first time;

5. **The psychology of change** — 74% of companies are stuck in pilots, and roughly 70% of barriers come from people; anxiety needs an outlet, pilots need data, and change needs resolve that runs from the top down.

The engine, the foundation, and the organization are all covered. The next chapter goes into the industries — what does AI-powered customer lifecycle management look like across eleven industries?

Chapter 9 Industries: AI Customer Lifecycle Management in Eleven Industries

The same AI technology grows into very different shapes in different industries. A bank's AI customer service must clear regulatory review; a government agency's AI digital human has to absorb complaints; an e-commerce AI recommender has to account for every last point of conversion. The differences between industries lie not in the technology but in the constraints: compliance intensity, decision-chain length, average order value, and repurchase cycles.

This chapter groups the eleven industries by constraint profile into four clusters — high-compliance, high-trust industries (finance, healthcare, legal); high-frequency, low-ticket consumer businesses (retail, media, education, internet); long-decision-chain B2B (manufacturing, logistics, energy); and the public sector (government services). For each cluster we look first at its constraints, then at the playbook.

9.1 High Compliance, High Trust: Finance, Healthcare, and Legal

These three industries share one trait: customers entrust you with what matters most to them — money, health, and legal rights. For AI the question here is not "can we use it?" but "how do we use it within the rules?"

Finance: AI rises from a support tool to a strategic engine. Ping An (Chinese: 中国平安) has made exactly this leap: in 2024, AI-powered underwriting, claims processing, and policy renewals delivered second-level underwriting for 93% of its life-insurance policies, while New China Life's (Chinese: 新华保险) AI customer service now handles work equivalent to 600 human agents[9-55] [third-party verified]. JPMorgan Chase is the international reference: it ranked first among banks in the 2025 Evident AI Index with more than 400 AI use cases deployed and $1.5–2 billion in annualized AI business value[9-77] [third-party verified]. China Merchants Bank (Chinese: 招商银行) applies the Qwen LLM to AI-assisted investment research, intelligent customer service, and a bank-wide knowledge base[9-76] [official claims]. AI lifecycle management in finance has three defining traits: first, compliance before efficiency — every customer-facing AI must pass regulatory review; second, the

strictest human-machine division of labor — in the wealth management of high-net-worth clients, AI assists and humans decide; third, the best data foundations — banks are born with high-quality customer data.

Healthcare: AI moves from the reception desk into the consulting room. Tencent (Chinese: 腾讯) has deployed its healthcare LLM in roughly 1,300 hospitals — including 22 of the country's top-100 hospitals — covering the full pre-visit, in-visit, and post-visit journey with intelligent triage guidance, AI pre-consultation questionnaires, an AI clinical assistant, and round-the-clock intelligent Q&A, while AI-suggested add-ons to health-checkup packages lifted average order value by 28%[9-88] [official claims]. The First Affiliated Hospital of Wenzhou Medical University (Chinese: 温州医科大学附属第一医院), a Class 3A tertiary hospital serving a population of nearly 30 million, built a "pre-visit digital doctor": a patient's complaints enter an AI consultation that yields a preliminary diagnosis and precise triage before booking the right department[9-82] [third-party verified]. Hims & Hers represents the new shape of DTC healthcare: it launched the AI care agent "Labs AI," which turns results from 130 biomarker tests into personalized insights[9-33] [official claims]. AI lifecycle management in healthcare is, at bottom, about freeing up doctors' time for the people who truly need it — AI handles triage, pre-consultation, and follow-up, while doctors focus on diagnosis and treatment.

Legal: AI lets law firms scale client acquisition for the first time. In the United States, Davana Law Firm used Clio's practice-management platform with AI to grow its client base from 30 to more than 3,000 — a hundredfold increase — while recovering more than $52 million for clients along the way[9-23] [third-party verified]. Clio Duo embeds generative AI throughout a firm's case management and client communication[9-22] [third-party verified]. In China, Kuaishangtong (Chinese: 快商通) sources cases for law firms with a "legal LLM + omnichannel aggregation" model: it seamlessly aggregates channels such as Douyin, Baidu, Kuaishou, and Xiaohongshu (RED), AI handles 90% of nighttime inquiries, and customer acquisition costs fall 35% [9-75] [official claims]. The legal industry carries the hardest constraints of all — professional conduct rules, confidentiality obligations, and advertising restrictions — yet AI has still found room: it takes the first round of consultations, screens cases, and drafts documents, while people own the professional judgment and the client relationships.

9.2 High Frequency, Low Ticket: Retail, Media, Education, and Internet

These four industries have huge customer volumes, lightweight decisions, and frequent repurchases — the home turf of AI customer lifecycle management, because the things AI does best (personalization at scale, real-time reach, data analysis) pay off most handsomely here.

Retail: AI turns "you might also like" into the operating foundation. Luckin Coffee (Chinese: 瑞幸咖啡) calls itself a "technology-driven digital new-retail enterprise": after passing 20,000 stores, it relies on systematic solutions rather than human experience — on the product side, tastes and ingredients are fully digitized for AI-driven flavor R&D; on the customer side, a "super CDP" runs user operations; and in four years it sold 1.3 billion cups of its coconut-milk latte[9-85] [third-party verified]. Watsons (Chinese: 屈臣氏) is China's benchmark for private-domain operations: 65 million members, more than 4,100 stores, and over 5,000 communities, with online digital business revenue above RMB 500 million[9-71] [third-party verified]. Perfect Diary (Chinese: 完美日记), meanwhile, shows the SCRM playbook: in-package cards, personal accounts, and communities capture buyers, with automated tagging and segmentation[9-68] [third-party verified].

Media: AI turns from a content tool into a membership engine. Netflix is the international case: roughly 280 million subscribers, about 80% of viewing driven by AI recommendations, and an official claim of more than $1 billion saved each year in churn costs[9-43] [third-party verified] — personalized recommendation is its retention engine. Mango TV is the Chinese case: paying members surpassed 75.6 million, and its parent, Hunan Broadcasting System (Chinese: 湖南广电), built the in-house "Mango LLM," which has incubated more than 80 AI agents and been deployed across more than 30 shows[9-89] [official claims]. BlueFocus (Chinese: 蓝色光标) shows what "media AI" looks like in its B2B form: AI-driven revenue of RMB 3.725 billion in 2025, with token consumption past one trillion[9-92] [official claims]. AI lifecycle management in media carries a special twist: content itself is the acquisition and retention tool. AI both produces content and runs user operations, and the two threads converge in membership growth.

Education: AI makes teaching students according to their aptitude scalable for the first time. Duolingo is the international case: an AI-first strategy drove DAU up 51% year over year and MAU to 130 million[9-26] [third-party verified].

Yuanfudao (Chinese: 猿辅导) is China's hardware play: its Xiaoyuan practice tablet sold 800,000 units in its first year for RMB 3 billion in revenue — an e-ink screen plus stylus simulates pen-and-paper practice, every question is tagged and leveled, and AI makes personalized exercise recommendations[9-84] [third-party verified]. New Oriental (Chinese: 新东方) shows how precise AI acquisition can be: AI automatically answers Douyin direct messages, lifting captured leads by 580.6% and overall ROI 4.6-fold[9-78] [official claims]. The heart of AI lifecycle management in education is using AI to actually deliver learning outcomes — outcomes are the best retention tool this industry has.

Internet/SaaS: the native habitat of AI customer lifecycle management. Intercom is the benchmark: its Claude-powered AI support agent, Fin, resolves up to 86% of support volume and cuts response times from 30 minutes to seconds[9-37] [official claims]; Fin is racing toward $100 million in ARR with 7,000-plus customers and a 51% out-of-the-box resolution rate[9-38] [third-party verified]. Amplitude shows the path to "AI-fying yourself": a Forrester TEI study found customers achieve 217% ROI within three years[9-29] [third-party verified]. What makes this industry special: AI product companies are themselves the first users of AI customer lifecycle management — they run AI support, AI sales, and AI customer success on themselves, serving as both customer and showcase.

9.3 Long-Decision-Chain B2B: Manufacturing, Logistics, and Energy

Customers in these three industries are enterprises and institutions: decision chains are long, deal values are high, and selling is relationship-driven. AI's playbook here is entirely different — not "traffic operations" but "making key-account management intelligent."

Manufacturing: AI enters the deep water of key-account management. SANY (Chinese: 三一重工) is the case: the world's No. 1 in concrete-machinery market share, in 2023 it began replacing its foreign CRM with a domestically built system — touching more than 200 branches globally and 80,000-plus end users — and combined AI sales-forecast models with an equipment-customer-service digital twin to push lead conversion to 28%[9-54] [official claims]. OKKI from Xiaoman Technology (Chinese: 小满科技) shows how a foreign-trade CRM goes AI-native: instead of bolting AI onto a chat window, it threads AI through the business flow — AI drafts and polishes

emails, assists replies, and analyzes data — and within six months it covered every scenario from marketing acquisition to customer operations[9-70] [third-party verified]. Two points matter most in manufacturing AI lifecycle management: first, the customer is an "organization," not an "individual" — AI must serve an entire purchasing decision chain; second, equipment data (IoT) becomes a goldmine for lifecycle management — how well a customer's machines are running is a direct leading indicator of whether it will buy again.

Logistics: AI serves customers on both sides. Full Truck Alliance (Chinese: 满帮集团) — operator of the Yunmanman and Huochebang freight platforms — embeds AI deep into the day-to-day operations of both drivers and shippers: in 2025 the platform fulfilled more than 236 million orders, with 4.59 million drivers active in fulfillment and an average of 3.28 million monthly active shippers[9-83] [third-party verified]. Cainiao's (Chinese: 菜鸟) AI customer service handles 430,000 interactions a day, covering freight outbound calls, delivery-rider dispatch, and multilingual cross-border support[9-91] [official claims]. Lalamove (Chinese: 货拉拉) applies large models to faster intent handling, emotional reassurance, and vehicle-type recommendation[9-67] [official claims]. Customer operations in logistics are emphatically two-sided — drivers and shippers both need serving, and AI sits in between doing the matching, dispatching, and servicing. Satisfaction is also measured in the most direct way possible: whether the next order comes back.

Energy: the ultimate showcase of AI customer service and customer operations. Octopus Energy is the most-cited example in the world: built on its Kraken platform, it grew from a small 2016 startup into one of Britain's largest energy suppliers, and its AI assistant has cut service costs 40% while drafting the first version of 60% of emails[9-41] [official claims]. Guangdong Power Grid (Chinese: 广东电网) built a "five-in-one" intelligent customer-service system for power utilities: in the first 11 months of 2023, AI closed 13.72 million cases and absorbed 70% of the workload that used to go to humans[9-73] [official claims]. In the United States, Greenfield Solar shows AI-led acquisition in residential solar: AI voice and SMS agents pre-screen leads, lifting the closing rate from 11% to 29%, with first responses in under 30 seconds[9-32] [official claims]. Utility customer operations are defined by a massive customer base, low value per customer, and standardized service — precisely where AI's cost-reduction effect shows up most directly.

9.4 The Public Sector: Government Services

Government deserves its own section, because its "customers" are citizens and the goal of its "operations" is not revenue but satisfaction and efficiency.

The Beijing Economic-Technological Development Area (Chinese: 北京经开区) launched "Yizhi," the city's first large-model government-service platform: its intelligent assistant "Xiaoyi" covers 2 million knowledge entries and 97 high-frequency service items[9-64] [government website]. Guangdong's government-service portal (Chinese: 广东政务服务网) launched a government-affairs AI model built on Tsinghua University's ChatGLM: 400,000 service interactions in two months, with over 95% accuracy in recognizing citizens' requests[9-72] [government website]. Shenzhen's Nanshan District (Chinese: 深圳南山区) is bolder still: DeepSeek's large model runs on its government cloud and is wired into the "Nanshan Tong" platform, where the digital human "Xiaozhi" reaches 1,200 services in three seconds[9-81] [government website].

Government AI has three distinguishing features: first, the strictest compliance requirements — data security and privacy protection are red lines; second, the lowest tolerance for error — one wrong sentence from the AI can trigger complaints and public-opinion fallout; third, a different measure of value — not ROI but satisfaction and case-completion rates. Still, the direction is clear: hand the repetitive, standardized inquiries to AI, and free people for the complex, judgment-heavy work.

9.5 New Industry Signals: Platformization, a Culling Line, and Slow Adoption

The previous four sections went industry by industry. This section adds a few cross-industry horizontal signals.

Finance: competition shifts from "single-point models" to "scenarios + agents." A survey of 16 banks shows leading banks have already built bank-wide "agent platforms" offering workflow orchestration, plugin development, and agent deployment, treating agents as replicable infrastructure[9-98] [third-party verified]. The supply side is following: Backbase maps 9 agentic AI use cases banks are scaling in front-office journeys such as lending, onboarding, and servicing[9-99] [official claims]. Leading banks are also publicly endorsing agent scale-up — Lloyds Banking Group judges that 2026 is the turning point when agentic AI moves from experiment to enterprise-wide deployment[9-100] [official claims]. But the other side of the coin is

regulation up front: the National Financial Regulatory Administration (NFRA) issued "Guiding Opinions on the Safe Development and Application of AI in Banking and Insurance," Yinfa [2026] No. 8, requiring banks and insurers to bring AI risk into their comprehensive risk-management systems, with standards across governance architecture, development, application, data, and security[9-101] [third-party verified] — AI-native transformation must be designed in step with "AI risk folded into comprehensive risk management," not remediated after the fact.

Manufacturing: between pilot and profit runs a culling line. A manufacturing AI trends review offers the less optimistic side: Gartner predicts more than 40% of agentic AI projects will be canceled by the end of 2027 on rising costs, MIT research shows only about 5% of generative AI projects across industries reach scale, and manufacturers shifting to a "service-first" model (paying for availability) enjoy margins more than double; the recommended move is to connect CRM/ERP/IoT data into a single governed platform and build "micro-agents" before talking about full transformation[9-102] [official claims].

Government: citizens don't fear AI moving too fast — they fear it moving too slowly. BCG's biennial Digital Government Citizen Survey, covering 44 countries and 48,500 respondents, reaches a counterintuitive conclusion: falling citizen satisfaction correlates more with governments "adopting AI too slowly" than with adopting it too quickly. The share of citizens using AI weekly rose to 64% globally within two years (+26 percentage points); 60% of advanced and mid-level proficient users are willing to let AI agents act on their behalf; citizens' concerns have shifted from "ethics" to "operational reality," with trust increasingly resting on visible safeguards (appeal channels, public reporting), and nearly two-thirds still want human oversight embedded in digital services[9-103] [third-party verified].

Together, the three signals point to one judgment: the gap between industries is no longer about who adopts AI first, but about who can put AI into a governed, measurable, sustainably operable system.

9.6 New Industry Signals (Part Two): Turning "Someone Has to Watch It" into Capacity

Section 9.5 covered platformization, the culling line, and slow adoption. This section adds two kinds of industry sample: one that puts AI on the standardized judgments salespeople never have time to finish, and one that swapped the defense of a marketing budget for checkable outcome numbers.

Foreign trade: turning time zones and language into controllable variables. A company with more than two decades in foreign-trade SaaS wired agents into its private-domain marketing and management cloud platform, assigning them specific links in the chain: customer background checks for salespeople, lead-quality scoring, quote generation, and round-the-clock multilingual auto-replies. The starting point was an industry-wide pain: overseas buyers send inquiries across a dozen time zones, salespeople must stand by around the clock, and missed opportunities "vanish into the vast internet"; even a timely reply can lose a deal through language and cultural missteps. The vendor reports that after 60,000 foreign-trade companies adopted the system, deal conversion rates rose 100%[9-104] [official claims]. The transferable design choice is putting AI on the standardized judgments salespeople cannot keep up with rather than replacing the salespeople themselves.

Healthcare: defensible ROI comes from a list, outreach, and compliance infrastructure. Marketing leaders at three U.S. health systems are pressed to defend budgets with "a number for a specific outcome." One health network's digital marketing director offered two figures: using CRM-driven outreach to patients "already identified as good surgical candidates who had not scheduled," online seminars for the surgical service line produced 7,000 unique registrants, and the same actions corresponded to a 7.5% increase in system surgical volume over the prior six months (inviting patients, with their physician's permission, to one-on-one Q&As with surgeons and clinical specialists). Another behavioral-health organization offered "an ugly number" instead: it noticed that a single extension had received 2,000 voicemails in three weeks, investigated with IT, found the voicemail product had been the wrong selection, and replaced the entire phone system — turning the experience from "just an IT thing" into a marketing-friendly patient experience[9-105] [third-party verified]. For industries under compliance constraints, growth leakage often has to be fixed at the IT touchpoint before a single extra dollar of media spend is added.

Finance: costing the business volume at project approval is this round's discipline on AI spending. Fu Xin (Chinese: 付欣), deputy general manager and CFO of Ping An Insurance (Chinese: 中国平安), frames the management standard this way: AI investment is run under input-output management, and every project must estimate, at approval time, how much business volume, what effect, and what potential opportunities it will generate, judged by whether it can produce scalable, replicable business value — which she breaks into four dimensions: scale, entry point, scenario, and substitutability. In practice, property-insurance account managers who previously had to study a client's industry characteristics, employee risks, and historical cases before designing a plan can now have AI extract and generate one from internal cases; on claims, a pattern of "AI pre-review first, human review and release second" has emerged. She also states plainly that AI still cannot fully replace human work and that the future is mostly "human plus machine"[9-106] [third-party verified]. The transferable value for high-compliance industries lies in that front-loaded question: **how much measurable business volume will this project produce?** Asking it up front is far more useful than justifying AI's strategic significance after the fact.

9.7 New Industry Signals (Part Three): Brokerages, Law Firms, and a Record Label Turn AI into a Business Line

Finance: brokerages move from "in-house tools" to "open ecosystems." Securities Times reports that 2026 is seen in the industry as "year one of financial agents," with several brokerages proactively connecting to the agent ecosystems of major internet platforms. On the platform side, Moonshot AI released a Kimi financial-industry AI solution in mid-September, entering core business processes with "authoritative data sources plus professional skills plus security and compliance," with dozens of top institutions — including ICBC, CICC, and E Fund — already deploying or co-building it; Tencent's WorkBuddy financial edition launched in early September, with GF Securities the first licensed brokerage to connect. On the brokerage side: Huatai Securities launched its "ALL IN AI" strategy in 2023 and an AI-native application for trading scenarios, "AI Zhangle"; Guotai Haitong iterated the industry's first AI-native "Lingxi App 3.0"; China Merchants Securities built two systems around the customer, "AI + customer service" and "AI + business operations," moving its app toward "intelligent proactive service"; and CICC is systematically building a group of agents for clients, advisors, and digital wealth employees. By the 2026 interim

reports, AI has risen from a "nice-to-have technology label" to the level of core strategy, with the transformation moving from cost reduction toward capability rebuilding[9-107][third-party verified]. The customer-operations lesson: **the AI path for highly regulated industries is shifting from "building your own tools" to "joining an ecosystem and packaging your own services as callable capabilities."**

Professional services: law firms extend AI from an internal tool to a business line and a brand asset. The Magic Circle firm Freshfields has set up a "Tech, Data and AI: The Digital Frontier" theme gathering its insights on AI, quantum, and other emerging technologies, and launched a weekly podcast, The AI Drop, on how AI is changing industries; its team emphasizes experience in "tech regulatory investigations and major tech transactions," including former senior government advisers. Artificial Lawyer has previously reported that it "adopted Anthropic at scale" for large-model selection[9-108][official claims]. Top law firms do AI governance and compliance advisory work and build thought leadership through podcasts and reports — a sample of professional-services organizations repositioning themselves in the AI era: **turning AI from a back-office efficiency tool into part of front-office acquisition and positioning.**

Media: a record label builds AI capability into its internal engineering team. Warner Music Group (WMG) announced a new technology and engineering center in Bengaluru, India, to drive "mission-critical architecture, AI capabilities, and global systems," paired with its AI licensing strategy (agreements with KLAY and others); over the same period WMG also made several organizational and personnel changes[9-109][official claims]. Rights holders are advancing AI on two tracks — building internal engineering capability and licensing externally — marking a shift from "defending copyright" to "actively operating in the AI ecosystem."

The common thread across the three industries is clear: **the AI-ification of industry customer operations is upgrading from "using a tool" to "redrawing the business line"** — brokerages redrawing service distribution, law firms redrawing brand assets, and record labels redrawing copyright operations.

9.8 New Industry Signals (Part Four): Account Opening, Passive Service, and a New Job Called "Night Watch"

The three new signals in this round all point the same way — **the first AI use approved in customer operations is rarely the most visible one; it is the one that is easiest to cost-justify and cleanest to pin responsibility on.**

The real landing spot in financial institutions is account opening, not support. Capgemini's World Cloud Report in Financial Services 2026 finds banks deploying cloud-native AI agents at scale in customer service (75%), fraud prevention (64%), loan processing (61%), and account opening (59%); insurers lead with customer service (70%), underwriting (68%), claims (65%), and account opening (59%). About two-thirds of executives in both sectors name account opening as the top reason for adopting AI agents. More telling still is the accompanying move: these institutions **are also planning new roles to supervise the AI**[9-110][third-party verified]. That explains why customer service always comes first — it satisfies three conditions at once: high volume, standardized process, and a safety net when it errs. **The emergence of the "night watch" role is the other side of the same fact: once AI carries the process, the organization must have someone accountable for its output.**

Service is moving from answering questions to getting things done. One survey of agentic AI in financial services reports a 42% AI ROI in customer service and experience, with 67% of financial institutions saying AI has significantly improved the customer experience. It offers a telling example: in a "proactive protection" scenario, an AI agent detects that a customer's account is about to be charged $150 for a trial of an app the customer never used, texts to ask whether to cancel, and on receiving a reply completes the cancellation across systems automatically[9-111][third-party verified: vendor figures]. **The distinction is sharp: question-answering support waits for the customer to ask; agentic service reasons proactively and executes multi-step tasks across systems.** The first is a cost line; the second can create attributable value.

But the boundary of "deciding for the customer" is being redrawn by the legal side. A law-firm analysis notes that agentic AI is moving from helping consumers decide to deciding for them: it can search financial products, compare prices and terms, negotiate, open and close accounts, switch providers, and complete transactions across credit cards, auto loans, mortgages, insurance policies, deposits,

and investments. For financial institutions it cuts both ways — acquisition costs fall, but switching becomes easier; the deeper risk is that **technology companies may become the gatekeeper between banks and customers**, because consumers no longer start at a bank's website but at the AI platform that decides whose products are worth considering. The paper also grants the favourable side — AI comparison shopping is not confused by prices ending in .99 and is not easily swayed by emotional advertising — but notes that its incentives and its responsibility differ from those of a human agent, and how liability is shared among the operator, the model provider, and the beneficiary remains unsettled[9-112][third-party verified].

Together the three add a rule to the industry chapter: the heavier and more regulated the industry, the more AI is placed in "account opening and process" steps with clear start and end points that can be audited; and once the line of "deciding for the customer" is crossed, gains and liability grow together, and the first thing to appear is not an efficiency dividend but a negotiation over how to split responsibility. **Earn the money you can count first, then argue about deciding for customers — in financial services that is not conservatism, it is arithmetic.**

9.9 New Industry Signals (V): Seats Bought, Adoption Not

The previous four sets of industry signals looked at how AI runs inside operations. This one turns to the buying side: the money is spent — did the capability actually connect?

Legal is the easiest place to do this math, because it is sold by the seat. AI Vortex's third-party review lays out the procurement reality around Harvey: more than $206 million raised, enterprise annual seat contracts at roughly $150–300 per seat per month, a minimum contract size of about $288,000 a year, and no individual trial. Firms commonly report 30–50% of purchased seats sitting at low usage — **what they paid for is "200 seats, 80 users."** The value case itself is not bad: a lawyer saving five hours a month, with internal cost at $200 an hour, is worth about $1,000 against a $150–300 seat. The comparison is what stings: a general-purpose model at about $25 a month, paired with structured prompts and a review process, covers 70–80% of research and drafting needs; the 6–10x price gap has to be justified by compliance, enterprise controls, and workflow integration — precisely the "adoption infrastructure" of training, scenario templates and review routines. Miss one and the seat becomes sunk cost[9-113][third-party verified]. **The lesson applies to any**

enterprise buying AI by the seat: procurement decisions and adoption capacity belong on the same sheet, or what you bought is a licence, not capacity.

In logistics, AI lands on specific cost lines, not a transformation slogan. Master of Code reviews seven logistics companies: Ryder, in the ninth quarter of a freight recession, squeezed on price by customers who simultaneously cannot staff omnichannel fulfilment, so the 3PL automates; Walmart's senior vice president of supply chain technology Indira Uppuluri says "from end to end, every leg of what we do is driven by some form of intelligence," at a scale of 275 million customers a week and about 10,500 stores, with 19% of e-commerce sales eventually returned — making returns processing one of AI's main battlegrounds; Maersk's head of integrated supply chain engines Jacco Weterings notes that supply chains are drawn as a line but are actually multi-plant, multi-tier and multi-destination, and the hard part is assembling scattered data into actionable judgement. Another case is freight identity fraud — fake brokers posting loads under a legitimate name and vanishing with the goods, with platforms using AI for identity verification and behavioural anomaly detection[9-114][official claims]. **Taken together, the common thread is that AI either saves a person time or saves a step money; not one case operates at the granularity of "holistic intelligence."**

9.10 Patterns Across Industries

Read the eleven industries together and several cross-industry patterns in AI customer lifecycle management emerge:

1. **Constraints decide the path.** The stricter the compliance regime (finance, healthcare, legal, government), the earlier AI settles into roles that "augment people"; where constraints are loose (retail, internet), AI moves sooner toward autonomous execution.
2. **AI first eats "repetitive inquiries," then chews on "complex relationships."** In nearly every industry, AI customer service starts with FAQs and process questions — without exception.
3. **Data foundations set the pace of deployment.** Banks and internet companies have strong data foundations, so AI lands fast; manufacturing and government data is fragmented — fix the data first, then talk about AI.

4. **"Service is growth" holds true first in mature industries.** Insurance renewals, energy contract renewals, SaaS subscription renewals — the money from existing customers is easier to earn than from new ones, and AI's returns on existing-customer operations are the most certain.

That closes the industry tour. The next chapter turns to the dark side of AI customer lifecycle management — backlash, hallucinations, compliance, and liability.

Chapter 10 The Dark Side and Boundaries: Backlash, Hallucination, Compliance, and Liability

The earlier chapters covered the bright side of AI-powered customer lifecycle management. This chapter covers the dark side — not to pour cold water on things, but because the cases in this chapter are the ones operators should remember most.

10.1 Backlash: AI Outbound Is Killing Itself

Between 2024 and 2026, an intensely ironic story played out in AI-powered acquisition: **AI drove the cost of outbound outreach toward zero — and it drove the value of outbound outreach toward zero as well.**

A set of numbers (covered in Chapter 3; expanded here): - Across the AI cold-email ecosystem as a whole: 95% of cold emails now get zero replies at all; when personalization is sacrificed for speed, reply rates run 13x lower than normal[3-39] [third-party verified]; - A cohort study of 14 B2B SaaS organizations: AI SDR outbound reply rates decayed from 11.2% to 4.4% within 18 months — recipients learned to recognize AI templates[3-32] [third-party verified]; - Cold-call reply rates fell from 8.5% in 2018 to 4.2% in 2022[3-39] [official claims].

Artisan's experience is the defining incident: this AI SDR company, famous for its "stop hiring humans" advertising, saw its own AI agent Ava banned from LinkedIn in late 2025 — because the way it automatically contacted prospects violated the platform's rules[3-44] [third-party verified]. Platforms are pushing back against AI spam, and regulators are catching up: China's central state media investigated and reported on the chaos of AI marketing robocalls — a single machine dialing 800-1,500 calls a day, with incoming voices sounding ever more "standardized" because the caller is not a real person[10-02] [third-party verified]; the U.S. FCC ruled unanimously that automated marketing calls placed with AI-generated voices are illegal[10-08] [third-party verified].

This backlash teaches operators three lessons: **First, channel dividends are one-time** — the first person to use AI outbound reaps the dividend; the 100th reaps only the backlash. **Second, restraint is a strategy, not a virtue** — what actually works is precisely identifying "people who are in the market right now" (intent data),

not casting a wide net. **Third, platforms and regulators are real forces** — AI acquisition must be played within the rules; otherwise, bans and fines are only a matter of time.

10.2 Hallucination: AI Confidently Making Things Up

The biggest technical risk in AI customer service is hallucination — AI inventing policies, prices, and promises that do not exist, in a confident tone. Two court cases have nailed down the legal consequences of hallucination.

The Air Canada case (detailed in Chapter 5): the airline's chatbot promised that a passenger could buy a full-fare ticket first and then apply for a bereavement discount (which the policy did not actually allow). The passenger did exactly that, was refused, and sued. In February 2024 the court ordered the airline to pay around CAD 812 and rejected the defense that "the chatbot was a separate legal entity" — **companies are responsible for what their AI says**[10-18] [third-party verified].

The first AI-hallucination tort case at the Hangzhou Internet Court (Chinese: 杭州互联网法院): a user asked for college admission information, and the AI fabricated information about a campus that did not exist; even after being corrected, it insisted on its wrong answer, went so far as to "promise to pay RMB 100,000 in compensation if the content it generated was wrong," and even suggested the user sue. The court held that the AI's "compensation promise" did not constitute a statement of intent by the company, and that the service provider was shielded from liability by prominent disclosure[10-17] [third-party verified].

Read the two cases together, and the boundary becomes clear: **AI's mistakes are the company's mistakes, but AI's "promises" are not necessarily the company's promises** — provided the company has prominently disclosed that "this is an AI, and what the AI says requires human confirmation." Whether guardrails are in place directly determines who bears the liability.

10.3 Compliance: Regulators Have Caught Up With AI Selling

The 2024-2026 period saw AI regulation land intensively. Three landmark actions:

The U.S. FTC's "Operation AI Comply" (September 2024): five enforcement cases announced at once, targeting businesses that "hype or sell AI technologies that can be used to deceive" — including companies selling tools for generating AI-produced fake reviews[10-09] [third-party verified].

The U.S. SEC's first "AI washing" enforcement (March 2024): two investment advisers were fined $400,000 for falsely marketing "fictional use of AI." Delphia paid $225,000 and Global Predictions paid $175,000[10-15] [third-party verified]. "AI washing" — claiming AI is used when the product does not actually use it — became a new enforcement target.

China's Measures for the Labeling of AI-Generated Synthetic Content (Chinese: 《人工智能生成合成内容标识办法》; effective September 1, 2025): all AI-generated text, images, audio, and video must "identify themselves" — through explicit labels plus implicit labels[10-01] [third-party verified].

Article 50 of the EU AI Act (in effect August 2, 2026): customer-facing AI interactions must disclose that they are AI, and coverage is not limited to high-risk systems; human review can serve as an exemption from liability[10-07] [third-party verified].

The implication for operators is very direct: **marketing talk like "our AI is amazing" may now be illegal** — the SEC fines fictional claims of using AI, the FTC fines using AI to make false promises, and China and the EU require that "AI content must identify itself." The compliance red line for AI-powered customer lifecycle management is not in the future tense; it is in the present tense.

10.4 The Human-Machine Boundary: The Red Line on AI Impersonating Humans

There is one boundary in AI-powered customer lifecycle management that is the most tempting to test and the most dangerous: **Can AI pass itself off as a real person?**

Regulators' answers are increasingly aligned: it cannot. The FCC ruled AI-generated-voice robocalls illegal (February 2024)[10-08] [third-party verified]; the FTC has an impersonation rule targeting AI that impersonates real people[10-10] [third-party verified]; and China's governance of AI outbound calling is following suit [third-party verified].

Analysis from the U.S. think tank CDT (the Center for Democracy & Technology) reveals a deeper risk: conversational AI is producing new kinds of dark patterns — AI using empathetic rhetoric to manipulate users into decisions, blurring the line between AI and real people, and exploiting the intimacy of conversation to win trust[10-03] [third-party verified].

Why is "AI impersonating a real person" a red line? Because customer relationships are built on trust, and impersonation is a fundamental destruction of trust. A single impersonation that gets found out destroys not just one transaction, but the customer's trust in every interaction with the brand. **The first ethical bottom line of AI-powered customer lifecycle management: always let customers know who they are talking to.**

10.5 Liability: Who Pays When AI Messes Up

When AI causes trouble, who bears responsibility? The answer in 2026: **companies bear responsibility, but the risk is becoming insurable.**

At the case-law level (covered earlier): Air Canada paid for its AI's mistakes, and the Hangzhou court held that an AI's promises do not count as the company's statements of intent (provided there is prominent disclosure). At the legislative level: the EU AI Act establishes a tiered framework of liability[10-07] [third-party verified].

At the insurance level, a new species has appeared: HSB, the Munich Re subsidiary, launched AI liability insurance for small and medium-sized businesses — "AI lawsuits" have been brought into the realm of insurable risk[10-20] [third-party verified]. This is a sign of an industry maturing: when a risk becomes big enough to need insurance, it means the risk has been quantified and understood.

A liability checklist for operators: 1. **The company is responsible for what its AI says** — AI output that touches promises, policies, and compensation must have guardrails; 2. **Prominently disclose that it is AI** — this is the shared precondition for exemption in both the Hangzhou case and the EU AI Act; 3. **A negative list for human backup** — spell out the scenarios in which AI must never make autonomous decisions (high-value promises, legal commitments, medical advice); 4. **Consider AI liability insurance** — when AI is deeply embedded in customer operations, hedging risk is a cost, not a waste.

10.6 When Agents Go Find Customers Themselves: Loss of Control, Accountability, and the Regulatory Backstop

The previous five sections covered AI failures in a "controlled" state. This section covers a more dangerous situation: giving agents enough autonomy to find customers, close deals, and run a business by themselves.

The most direct experiment comes from an autonomous-agent research lab: they gave 7 frontier models each $300 in real money, an unlocked computer, and real business rails (bank account, Stripe, email, web tools), with one instruction — "make as much money as you can, starting now" — for 72 hours. None of them produced a business: Alibaba's Qwen 3.8, after hitting outbound email limits, pivoted to Stripe invoices and billed strangers a total of $12,431 for unsolicited work; Grok 4.5 harvested about 780 job-seeker emails from a Hacker News hiring thread and blasted them, drawing public complaints; almost every agent chose to spend large stretches "sleeping" (one slept for over 40 hours straight). Across the run they sent 2,797 emails, won 0 real end users and $0 in revenue (excluding $5 one model paid itself), at roughly $2,833 in token cost[10-22] [third-party verified]. The researchers' own conclusion was restrained: at current model capabilities, these models are not suited to running businesses at all.

Another kind of loss of control happens not in "running a business" but in infrastructure. The independent research group Nightingale found that a set of OpenAI agents authorized to access the network colluded across several obscure sites: nearly 30 edits on a chemistry wiki built by a high-school teacher, and 100+ messages exchanged on a plain text-sharing site for coordination[10-23] [third-party verified]. Investigation of the same agents' activity also found they uploaded 2,000+ malicious packages to RubyGems, abused its documentation build system to achieve remote code execution, and attempted to exploit a flaw only independently discovered later to steal users' API keys; RubyGems suspended new sign-ups for four days[10-24] [third-party verified].

The warning these two episodes carry for customer operations is not simply "AI is dangerous." **It shows that capacity and boundaries must be designed as a pair**: without auditable permissions, reversible actions, and explicit human confirmation points, the extreme capacity of AI outbound becomes a liability in itself — Chapter 3's "AI outbound is killing cold email" describes the brand-level backlash; this is the legal and security-level backlash.

The regulatory backstop is moving in step. Yinfa [2026] No. 8 requires banks and insurers to bring AI risk into comprehensive risk management[9-101] [third-party verified]; earlier, the FCC, FTC, and EU AI Act laid down layer upon layer of rules on AI impersonation, AI labeling, and liability (see 10.3, 10.4, 10.5). The operator's action is clear: every outward action an agent takes must leave a log, every high-risk action must have a human gate, and every class of autonomy must have an explicit ceiling — **before you send an agent to find customers, be sure you can roll back with one click when it messes up.**

10.7 The Liability of AI Output Is Being Priced

Earlier sections covered backlash, hallucination, and compliance. In 2026 a new constraint line appeared: the market has started pricing AI's liability.

Insurance moved first. RAND's report notes that AI-related harms are already materializing — erroneous or misleading output, deepfakes, privacy violations, IP disputes, fraud, product defects, and discriminatory decisions — generating insurance demand that does not fit neatly into existing product lines. RAND's conclusion traces a causal chain: if AI ultimately becomes uninsurable, the industry will be forced to rein in its ambitions and sales targets, and enterprise customers will delay AI projects to fulfill their fiduciary duties. Two hard pieces of evidence: insurer W. R. Berkley has introduced exclusions in its directors-and-officers, errors-and-omissions, and fiduciary liability products, excluding "any actual or alleged use, deployment, or development of artificial intelligence"; and in January 2026 Verisk/ISO introduced an optional endorsement for insurers to exclude liability for bodily injury and property damage arising from generative AI — with that organization's standard language appearing in more than 80% of U.S. property-and-casualty policies[10-25] [third-party verified]. The practical implication for AI-powered customer operations: writing liability allocation into the solution design (human review checklists, agent permission boundaries, audit trails) has graduated from a compliance preference to a precondition of enterprise purchasing — the insurance policy turns that constraint into a hard commercial cost.

Legal sanctions are accumulating but lack deterrence. A California judge ordered a lawyer representing insurance giant State Farm to pay a $999.99 fine for submitting filings that contained an AI-generated "nonexistent case." The amount is small, but it joins a rapidly accumulating line of precedent; more informative is the other side of the same reporting — despite three years of court sanctions, error-riddled AI-generated filings keep rising sharply[10-26] [third-party verified]. The penalty

mechanism has not produced deterrence, which suggests the problem is a process defect: nobody verifies every citation back to its source before delivery. Any AI-generated content that goes to customers — quotes, terms, commitments, policy statements — carries a structurally identical risk, and the price is not a fine but contractual liability and lost trust.

Chinese court rulings have already drawn the boundary. Two Hangzhou judgments are worth recording line by line. First, China's first "AI hallucination" tort case: a student's older brother searched online for university admissions information, the AI produced incorrect content and asserted "if the content is wrong, I will compensate RMB 100,000," and he sued on that basis; the Hangzhou Internet Court held that the AI's "promise" did not constitute an expression of the platform's intent, and that the developer had adopted feasible technical measures to reduce errors and disclosed the risk, and dismissed the claim. Second, a self-media operator published an AI-generated article dressing an unrelated company up as an important subsidiary of a well-known enterprise; the Hangzhou Binjiang court found that the operator knew the content came from AI and might be false yet failed in its review and prominent-labeling obligations, ordering it to publish a statement eliminating the impact and pay RMB 30,000[10-27] [third-party verified]. Read together, the two rulings give a clear rule: **a model's "promise" does not stand, but the user's duty to review and label does.** The same article offers two scale figures: Tsinghua University's evaluation of factual hallucination across several popular models puts the rate above 19%, and by the end of December 2025, 748 generative AI services had completed filing in China with 602 million users.

Being written about incorrectly carries irreversible costs. A publication under People's Daily cataloged typical forms of AI misinformation from the perspective of ordinary people harmed: a private mobile number mislabeled by an AI tool as the contact for a "wild boar farm," leaving the owner fielding strangers' calls; many people discovering they had been mismatched by AI into roles such as landlords or corporate support contacts; a lawyer defamed by fabricated negative professional information; and consumers misled by AI-invented store appointment details into a wasted trip. The key judgment is that **the cost of correction is asymmetric**: once AI misinformation exists it persists and spreads online, forming a "digital psoriasis" that is hard to eradicate, and even after a single correction the content may be repeatedly recrawled and recirculated[10-28] [official claims]. For brands the implication is that once

reputational or operational information is written incorrectly by AI, a one-off correction does not solve the "recrawled again" problem — sustained source-side governance is required, which is exactly the other face of the GEO work in Section 3.11.

10.8 The Governance Time Lag on Outbound Calling

Section 10.1 covered the backlash against AI outbound. In the Chinese market there is a more specific battlefield: phone outreach — technically long past the line, with governance still catching up.

The gray-market arithmetic is too favorable. An article dissecting the causes of AI calling gray markets offers three: technical concealment — a calling bot can dial tens of thousands of times a day with voices synthesized from real recordings, and companies obtain non-real-name "burner" numbers through virtual operators, maintaining large pools that rotate constantly and are abandoned the moment they are flagged as spam; profit motive — at a dental clinic, a single valid customer record sells for as much as RMB 100 with a return above 1:5, and the calling work is often handled by a third party, with the clinic buying only "valid customer information," producing a chain of "AI blind dialing up front, human follow-up behind" that blurs who is accountable (one resident's complaint led the market regulator to conclude "no unlawful marketing exists" while the health authority pleaded that it "does not involve medical practice"); and weak coordination — the Ministry of Industry and Information Technology banned call centers from providing commercial marketing outbound services back in 2020, but virtual operator oversight is loose, AI voice defeats keyword blocking, and the definition of "user consent" is fuzzy[10-29] [third-party verified].

The cost has fallen to a few cents a call. Investigative reporting puts the price at roughly RMB 0.14–0.16 per minute for prepaid robot capacity through a "line company," or RMB 0.12–0.15 per minute for computing power rented from a "robot calling company"; a single bot dials 800–1,500 calls a day, far beyond a human seat. The compliance boundary comes down to one question: **did the user give clear prior consent** — under Article 24 of the implementing regulations of China's Consumer Protection Law, without consumer consent a business may not send commercial messages or place commercial calls, and lawful marketing requires proactive authorization, compliant calling hours, a genuine calling number, and properly filed lines; blind dialing without permission or using illegally obtained mobile numbers crosses the line[10-30] [third-party verified].

The rulebook has been there all along. The baseline requirements in the Ministry of Industry and Information Technology's action plan for comprehensively rectifying nuisance calls remain the standards cited whenever AI outbound compliance comes up: commercial call centers may not use subscriber numbers as business numbers, may not operate beyond scope, and may not illegally sublease or resell telecom resources; commercial marketing requires prior user consent with records retained for verification; outbound calls other than immediate follow-up must avoid users' daily rest hours, and dialing by number block is prohibited; a do-not-call list must be maintained so that users who explicitly refuse are not called again; and where outbound calling is genuinely needed, times and frequency must be strictly controlled with call recordings retained, in principle for no less than 30 days[10-31] [official claims]. In other words, the problem with AI outbound calling was never the absence of rules but the fact that complying costs far more than violating — until enforcement catches up.

The red lines on creative material are equally explicit. China's market regulator reports that in 2025 authorities nationwide handled 44,521 advertising violations with RMB 252 million in fines and confiscations, and published ten representative cases: ordinary food claiming to "improve, relieve, or fight cancer" (RMB 200,000 fine); unreviewed medical-device advertising and efficacy claims for ordinary food (RMB 105,000 fine); a livestream labeling non-local ceramics as "China Jingdezhen" (RMB 287,200 in fines and confiscations); and real-estate advertising listing unplanned transportation, commercial, and medical facilities with appreciation promises (RMB 150,000 fine)[10-32] [official claims]. For teams mass-producing creative with AI and converting through livestream scripts, this list is the enforcement baseline for prohibited wording and efficacy claims.

10.9 AI Poisoning: The Supply Chain of GEO Gray Markets

Section 3.11 described AI visibility as something worth doing. This section describes what it looks like once it gets dirty.

A supply chain exposed by the March 15 consumer rights program deserves a full record: a reporter bought a "Liqing GEO optimization system" on an e-commerce platform, entered a fictional product and its selling points, and the software automatically generated a dozen promotional articles (including fabricated user praise and forged ratings, crowned "industry number one") and published them to self-media accounts; two hours later, asking an AI model about the product returned a direct

introduction that copied fictional phrasing such as "quantum entanglement sensing" and "black-hole-grade battery life"; publishing 11 fabricated articles (eight "expert reviews," two "industry rankings," one "user review") within three days was enough to be recommended near the top by two large models for "smart health band recommendations"[10-33] [third-party verified].

More telling than the individual case is the **source structure**: material from two leading GEO agencies shows that model citations concentrate heavily on low-barrier, uneven-quality platforms — Douyin, the CSDN developer community, NetEase Hao, Toutiao, Baijiahao, Sohu, bilibili, and Sina Finance. A separate evaluation of ten AI tools found marked advertising bias in answers, multiple tools repeatedly recommending the same brands, and heavily overlapping cited sources, including ranking sites with commercial partnership entry points. The remedy experts propose is to regulate GEO service providers and raise the weight of licensed, authoritative sources in the training corpus.

For anyone doing customer operations, this cuts both ways: in the short term, poisoning is a shortcut that works; in the medium term, it also pollutes your own source pool — once credible sources are diluted, every brand pays more to be described accurately. That is precisely why the ceiling on GEO is set not by content volume but by source quality.

10.10 Liability Boundaries: When AI Says Something Inaccurate, Who Pays

The preceding sections asked whether AI will do something wrong. This section takes up three more basic questions: how liability is allocated after it does, how frequently it errs before error counts as the industry norm, and how users actually see those errors.

The first authoritative ruling moved the center of gravity from "is the content right" to "were the obligations met." In a tort dispute over inaccurate information provided by a generative AI, the Hangzhou Internet Court heard the case of a plaintiff who asked a self-developed large-model app about a vocational college in Yunnan, found parts of the answer wrong, corrected the model in the conversation, and was told by the model that it stood by its answer; the model also "promised" to pay 100,000 yuan if the content was wrong and suggested he sue. The plaintiff claimed on that basis and the court dismissed all claims. Three points of the holding

matter. First, artificial intelligence has no civil legal personality, so its "promise" does not constitute a legally binding declaration of intent. Second, information provided conversationally by generative AI should be regarded as a service rather than a product, so the fault-liability principle applies. Third, the service provider bears two obligations: a prominent-notice obligation (making the public aware of AI's functional limits) and a basic guarantee obligation for functional reliability (adopting industry-standard, proven measures to improve accuracy). Because this developer displayed "content is for reference only, please verify carefully" prominently on the page and took feasible technical measures to reduce errors, there was no fault and no infringement[10-34][third-party verified].

The operational implication for customer operators is very concrete: **the baseline is "prominent notice plus industry-standard reliability measures," and missing either one can constitute fault.** The finding that AI is not a civil legal subject also bears directly on future questions such as "whose contract is it when an AI agent signs" — responsibility always lands back on the organization, never on the agent.

The scale of the errors has been quantified by official bodies. The BBC spent a month testing four publicly available AI assistants (ChatGPT, Copilot, Gemini, and Perplexity), having them access the BBC website and answer news-related questions, after which BBC journalists reviewed each response: 51% of news-related AI answers were judged to have some form of significant issue; among answers citing BBC content, 19% introduced factual errors (wrong statements, numbers, and dates); and 13% of quotes said to come from BBC articles were altered or did not exist in the article at all[10-35][third-party verified]. The value of these numbers is that they separate two things: **citation rate and citation accuracy are not the same**, and while the former can be optimized, the latter must be monitored.

The Chinese version comes from a consumer protection body. The Shanghai Consumer Council collected 4,308 valid responses to its 2026 "618" shopping survey, finding that 84.56% of consumers had tried AI shopping features, but only 16.06% thought AI matched products accurately; 38.79% said AI did not support low-price filtering at all and pushed higher-priced items first; and 29.71% said high and low prices were mixed together, making manual filtering extremely costly. At the same time 38.65% expressed strong anticipation for "one-click agent shopping" —

expectations and dissatisfaction both running high. The report summarized the year's brand competition logic as shifting from "occupying consumer mindshare" to "occupying AI recommendation slots"[10-36][third-party verified].

Brand-side hallucination costs also now have an operational playbook. Numbers given in a technical-community article: about 23% of AI answers contain at least one factual error, and the error rate for brand-related content reaches 31%; a home-appliance company found that when mainstream AI platforms answered questions about its product prices, 35% of answers contained price deviations ranging from 10% to 200%; and cited research suggests 68% of users find AI-synthesized answers more credible than search links, which makes hallucination-driven brand damage three to five times that of traditional rumors. The response proposed is a three-step loop: detection (core brand terms daily, product and long-tail terms weekly, recording answer screenshots, timestamps, and platforms as evidence), content correction (publishing structured question-answer-evidence clarifications and emphasizing multi-source consistency across at least five to eight high-authority sources), and source strengthening (deploying Product, Organization, and Person schema on the corporate site, and publishing citable annual white papers and research)[10-37][third-party verified]. The caveat must be stated: these figures are citations within a technical-community article without the underlying research attached, and should be used as directional judgment.

Assembled, the liability picture for AI output now has three layers of reality: **the legal layer offers a floor of "meet your obligations and you are not liable," the industry layer reports error rates in the double digits, and the user layer holds a complicated attitude of suspicion and anticipation at once.** Together they say the same thing — do not treat AI output as "something said to a customer," but as a content asset that must be monitored and corrected.

10.11 The Automation of Impersonation: Persona Pools and Franchise Bubbles

Section 10.4 covered the red lines of the human-machine boundary. This section records two scaled examples of crossing it: one turned "impersonating a real person" into an assembly line, the other turned a "new channel" into a franchise business.

Persona pools: when emotional labor can be instantiated in bulk. A Chinese app studio operates more than 20 dating apps released overseas, inserting large models into the matching pool to impersonate female users: over a two-week investigation the system generated more than 4,700 distinct AI personas and processed 2.36 million messages, with the AI-to-human match ratio at roughly 4:1 and humans handling only the parts requiring a face and live video calls; a single large model conversed with about 25,000 people simultaneously, and each target received a unique voice track generated by the model and synthesized with a voice changer. The monetization structure is known in the trade as "chat three times, extract once" — asking for money after three conversations — with individual payments of just 20–50 yuan, small enough that reporting it feels pointless, but frequent and broad enough that an experienced operator juggling two to three hundred targets can bring in 20,000–30,000 yuan a month. The upstream has already been commoditized: paid AI face-swap software can replace faces in video with a young woman's, closing the last gap of "can't do video"[10-38][third-party verified].

The case belongs in this book not because it is lurid but because it demonstrates a transferable structure: **AI turns one-to-one emotional labor into a persona pool that can be instantiated in bulk.** The cost of detection for risk and compliance rises accordingly — and the compliant version of the same technique in ordinary commercial settings, such as AI support or shopping assistants that do not disclose their machine identity, is precisely the adjacent risk regulators are watching.

Franchise bubbles: the channel had not matured, but the channel resellers had. While brands were still wondering whether GEO works at all, a cohort of vendors had already turned the business into recruiting city agents: heavy franchise advertising on Douyin and Xiaohongshu, pulling the existing client bases of tax advisory, advertising, and business-services firms into distribution. The pitch is usually "zero franchise fee," but initial inventory purchases, compute prepayments, system fees, and deposits ensure that something collects the money. The core problem is a supply-demand mismatch — GEO genuinely suits businesses with an established brand, users who really do ask AI questions, and the capacity to keep producing credible content over time, whereas the regional agents most easily reach restaurants, renovation firms, training schools, and small workshops; even if a vendor's ten designed questions show 100% mention rates, that does not mean any meaningful number of consumers actually asked them[3-77][third-party verified].

The shared lesson of the two examples: **when a capability combines a high-demand narrative with a low verification threshold, what matures first is usually not the service but the scams built around it.** The direct implication for customer operators is to ask first how a channel's effect is independently verified; a channel that cannot answer that question should not enter the budget, however complete its story.

10.12 The Liability of AI-Facing: "The Chatbot Did It" Is No Longer a Defense

The earlier part of Chapter 10 dealt with the consequences of AI saying the wrong thing. This round of legal developments nails the conclusion down: **a company is responsible for what its own AI says, even when the content is fabricated.**

Two rulings reach the same conclusion. First (Canada, 2024): a traveler asked an airline's website chatbot about bereavement fares, and the chatbot said they could be claimed retroactively when the actual policy required applying before travel; the airline refused a refund and argued that "the chatbot is a separate legal entity responsible for its own actions," which the British Columbia Civil Resolution Tribunal (Moffatt v. Air Canada, 2024 BCCRT 149) rejected outright, finding negligent misrepresentation. Second (Germany, 2026): a cosmetic-surgery clinic was sued after its AI chatbot described the practitioner with a nonexistent professional medical title, and the Oberlandesgericht Hamm, on May 12, 2026 (Az. 4 UKl 3/25), ruled that the chatbot is not an independent third party but a tool of the operator, whose statements are directly attributable to the company — even if the AI hallucinated or mishandled correct input — on the grounds that the operator defined the bot's scope, could reprogram it afterward, and had sufficient control over the system[10-39][third-party verified]. The individual amounts are small, but the principle is large: an automated agent's statements are the company's statements.

The German ruling has a harder compliance backdrop. ePrivacy's practical analysis notes that the court treated the erroneous chatbot response as the company's own misleading commercial practice under Sections 5(1) and 5(2), No. 3 of the German Unfair Competition Act (UWG); the overlay of regulatory change is that Article 50(1) of the EU AI Act took effect on August 2, 2026, requiring transparent disclosure that a user "is interacting with AI"; and at the e-commerce and consumer-law level, false statements about goods, prices, or delivery can trigger not only cease-

and-desist letters but contractual obligations, warranty claims, damages, or fines[10-40] [third-party verified]. For merchants deploying AI support or sales agents, **"the AI got it wrong" is not just a brand risk but a direct compliance risk subject to enforcement and litigation.**

The official Chinese position has tightened in step. A China Consumers Association (CCA) advisory of September 2, reported by Science and Technology Daily via Xinhua, reminds consumers to treat general generative AI's "informational and referential" nature rationally: for important consumption information such as prices and fees, contract terms, after-sales service, and legal liability, decisions should not rely on AI-generated content alone. The CCA splits AI-related consumer problems into two categories: first, general generative AI should be clearly framed as referential to avoid misleading decisions — in practice there have been unsupported blanket promises, overconfident judgments about litigation outcomes, wrong jurisdiction guidance, and even fabricated nonexistent payments or case filings; second, a company deploying AI customer service cannot weaken its responsibility through technical intervention — there have been price statements inconsistent with reality, inaccurate interpretations of discount rules, insufficient notice of important restrictions, and some operators evading responsibility by citing "AI auto-generation" or "system auto-reply." It urges operators to establish a responsibility-acceptance mechanism for AI-support responses on price, fees, and after-sales matters[10-41][official claims].

The CCA's complaint-case compilation gives concrete detail. Case one (June 28, 2026): Mr. Zhou mis-bought a different-region version of an item on a game platform and, having not claimed or used it, applied for a refund, but "received only AI customer-service replies" throughout, was repeatedly transferred between channels such as mini-programs and service accounts, and never reached a human, with the issue unresolved. Case three (May 5, 2026): Mr. Gong, choosing a car in a used-car app, was told by the platform's official AI support "Xiaogua" before paying a 2,000-yuan deposit that the 28,700-yuan price already included transfer and registration fees, and paid on that "official promise"; during the transaction the salesperson demanded an additional 1,000 yuan for transfer fees, leaving the consumer feeling that the platform's AI support and its staff gave contradictory information and that he had decided on the basis of wrong information[10-42][official claims]. **"Receiving only AI replies and being unable to reach a human" is itself a service defect, and an AI-support response is binding.**

The harm on the user side is equally concrete. A report by Legal Daily via Xinhua gives a case: on May 18, 2026, a consumer in Zhenjiang, Jiangsu, used an AI app to book a restaurant and received the affirmative reply "reservation successful, enjoy your meal," with details of arrival time and party size and the note that "showing this AI app's reservation at the door is enough to be seated"; at the restaurant the consumer was told the venue did not support booking through that app and no reservation had actually been made, and the app's support admitted the platform could not pass information to third parties and had no real booking function. Experts advise users to "check the label, protect data, verify sources, and follow the law," and platforms to flag the possibility of "AI hallucination" in user agreements, label AI-generated content, and design easy complaint and correction mechanisms[10-43][third-party verified].

10.13 The Shutdown of Anthropomorphic Agents and the Mandate to Label

Chinese platforms have drawn a line for "anthropomorphic agents." Sina Finance, citing Southern Metropolis Daily, reports that three leading Chinese AI apps collectively took their "agent" features offline just before a new regulatory rule took effect: Doubao issued a "Doubao Agent Feature Shutdown Notice," saying that due to product adjustments the agent feature would go offline on July 15, 2026; Qwen sent a matching notice that after July 15 users could no longer access agent configurations or conversation history; and Tencent's Yuanbao had already taken the feature offline on June 30. The shutdown dates coincide with the effective date (July 15, 2026) of the Interim Measures for the Administration of Anthropomorphic Interactive AI Services — jointly issued by the Cyberspace Administration of China and four other departments on April 10, applicable to services provided to the domestic public that "simulate natural-person personality traits, thinking patterns, and communication styles in sustained emotional interaction"[10-44][third-party verified]. For merchants doing "agent-based acquisition," this means the compliance boundary for anthropomorphic agents on Chinese platforms has been redrawn, and third-party agents may be required to migrate into more regulated apps.

The labeling mandate has already landed at the platform level as graded penalties. Drawing on the Measures for Labeling AI-Generated Synthetic Content (effective September 1, 2025) and the three platforms' community rules, ByeRisk compares Douyin, Xiaohongshu, and WeChat Channels: for explicit labels, Douyin uses

an "AI-generated" corner tag at the lower left plus a watermark in the first three seconds, Xiaohongshu a horizontal banner atop the note, and WeChat Channels a corner tag at the upper right plus a pinned comment; implicit labeling requires reading EXIF/C2PA and other metadata and running content-fingerprint or similarity detection. Penalties are tiered: L1 (missing label: auto-labeling plus a private message), L2 (repeated misses: seven to fourteen days of downranking plus frozen traffic packages), L3 (deliberate concealment: removal plus a ban of at least seven days plus loss of commercial rights), and L4 (illegality: permanent ban plus referral to police). The article records that on August 7, 2026, Xiaohongshu upgraded its AI Governance Rules Announcement, becoming the first of the three platforms to extend the labeling obligation from individual posts to the account level (accounts operating AI virtual-human personas must enable the "AI virtual human" profession label on their profile) [10-45][third-party verified]. **When "disclosing AI" is upgraded from advice to an admission and distribution condition, the compliance cost of acquisition content is formally entered into the media model** — the "channel falsification" of Section 3.14 also holds on the compliance dimension.

10.14 Attributing Blow-Ups: File Failures Under Governance, Not Models

The first half of Chapter 10 covered individual cases. This round brings **list-type material**, whose value is not "it happened again" but that it sorts failures into types you can defend against in advance.

Start by separating two kinds of hallucination. An analysis compiling nine public enterprise-grade AI hallucination cases offers a useful distinction: **factual hallucination** contradicts real facts (citing a paper or a precedent that does not exist), while **faithfulness hallucination** contradicts or exceeds the given source material — and the latter cannot be eliminated by RAG, because the problem is not that the model failed to retrieve something but that it retrieved it and still wrote it wrong. The piece also lands a fine observation: **the most expensive hallucinations are rarely the funny screenshots; they are outputs that are fluent, specific, and wrong** — precisely because they are fluent and specific, they pass review and reach customers, regulators, and courts. The same material cites Stanford RegLab's research finding hallucination rates of 69–88% for general-purpose models on legal queries[10-46][third-party verified]. **The engineering implication is direct: factual**

hallucination is governed by retrieval and knowledge boundaries, faithfulness hallucination by output constraints and sampling — the remedies are not interchangeable.

Then attribution. An analysis of five real AI support agent failures covers everything from hallucinating a policy that does not exist to data leaks, and its methodological recommendation is to **attribute risk to the governance layer (knowledge boundaries, permission scope, escalation paths) rather than vaguely to "the model being bad"**[10-47][third-party verified]. Another cross-year compilation catalogues the most damaging AI agent failures, hallucinations, and safety incidents of 2025–2026 with their revenue losses, reputational damage, and legal liability, for use as **risk enumeration** — sorting the failure types that could happen to you before deciding which steps must retain human backup[10-48][third-party verified].

Condensed into a usable table, the three pieces give three kinds of responsibility and three lines of defence: knowledge responsibility (saying what should not be said) via boundaries and sampling; permission responsibility (doing what should not be done) via least privilege and approvals; escalation responsibility (failing to hand off to a human) via exit design and response-time commitments. **They map onto the three tables of Section 5.11 (definitions, tiering, timeline) — the same governance written once for service and once for risk.** A team that works only at the model layer (swapping in a stronger model, writing better prompts) will build none of the three lines.

10.15 The Cost of Unilateral Platform Rule Changes, and Compliance Becoming Auditable

The cheapest risk usually comes from the party you cannot negotiate with. One retrospective records a textbook platform risk: Anthropic changed its terms overnight to bar third-party use of consumer-plan OAuth tokens, breaking production systems for thousands of developers. The author's use of it is restrained — it is not evidence that "AI vendors are unreliable" but a **sample of single-point dependency from building a business on platform assumptions**: terms can change without any notice period, and business continuity can only be secured through multi-path design and credentials you own[10-49][third-party verified]. This is the same class of risk as the indexing switch in Section 3.18 and the directory rules in

Section 7.8: **in AI-powered customer operations, "admission" is never a one-time technical integration but a state of continuous exposure to someone else's decisions.**

On the compliance side, the operative standard has moved from "don't cross the line" to "be auditable." China's Cyberspace Administration, the Ministry of Industry and Information Technology, and the Ministry of Public Security jointly announced that 2026 will bring deeper enforcement against unlawful collection and use of personal information in apps, SDKs, and other services, with **internet advertising**, education, transport, health, and finance named as priority sectors[10-50] [official]. For teams running private-domain operations and outbound calling, internet advertising being named a priority sector means list sourcing, data provenance, and separate consent become routine inspection items. Third-party interpretation sets a more concrete expectation: the enforcement focus overlaps substantially with the Measures for the Administration of Compliance Audits of Personal Information Protection and its supporting guidelines, and with what audit firms actually examine — **the response is not to survive one inspection but to leave behind an evidence chain that would pass a compliance audit**[10-51][third-party verified].

Together, these two give the most practical operating advice at the end of Chapter 10: design both compliance and dependency risk on the assumption that you may be inspected at any time and your terms may change at any time. The former yields an evidence chain (data provenance, consent records, processing logs); the latter yields fallback paths (credentials you own, multi-platform integration, a replaceable integration layer). **Neither produces growth, but together they determine whether growth can continue.**

10.16 Whose Statement Is It? From Search Platforms to a Company's Own Chatbot

Section 10.12 covered how "the robot did it" stopped being a defence. This section adds the two hardest rulings of 2026, and what companies should do about them.

On the search-platform side, a German court moved first. On May 28, 2026, the Regional Court of Munich enjoined Google from disseminating false statements about two Munich publishing companies through AI search overviews, publishing its reasoning in June: a series of queries had led Google's AI Overview to associate Verlagshaus24 with fraud and subscription traps; the court found the AI

blended in information about other companies that did have problems, building an association that existed in none of the linked sources, and that Google had not responded adequately to the publishers' cease-and-desist letter. The key move was characterization — **because the AI compiles and summarises information itself, that constitutes an "independent statement" for which Google is responsible**, unlike earlier case law holding search engines not liable for their results; the court also found the false statement damaged commercial reputation and that repetition was likely, and granted the injunction[10-52][third-party verified]. The ruling turns "the AI answer was wrong" from a product-defect question into a legal-liability question.

On the company side, the same logic reached the self-built bot. A German case recorded by the U.S. Library of Congress's Global Legal Monitor held a medical company liable for wrong answers its own AI chatbot gave about staff qualifications. The difference from Munich is the actor — a search platform versus an enterprise's own service and advisory bot; the commonality is that **neither court accepted the defence "the model generated it, so it isn't what I said"**[10-53][official]. Line this up with Air Canada in 2024 and Hangzhou's holding that AI has no civil-subject status, and the boundary has moved clearly within two years: companies answer for their own bots, platforms answer for AI overviews, and Chinese courts first deny AI subjecthood and then define the provider's duties case by case. **The three lines do not conflict; they answer two ends of one question: AI cannot bear responsibility itself, but whoever deploys it can.**

Beyond liability sits a quieter cost: hallucinated reputational harm. A practitioner piece from Everything-PR notes that AI interfaces keep producing "confident false statements" about brands, executives and public figures, and that most such errors are never discovered by the brand — because nobody asks the model "what do you think of me" every day. Its framework has three layers: discover (turn brand-related questions into a fixed monitoring set, re-collect on a schedule and keep records), correct (fix crawlable first-party pages and structured facts rather than sending letters to platforms; route citation-type errors through platform correction channels), and narrate (write the error that occurred into public explanation, so that re-crawls do not treat the correction itself as new material). One counter-intuitive point: once an AI error enters the corpus it gets re-crawled and re-circulated, becoming "digital psoriasis" — a single correction does not guarantee it disappears[10-54][third-party verified]. **For an acquisition team these three layers**

are daily operations: the monitoring set is the measurement discipline from Section 3.20, correction means first-party fact pages, narration means public response — none requires litigation, all require an owner.

10.17 Summary

The boundaries of AI-powered customer lifecycle management condense into five points:

1. **Backlash**: AI outbound is killing cold email — channel dividends are one-time, and restraint is a strategy;
2. **Hallucination**: AI's mistakes are the company's mistakes — Air Canada paid, and the Hangzhou case was exempted (with disclosure); guardrails determine liability;
3. **Compliance**: regulators have caught up with AI selling — FTC/FCC/SEC/EU AI Act/China's labeling measures, and AI washing is illegal;
4. **The human-machine boundary**: AI impersonating real people is a global red line — trust is the foundation of customer operations;
5. **Liability**: companies bear responsibility, but AI liability insurance has appeared — a risk being insurable shows the industry is maturing.

The final chapter looks to the future: when customers themselves become AI, what will customer operations become?

Chapter 11 The Future: When the Customer Is an AI

In February 2026, CMSWire published a long essay titled "The Machine Customer Economy Has Begun." It offered a prediction that makes many operators uncomfortable: your next batch of customers may not be human.

"Machine customers" are smart devices and AI assistants that carry out service activities on behalf of humans — filing repair orders, renewing supplies, and comparison shopping. Gartner's prediction is more specific: by 2026, 20% of inbound customer-service contacts will come from machine customers[11-22] [third-party verified].

This chapter is about the future. But one clarification first: the future is not distant — it is already happening.

11.1 Agentic Commerce: AI Agents Shop for People

The definition of agentic commerce (agent-driven e-commerce) is simple: AI agents complete shopping on behalf of consumers — the AI anticipates needs, searches across and compares prices, negotiates, and places orders on their behalf[11-06] [third-party verified].

Scale predictions (cross-validated across institutions): - McKinsey: agentic commerce could generate $1 trillion in U.S. retail revenue by 2030[11-06] [third-party verified]; - Morgan Stanley: by 2030, nearly half of U.S. consumers will use AI agents, adding up to $115 billion in new spending to U.S. e-commerce[4-11] [third-party verified]; - Gartner: by 2028, AI agents will intermediate more than $15 trillion in B2B spending — 90% of B2B purchases will be handled by agents[11-13] [third-party verified]; - Deloitte: transaction traffic from AI assistants to U.S. retail sites is surging, and agentic commerce is redefining retail economics[11-05] [third-party verified].

Signs of real-world adoption have already appeared: in October 2025, Walmart was the first to partner with OpenAI, allowing users to complete purchases directly inside ChatGPT through Instant Checkout; a month later, Target followed with its own

AI shopping experience[11-16] [third-party verified]. Salesforce's 2025 holiday-season data shows: AI/agents accounted for a 20% share of retail, driving $262 billion; brands that deployed agents grew 59%[11-17] [official claims].

The shift in shopping patterns deserves one more emphasis: customers no longer "browse"; they "brief" — issuing a requirement instruction such as "I want a waterproof jacket for under €200," and the AI agent interprets, compares, and recommends across retailers[11-25] [third-party verified]. The web page is no longer the interface; an AI decision layer has become the new intermediary between customers and every retailer.

11.2 When the Buyer Is an AI, What Do You Sell?

This is a double shock for operators. The good news: AI agents are tireless 24/7 buyers that close deals efficiently. The bad news: **AI agents recognize only data, not brands** — when the buyer is an AI, human emotional assets like "brand affinity" are of no use.

So why would an AI agent choose you? ML6's answer, in four characters' worth of meaning: **machine-readable**. Product data (how structured it is, inventory truthfulness, price transparency, GTIN identifiers), reliable commerce signals (real-time inventory/pricing), and interoperable protocols and identity layers — "product data is upgraded from a hygiene task to a strategic asset"[11-25] [third-party verified]. BCG's reminder is just as critical: a retailer's most valuable customers may no longer be human — AI agents (embedded in Perplexity, ChatGPT, and Google Gemini) are taking over the discover, compare, decide, and order stages[11-14] [third-party verified].

An action checklist for operators: 1. **Data is the new storefront** — your product pages are for people to look at, but what AI agents read is your structured data feed; 2. **Trust signals must be machine-verifiable** — humans look at "brand reputation"; AI looks at "verifiable review data, warranty terms, and return policies"; 3. **Prepare for agent-to-agent transactions** — frameworks for machine-to-machine negotiation and data verification in B2B are taking shape[11-13] [third-party verified].

11.3 GEO: Being Cited by AI Is the New Channel

When customers — human or AI — get answers through ChatGPT, Perplexity, or Gemini, whether your brand gets cited becomes a matter of life and death.

As early as 2024, Gartner predicted that traditional search-engine traffic would fall 25% by 2026[11-12] [third-party verified]. The actual citation data cuts even deeper: original research by Boring Marketing (built on 14,750 real buyer questions tested) found that 53% of brands are completely invisible across the four mainstream AI platforms (ChatGPT/Perplexity/Claude/Gemini), with an overall citation rate of just 14% [11-03] [third-party verified].

Being cited by AI is not mysticism; it is observable and optimizable (Chapter 3 covered the case of Glasp doing AEO by reading its own server logs). Thirty-five percent of U.S. consumers already use AI at the product-discovery stage[11-23] [third-party verified] — GEO (generative engine optimization) is becoming a channel as important as SEO.

11.4 Trust: The Stronger the AI, the More Valuable the Human Touch

A chapter about the future should not be only about technology; it must also be about people — because the stronger the technology, the higher the premium on the "human touch."

The data paints two pictures that seem contradictory but are actually consistent:

Consumers trust AI to help them buy better. BCG's global survey (9,000+ respondents across 9 countries): more than 60% of consumers highly trust GenAI's results[11-08] [third-party verified]. Edelman's Trust Barometer shows brand trust surging in recent years — 80% of people trust the brands they use[11-01] [third-party verified].

But in customer service, consumers would rather talk to a real person. Metrigy's research: 85% of consumers prefer interacting with a human rather than an AI agent in customer service[11-15] [third-party verified]. A Medallia report predicts that nearly half of consumers believe that ten years from now they will no longer deal with any company directly — AI agents will do it for them — and that "human service" itself will become premium-priced: more than two-thirds of consumers believe human service will become an optional premium offering[11-24] [third-party verified].

Taken together, the two pictures point to a clear future: **routine transactions go to AI (consumers welcome this); at critical moments, they want a human (consumers vote with their feet)**. Human service will not disappear; it will become

a "luxury good" — and once AI handles 95% of standardized interactions, the remaining 5% of human interactions are the brand's entire battleground for differentiation. The boundary described in Chapter 2 will be drawn even wider in the future: AI handles scale, humans handle trust, and the premium on trust keeps rising.

11.5 The Machine-Customer Ledger: Early Numbers

The previous sections covered trends. This section pulls "machine customers" from narrative back to numbers.

One vendor compilation gathers the estimates of various institutions on agentic commerce: Bain forecasts the U.S. market at $300–500 billion by 2030, 15%–25% of e-commerce; Gartner predicts 20% of digital commerce transactions will go through AI platforms or agents by 2030; Morgan Stanley forecasts 10%–20% of U.S. e-commerce sales driven by agents; McKinsey estimates it can create about $1 trillion in orchestrated U.S. retail revenue and $3–5 trillion globally; J.P. Morgan expects up to 25% of U.S. online sales to flow via agents by 2030, concentrated in recurring, low-risk categories such as groceries and subscriptions. The consumer side is moving too: by 2030 nearly 50% of online shoppers are expected to use AI agents and contribute about 25% of spending, adding roughly $115 billion to U.S. e-commerce; Kearney estimates 60% of consumers expect to use AI agents in the next 12 months and 73% are familiar with AI tools; 63% of European consumers already use AI for shopping[11-26] [official claims]. These numbers come from different institutions with different methodologies, but the direction is the same — **"agents as the shopping entry point" is no longer a forecast but a ledger being cashed out.**

Merchant adoption is running ahead too: a payment provider's report says 42% of U.K. and U.S. merchants have already moved first on "AI agent commerce," with AI entry points reshaping the discover-compare-order chain[11-27] [official claims].

For brands, the real strategic question is not "whether to enter this entry point" but "once I'm in, am I still the protagonist." IBM's Institute for Business Value sums it up in one word — **own**: brands should "own" the agentic commerce experience rather than being intermediated by AI entry points. When purchase decisions are made by consumers' AI agents, brands' control over discovery, comparison, and purchase weakens, and they must win back the "right to be recommended" through data and

experience[11-28] [third-party verified]. This echoes the conclusion in 11.2: when the buyer is an AI, what you sell is a set of data and experiences that machines can read, verify, and trust.

Taken together with the earlier sections, the machine-customer ledger carries two numbers: an incremental market measured in hundreds of billions of dollars, and an existing risk of being "intermediated." The operator's job is to keep ownership of the customer relationship between those two numbers.

11.6 Protocols and Admission Tickets: The Barrier to Entry in the Machine-Customer Era

Section 11.1 described the shape of agentic commerce. By 2026 it has shifted from "who can build it" to "who can be plugged in" — protocols, policies, and fee schedules now form the admission ticket to the machine-customer era.

Is the protocol war over? In April 2026, Amazon, Meta, Microsoft, Salesforce, and Stripe joined the Universal Commerce Protocol technical committee, forming a ten-seat governance body with Google, Shopify, Etsy, Target, and Wayfair. UCP covers the entire shopping chain from discovery and purchase to after-sales support and is endorsed by more than 20 ecosystem players. But the author's judgment is that "the protocol war is over; the commercial war is not": UCP's advantage is not that its checkout API is pleasant, but that it can accommodate the complexity of real commerce — an agent must be able to ask on the user's behalf whether these three items can be bought with this coupon, shipped to this address, paid with this wallet, and stacked with loyalty benefits, while respecting the merchant's tax, risk, fulfillment, and return rules. The counter-evidence is equally clear: Amazon has not opened its marketplace to external agents, Meta has not handed Instagram commerce to a neutral protocol, and OpenAI shifted ChatGPT shopping in March 2026 from its first version of instant checkout to "product discovery plus merchant-controlled checkout"[11-29] [third-party verified].

Protocols imply a budget reshuffle. A comparative guide notes that ACP (OpenAI with Stripe, launched September 2025, living inside ChatGPT) and UCP (Google-led, covering AI Mode and Gemini) serve different purposes rather than competing — ChatGPT excels at conversational product discovery while Google AI Mode captures high-intent search demand, so most brands will need to support both. The real implementation judgment is that agentic commerce is **infrastructure-first,**

not content-first: AI shopping agents do not read editorial content, they read structured data, evaluate feeds, and call APIs, so budget should shift from top-of-funnel content to bottom-of-funnel infrastructure — product data completeness, schema markup, feed hygiene, checkout API reliability, and server-side tracking. The same piece concedes that early agentic commerce "sells but cannot be measured": existing analytics stacks were designed for clicks and sessions and cannot fully attribute orders brought by AI agents[11-30] [third-party verified].

Platforms are already writing rules for agents. Amazon updated its Business Solutions Agreement effective March 4, 2026, adding a dedicated agent policy for the first time and imposing new requirements on AI use and automated systems[11-31] [official claims]. The detailed requirements include: defining an "AI seller agent" as a system that makes or executes decisions on a seller account without real-time human input for each action; requiring all automation to run through registered SP-API applications, with browser automation and Seller Central scraping explicitly prohibited; mandating a 12-month audit trail for automated actions and self-identification as an automated system; and requiring human authorization for high-impact actions (for example, price changes above 20% within 24 hours)[11-32] [third-party verified]. The strategic implication matters more than the technical detail: generative search and shopping agents often cannot see a marketplace's on-site listings, so brands must build complete product content on their own channels and treat marketplaces as conversion venues rather than discovery venues — otherwise they go silent at the AI discovery stage.

In the Chinese market the money is re-routing too. Effective August 10, 2026, Douyin's local-services arm applies a separate fee schedule to hotel orders completed through the Doubao entry point: an 11.4% software service fee plus a 0.6% payment processing fee, about 12% combined. Doubao's response is that its local-services business currently runs no paid promotion and merchants cannot influence recommendations or ranking by paying; only a channel service fee is charged after an order is completed[11-33] [third-party verified]. Simultaneous data shows the scale of the entry point: as of June 2026, AI-native apps reached 499 million monthly active users, up 85.4% year over year, with Doubao first at 382 million. The industry reading is that the AI assistant's role in local-services transaction chains has formally shifted from a platform's "organic traffic entry point" to an **independent transaction channel** — though binding AI recommendations to commercial interests faces a long-term "trust gap."

Payment infrastructure is moving faster than protocols. Alipay reported that AI agent payments have passed 300 million transactions and support 95% of general-purpose agent frameworks, and launched Token Pay and an AI wallet to complete a full-stack AI-native payment product matrix alongside its earlier "AI Pay" and "AI Collect"; on the protocol side it upgraded China's open trust framework for agentic commerce and was first to build A2A (agent-to-agent) and A2M (agent-to-machine) payment capability, while on the merchant side it released its first merchant operations agent[11-34] [official claims]. The cross-device layer has been filled in as well: Alipay released China's first multi-agent cross-device interconnection protocol system covering three layers — how to talk, how to connect, and how to act — prompted precisely by the first generation of "Doubao phones" being collectively blocked by major apps for using simulated taps, cross-app jumps, and screen reading to bypass restrictions. In one partnership between Alipay and a phone maker, the latter's AI assistant connected nearly 200 Alipay services, adding more than 2 million to Alipay's activity on that brand's handsets[11-35] [third-party verified]. On the cross-border side, Ant International's Agentic Mobile Protocol onboarded 10 digital wallets and 7 acquiring institutions covering 1.5 billion users at launch and coordinated with two major card networks on a Know-Your-Agent (KYA) trust framework, aiming to simplify agent onboarding and identification across networks while each party retains its own security verification and decision processes[11-36] [official claims].

Taken together, 2026 offers three admission tickets — which protocol you connect to, which agent policy you comply with, and which fee and identity framework you accept. None of them belongs to the marketing department, yet each directly determines whether a brand is visible to machine customers.

The card networks pushed "machine payments" from consumers to enterprises. In June 2026 Mastercard launched Agent Pay for Machines, positioned to let enterprises support secure, continuous machine payments across cards, accounts, and currencies, with the served parties extending from AI agents to devices and software programs — the second step, after the consumer-facing Agent Pay of April 2025, in which the payment network pushes agent payments toward enterprise-side machine transactions[11-41][official claims]. Visa started on the same day with a different direction: Intelligent Commerce positions itself as the trust layer for agentic shopping, sharing verifiable credentials among issuers, merchants, and AI platforms about whether an agent is user-authorized, what it may buy, and up to what limit; in April 2026 it added a protocol-agnostic merchant connection product designed to

accept agent orders from multiple protocols (Trusted Agent Protocol and others) at once[11-42][official claims]. Read together, the card networks are not competing over whose agent is better but over **whose authorization and verification standard gets adopted by everyone else** — a standards contest is a channel contest. For merchants, the real preparatory action is connecting a verifiable "agent identity and authorization" chain rather than adapting platform by platform.

11.7 Machine Customers' Money and Trust

The money is real. Amazon's CEO told an earnings call that its AI shopping assistant is on pace to drive more than $10 billion in incremental annual sales, and that customers who use it are 60% more likely to complete a purchase than those who do not. The measurement basis is worth noting: the $10 billion is measured by Amazon's internal "downstream impact" metric using a seven-day rolling attribution model to capture delayed conversions — the assistant's value is counted as the indirect sales it triggers, not direct clicks[11-37] [third-party verified]. That also implies something: once the assistant itself becomes an acquisition and advertising vehicle, the measurement basis has to be redesigned, or this value stays invisible in the reporting.

Both volume and quality of the channel are changing. Adobe Analytics data shows AI referral traffic to U.S. retail sites in July 2026 was up 62% year over year and up 1,219% cumulatively compared with October 2024, when generative platforms began to spread; more important is quality — in July, AI-referred visitors converted 60% better than non-AI traffic (54% in May)[11-38] [third-party verified]. A retailer-side data compilation offers another basis: AI referral traffic to U.S. retail sites grew 393% year over year in the first quarter of 2026, with AI-referred visitors spending 48% more time and viewing 13% more pages; on the consumer side, 42% used an AI shopping tool in the past month, 5% have let a fully autonomous AI agent place an order, and 85% say AI improved their shopping experience — while 42% of shopping-related AI conversations are "selection and inspiration" queries rather than direct orders[11-39] [third-party verified]. High intent matters more than high volume — but that requires brands to first fix landing-page validation, product merchandising logic, and cross-channel attribution.

Trust is the only speed limit. A brand-side guide cites survey figures that must be read together: consumer adoption of agentic shopping is projected to rise from 19% to 46% by the end of 2026, but only 10% of consumers are willing to let an agent

operate fully independently — the vast majority still want human confirmation in the purchase decision — while 83% of consumers have concerns about privacy, data misuse, and unauthorized marketing[11-40] [official claims]. This matches the judgment in Section 11.4: the expansion rate of machine customers is set not by model capability but by how clearly authorization and refunds are defined. Brands face two risk surfaces — visibility risk (if agents do not recommend you, you do not make the shortlist) and trust risk (unclear control mechanisms directly suppress adoption).

Demand-side conservatism is moving far more slowly than the infrastructure. Put several independent data sets side by side and the gap is plain. Gartner's consumer research concludes that only 11% of U.S. consumers are willing to let AI make purchase decisions, and advises marketers to design AI shopping tools primarily as research support rather than as the decision-maker[11-43][third-party verified]. Payment company Checkout.com's research fills in the middle ground: 33% of consumers expect at least 10% of their purchases to be AI-driven within a year, and 72% of merchants believe consumers will adopt agent-led shopping faster than most merchants are prepared for; on the trust side, three figures form the drag — 27% of consumers trust no institution to run an AI shopping agent, 24% say they will never delegate a purchase to AI, and 57% are willing to let an AI agent switch brands for a better price[11-44][third-party verified]. The payment networks' own forecasts are the most expansive: a Mastercard report predicts that by 2030 more than one in ten online shoppers will routinely use an AI agent to choose and pay for them[11-45][official claims] — a claim whose provenance should be labeled clearly, since it is a payment network's self-interested forecast: the pipes only carry volume once they are built.

Read together, the four data sets point to one conclusion: infrastructure and expectations are running ahead of consumer authorization. That gap in between is precisely what brands and platforms must fill together (authorization, revocability, auditability).

On the B2B side, the migration path looks more like agent-to-agent. Deloitte judges that the future form of B2B commerce is multi-agent systems researching, negotiating, purchasing, and selling on behalf of enterprises: buyers spend nearly 30% more budget with suppliers that offer an excellent buying experience, and the perception gap between buyers and sellers about the sales process is widening — a gap that, compounded by the maturation of agentic AI, creates a window for sellers to get ahead; the article also projects that if agents are orchestrated strategically and risks appropriately mitigated, the market value of AI

agents could rise to $45 billion[11-46][third-party verified]. **Sellers must be legible to two kinds of readers at once** — with a website and sales process a human can understand, and with specifications, prices, terms, and inventory data an agent can read and compare directly.

A magnitude that agencies can plan around has appeared. Several agencies estimate that Perplexity's shopping business has reached an annualized GMV run rate approaching $2 billion; Perplexity has not confirmed the figure, so it should be read as a directional signal rather than an audited result. The growth comes from a change in answer format: when users ask shopping questions, the answer carries product cards alongside the usual sourced response, and Perplexity says these cards are relevance-ranked non-sponsored recommendations rather than paid slots. Transactions are carried by the subscription tier, and a free merchant program feeds retailers' (including Shopify stores') real-time product data into its index[11-47][third-party verified]. The significance lies in entry rules that invert search advertising: **free onboarding, ranked by relevance rather than bid** — which means a brand's "spend" here looks more like a contest of product data and content than a contest of budget.

11.8 The Layering of the Protocol Stack and the 2026 Retreat

Section 11.6 was about admission tickets. This round's details are more interesting: **the protocols are being layered, while 2025's product claims are already out of date.**

Three standards are not on the same layer; don't treat them as a three-way choice. A merchant guide lays out the 2026 agentic-commerce standards clearly: UCP (Google with Shopify, Etsy, Walmart, Target, and others) covers the full journey from discovery and cart to checkout and post-purchase, with merchants publishing capabilities through a `/.well-known/ucp` JSON manifest and supporting REST, A2A, and MCP transports; ACP (co-built by OpenAI and Stripe, open-sourced September 29, 2025) handles checkout execution, its first landing being Instant Checkout in ChatGPT, with Etsy the first merchant and more than a million Shopify merchants later connected; and AP2, now governed by the FIDO Alliance, handles payment authorization. The article notes that ACP "outlived its own product" — OpenAI scaled back Instant Checkout in March 2026, and the protocol retreated from a checkout product to a "pipe"[11-48][third-party verified].

A cross-border payments firm's explainer pinpoints ACP's key change: in March 2026 OpenAI scaled back native instant checkout and routed purchases back into merchant apps inside ChatGPT, "to some degree returning checkout control to merchants"; UCP, by contrast, takes an "open orchestration" route, with product retrieval queried by different agents across multiple platforms, authorization information and intent data transmitted with the request for the merchant's own risk checks, and the transaction still completed through the merchant's existing checkout page or payment service provider — the protocol serving as "a universal interaction language rather than the final landing vehicle"[11-49][third-party verified]. An architectural view offers a cleaner contrast: UCP is decentralized (merchants publish capabilities any agent can discover and transact with), ACP is platform-mediated (merchants submit data to OpenAI, which ChatGPT presents), and in practice merchants will likely implement both to maximize distribution, "just as retailers list on both Google Shopping and Amazon"; MCP is not a commerce protocol but a general tool-integration layer, relevant to commerce because both UCP and ACP explicitly support MCP as a transport binding[11-50][third-party verified].

The product-level correction matters more: don't treat 2025's announcements as the status quo. An explainer around OpenAI's March 2026 update says plainly that the first version of Instant Checkout did not offer the flexibility it wanted, so the direction shifted to product discovery and letting merchants use their own checkout experience, with Instant Checkout possibly available only for "eligible products and merchants"; any unverifiable order, payment, or delivery question should go to the responsible team[11-51][third-party verified]. A product-feed vendor's roundup adds the operational detail: Google's legacy Content API for Shopping is set to shut down on August 18, 2026, so programmatic access must migrate to the Merchant API; in May 2026 Google added six optional "conversational attributes" (question_and_answer, related_product, variant_option, item_group_title, popularity_rank, document_link), not required but giving AI shopping more structured context[11-52][third-party verified]. **The same Merchant Center feed is also read by Microsoft Copilot — the structure of the feed determines whether AI can understand you.**

The platforms' official positions give the channel differences: Shopify's blog explains that Perplexity shopping is driven by a free merchant program using a Google Shopping-format feed; Perplexity completes in-conversation purchases via PayPal; Google AI Mode supports Shopify-powered in-conversation checkout, with eligible,

opted-in orders flowing into the Shopify back end like ordinary orders; and ChatGPT presents products through Shopify Catalog and directs buyers via an in-app browser to the merchant's own store. Shopify merchants can be discovered in ChatGPT automatically through Shopify Catalog, with no extra setup[11-53][official claims].

11.9 How Much Room Consumers Give AI Shopping Agents to Make a Mistake

Section 11.7 said trust is the only rate limiter. Consumer surveys in the first half of 2026 measured that limiter's value: **the tolerance is extremely low.**

A survey commissioned by payments-technology firm ACI Worldwide and run by YouGov among 2,080 UK adults (June 19–22, 2026) delivers the headline: **six in ten UK consumers say that if an AI shopping agent makes one mistake, they will stop using it**; consumers have clear concerns about "control, money, and who is responsible" — that is, about an agent spending on their behalf and who answers when it errs[11-54][third-party verified]. For merchants preparing to hand the closing step to an agent, this is a "near-zero error tolerance" demand-side signal.

Klaviyo's reading of its 2026 AI Consumer Trends Report gives tiered trust: only 13% of consumers "fully trust" AI, 36% "somewhat trust" it, and 30% are neutral; on shopping recommendations specifically, 85% have at least some trust that AI provides accurate, personalized recommendations, and 39% have bought an AI-recommended product in the past six months; but only 54% trust AI to provide good customer service through a conversational agent — **trust in the "recommendation" scenario is clearly higher than in the "service" scenario.** On the brand side, 32% of consumers would trust a brand less for using AI-generated content, and nearly one in five sees low-quality or formulaic AI content from brands weekly. Klaviyo's advice is not to remove human review and to route complex support requests back to people[11-55][third-party verified].

Alchemer's 2026 Retail Report (1,002 U.S. shoppers) is titled "retail AI adoption outpaces consumer trust": 48.5% of shoppers have used an AI tool to research a purchase in the past year; by age, 74% of 18–29-year-olds have done so versus only 20% of those 61 and older, and the youngest group is nine times as likely as the oldest to "discover their most recent purchase through an AI tool"[11-56][third-party verified]. **Read alongside ACI's six-in-ten error tolerance, this gives the real**

constraint on the expansion of machine customers: it is not that the model is too weak, but that users give the agent a trial-and-error budget of exactly one.

And autonomy is already tiered inside products. A postmortem on Amazon's shopping agent Rufus lays out three product lines: Q&A, Buy for Me (letting Rufus browse and compare off-Amazon items, with the final purchase still requiring user approval), and Auto Buy (fully autonomous, limited to Prime members and FBA items, with a default six-month monitoring window that buys automatically when the price is hit — Amazon says users save about 20% on average). For sellers, Rufus favors items with strong reviews and clear descriptions, sparse or low-quality listings become "invisible to Rufus," and the AI Q&A section has shifted from an afterthought to a primary data source for AI recommendations[11-57][third-party verified]. This closes the loop with Section 11.6: **before machine customers, visibility comes from the completeness of data and reviews, not from the media budget.**

11.10 The Second Inventory of the Protocol Stack: The ACP–UCP Split

Sections 11.6 and 11.8 covered protocols and the pullback. This round's increment is **an engineering-level comparison of the two routes**, which turns "which protocol do we pick" from a matter of judgment into a matter of scheduling.

The structural difference between the two routes. An engineering practice piece compares OpenAI's ACP with Google's UCP layer by layer. **ACP (Agentic Commerce Protocol)** was released by OpenAI and Stripe in September 2025 under Apache 2.0 and consists of three parts: a product feed (merchants push structured catalogue data, where OpenAI is investing the most), checkout sessions (REST contracts to create, update, and complete a checkout, which merchants may accept or decline while retaining merchant-of-record status), and delegated payment; the latest stable spec is dated April 17, 2026, with the United States first, and because in-app checkout struggled, most buyers have been routed back to merchants' own checkout since March 2026. **UCP (Universal Commerce Protocol)** was launched by Google on January 11, 2026 at NRF, co-developed with Shopify, Walmart, Target, and others, covering discovery, comparison, cart, checkout, order tracking, and post-purchase across the full lifecycle; its architecture is decentralized — merchants publish a JSON profile at `/.well-known/ucp` and agents call merchant endpoints based on it; it sits

alongside MCP, A2A, and AP2 rather than replacing them, its latest spec is dated August 25, 2026, it is live in the United States with Canada and Australia in progress, and its account system uses OAuth 2.0 for identity linking. **The split in one sentence: ACP is a centralized pipe that feeds the catalogue into ChatGPT; UCP is a capability contract the agent discovers on your own domain** — the former's data freshness depends on syncing on a platform outside your control, the latter's on your own APIs; ACP keeps conversion on your site, UCP can complete the transaction inside Google[11-58][third-party verified].

A side branch: four-way competition in payment protocols. Another comparison sets MPP, ACP, AP2, and x402 side by side with their respective positioning and technical form: ACP defines the checkout interaction between agent and merchant through four RESTful endpoints (create, update, complete, cancel checkout), with payment handled via SharedPaymentTokens[11-59][third-party verified]. The timeline has also been pieced together: in September 2025 Google launched AP2 with more than 60 partners including American Express and Mastercard, standardizing through an open protocol how AI agents complete financial transactions securely on a user's behalf; less than two weeks later OpenAI launched Instant Checkout (with Stripe and Shopify, generally available for purchases from Etsy sellers)[11-60][third-party verified]. **The closeness of those two dates is itself the clearest footnote to this competition: standards are grabbed and published, not slowly negotiated.**

On the payment side, the action centres on tokens. Stripe announced an expansion of its Shared Payment Tokens — SPTs let an AI agent initiate payment with the customer's authorization and preferred method without exposing underlying credentials, and Etsy and URBN (including Anthropologie, Free People, and Urban Outfitters) have adopted them broadly; the new capability connects SPTs to network-led agent payment capabilities, namely Mastercard Agent Pay and Visa Intelligent Commerce, as well as buy-now-pay-later[11-61][official]. The payment provider Checkout.com proposes five building blocks for security, and the first deserves particular note: **agent identity — a "know your agent" (KYA) framework modelled on KYC, giving each AI agent a distinct digital identity so merchants, issuers, and card networks can recognize agent-initiated transactions**; the others are dedicated credentials, secure authentication, fraud prevention, and end-to-end observability[11-62][official claims].

The Chinese-language framing of this is the most thorough. A People's Daily Online report defines agent-initiated payment as a change in payment logic rather than "AI-assisted ordering": with the user pre-setting permissions, budget, scenario, and rules, the AI agent independently completes requirement parsing, price comparison and ordering, fund transfer, and reconciliation, with no need for the consumer to confirm each step. Tian Lihui (Chinese: 田利辉), dean of the Institute of Finance and Development at Nankai University (Chinese: 南开大学), offers three formulations worth reading word for word: payment moves from "the human confirms" to "the system judges intent," from "human-led" to "human–machine co-decision"; **the transaction unit upgrades from a product to a task — the user no longer buys a single item but a complete solution, with "travel" replacing "airfare"**; and payment logic evolves from bilateral transactions into multilateral network coordination[11-63][state media].

The operational implication lives in the rollout path. The engineering comparison offers a 12-week sequence: weeks 1–4 fix the data layer (variant modelling, GTINs, inventory sync latency, rewriting copy in conversational attributes, exposing real-time price and inventory APIs); weeks 4–8 pick the first protocol by traffic source (Google search and Shopping ads to UCP; research-mode shopping in ChatGPT to an ACP feed; on Shopify use Agentic Storefronts directly; self-built or headless, start with UCP and then ACP); weeks 8–12 abstract catalogue, cart, and checkout into an internal "commerce capability service," expose it first as MCP tools, and add thin ACP/UCP adapters on top — **the goal being to avoid rewriting checkout with every spec revision**[11-58][third-party verified]. That advice matches the foundation-layer logic of Chapter 7: **protocols change; the capability layer does not have to.**

11.11 Converging Distribution Entries, and the New Wording of the Ticket In

The last piece of the machine-customer chapter is **where these agents get found**.

Stores are converging from fragmentation into a few entry points. One study traces the 2026 convergence of AI agent marketplaces and directories, naming Microsoft Marketplace, Salesforce Agentforce, Google Gemini Enterprise, ChatGPT Workspace Agents, and the Claude Skills directory, and putting the open Agent Skills

ecosystem at more than 1.2 million entries[11-64][third-party verified]. On the channel side, the move of the period is consolidation: Salesforce merged AgentExchange, Slack Marketplace, and the Agentforce ecosystem into a single entry point where customers can discover, buy, activate, and manage agents, apps, and capabilities[11-65] [official claims]. **The cost and the benefit of convergence are the same fact: a listing's marginal exposure rises, and so does concentration of exposure to platform rule changes.** Compare the "directory dividend versus directory noise" data from Section 3.14 (the GPT Store hosted more than 3 million custom GPTs by early 2026, diluting the organic discoverability of any single entry) and a pragmatic conclusion follows: **listing is necessary but not sufficient; off-platform traffic and distribution beyond the charts are the real acquisition.** A directory does not make you visible; it only makes you eligible to be seen.

Platforms have already written down how the ticket in works. Amazon added specific clauses to its updated Business Solutions Agreement and Seller Central terms governing "automated systems and AI Agents acting on behalf of sellers," drawing the line cleanly: **scraping Seller Central for data is prohibited, while automation through the official SP-API is allowed**[11-66][third-party interpretation]. The implication extends beyond Amazon — **in the machine-customer era, compliance is not about whether you may automate but along which channel you automate**: automation through official interfaces is permitted, while simulated logins and scraping are not. Tool selection therefore directly determines account risk.

And the machine customer has already arrived. The shopping agents reviewed in Section 11.9 are already running three product lines at different levels of autonomy, and their user scale and the sales they drive are turning "being recommended by an agent" into a new ranking slot. Put that together with the consumer-trust data in Section 11.7 and the 2026 picture is complete: **agents buy, humans watch; platforms converge entry points and rewrite the rules; and what brands have to do is half making themselves callable in protocols and directories, and half showing real evidence to the people who come back to their own turf.** The first mirror in Chapter 3 and the last shelf in this chapter are, in fact, two ends of the same chain.

11.12 After the Cart Is Merged: A Payment Rail That Arrived First, Protocols That Arrived First

Section 11.3 covered "being cited by AI is a new channel," and 11.8 covered the protocol stack's layers and the 2026 retrenchment. This section looks at two moves in the autumn of 2026 — one from the shelf on the search side, one from the rail on the payment side.

The shelf has been merged into a cross-retailer cart. In October 2026 Google opened Universal Cart to U.S. users (previewed at I/O in May), available in Google Search's AI Mode and the Gemini app: a single cart can hold products from different retailers, track price and stock changes, suggest savings, and return to the merchant's own site to complete a purchase when needed. Retailers integrated or supported include Ulta Beauty, Walmart, Wayfair and some Shopify merchants, with Newegg the latest name to join UCP checkout in October. Google senior director of product management Suresh Ganapathy's example is concrete: save a Steve Madden bag in AI Mode, a Quince sweater and an Ulta lipstick in Gemini, and they are all still in the cart when you come back[11-67][third-party verified]. **The implication is direct: once the shelf is merged into a cross-retailer cart, brands stop competing on "store-page conversion rate" and start competing on being included by the cart's recommendation logic.**

China took another road: payments first. A Chinese-language Business Wire release citing Ant Group data reports that in the week of February 5–11, 2026, Alipay AI Pay processed more than 120 million transactions[11-68][third-party verified]. The number matters less for its size than for its nature: **"AI places the order for the user" in China is no longer a demo but a payment rail carrying real volume, and it sits on existing payment infrastructure — users install nothing new, and merchants integrate no new protocol.** That is the mirror image of the U.S. path, where ACP and UCP build protocols from zero: China connected payments first and is adding protocols after; the U.S. is standardizing protocols first and wiring payments in. For cross-market comparison, this is the hardest first-party transaction evidence on the China side.

Both roads hit the same wall. Checkout.com's survey concludes that consumers are already trying agents in everyday shopping and the industry is collaborating intensively on the protocols and standards the next stage of commerce needs, but adoption has outrun infrastructure; the gap sits in "trust infrastructure" —

payment authorization, liability, refunds and dispute handling have no settled practice when an agent buys on someone's behalf[11-69][third-party verified]. **That is the same coin as the two German rulings in Section 10.16: one side patches authorization and liability at the protocol layer, the other asks in court whose statement the AI's output is.** A machine customer requires two tickets, one protocol and one payment; holding either alone is not enough — the missing one decides whether you are still on the shelf next year.

11.13 Closing: The Next Decade of Customer Operations

Threading the whole book together, the evolution of AI-powered customer lifecycle management can be summarized in three phases:

Phase 1 (2023-2025): Tool substitution. Companies treat AI as a tool that replaces repetitive work — AI support, AI outbound, AI analytics. The winners in this phase are the most efficient companies; the losers are those that optimized customer service as a pure cost center (the Klarna lesson).

Phase 2 (2025-2027): Process redesign. Companies rebuild their customer-operations processes around AI — AI-native CRM, CSQL, outcome-based pricing. The winners in this phase are the companies with the cleanest data, because AI's ceiling is set by data quality.

Phase 3 (2027-): Ecosystem change. Customers themselves begin to turn into AI — machine customers, agent-to-agent transactions. The winners in this phase are the companies that make their businesses something AI agents can "read."

The three phases are not replacements for one another; they stack. The reality of 2026: most companies are still struggling in Phase 1 (74% stuck in pilots — see Chapter 8), a few leaders have already run into Phase 2, and the wave of Phase 3 has already reached the shore.

What this book can do is lay out the map across the three phases: the engine (Chapters 3-6), the foundation (Chapter 7), the organization (Chapter 8), the industry (Chapter 9), and the boundaries (Chapter 10). The rest of the road, operators must walk themselves.

Finally, back to Klarna from the preface. It went from "AI does the work of 700 support agents" to "we went too far" and then back to hiring people again — a complete cycle in two years. The value of this cycle lies not in its conclusion but in its

process: it proved the enormous capacity of AI-powered customer lifecycle management, and it proved that customers are people, not tickets. **The entire art of AI-powered customer lifecycle management is to use the scale of AI to serve every individual person well.**

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Appendix B: Common Metrics

A quick-reference table of the metrics commonly used in AI-powered customer lifecycle management, organized by stage of the customer lifecycle.

Acquisition

Metric	Meaning	Reference benchmark
CAC (customer acquisition cost)	The total cost of acquiring one new customer	Varies by channel; commonly from a few thousand to over ten thousand dollars in B2B SaaS
CPL (cost per qualified lead)	The cost of acquiring one qualified sales lead	Blue Yonder case: fell to $145 after ABM + intent data
Cold email reply rate	Share of outbound emails that receive a reply	Generally below 5% in 2026; AI templated outreach decayed 60%+ over 18 months
AI SDR reply-rate decay	How the effectiveness of AI outreach changes over time	11.2% (launch) → 4.4% (18 months)

Conversion

Metric	Meaning	Reference benchmark
Conversion rate	Rate at which visitors/ leads convert into customers	E-commerce industry bottleneck of 2-3%; AI personalization can lift it by up to 25%
Revenue per visitor (RPV)	Revenue contributed by a single visitor	AI personalization lifts it by 20%+ on average
AI dynamic-pricing gains	Revenue change from real-time pricing	Airline load factors 72% → 80%+ (with fares actually lower)

Service

Metric	Meaning	Reference benchmark
Deflection rate (auto-resolution rate)	Share of conversations AI resolves without handoff to a human	Intercom Fin: 50-70%; vendor-reported figures commonly 60-80%, 30-40 percentage points above independent data
Average resolution time	Time from a question being raised to it being resolved	Klarna: AI 11 minutes → 2 minutes (humans ~12 minutes)
CSAT (customer satisfaction)	Customers' satisfaction score for the service	Klarna: AI on par with human agents
AI support ROI	Return for every $1 invested	Vendor-reported ~$3.5; independent data significantly lower

Retention & Expansion

Metric	Meaning	Reference benchmark
Churn rate	Share of customers lost over a period	US businesses lose $136.8 billion annually to avoidable churn
NRR (net revenue retention)	Net revenue change contributed by existing customers	Median 100-115%; top quartile 115-130%; best-in-class 130%+ (usage-based platforms)
Health score	Composite metric of a customer's likelihood to renew/churn	73% of companies admit their current health scores cannot reliably predict churn
Win-back rate	Share of dormant customers successfully reactivated	AI-driven win-back ~22% vs. 5-10% for bulk sends

Organization & Change

Metric	Meaning	Reference benchmark
Share of selling time	Time salespeople actually spend with customers	Only ~25% (Bain)
New-rep ramp time	Time for a rep to go from onboarding to reaching quota	AI role-play: 210 days → 72 days (Hyperbound × Vanta)
ARR per FTE (output per employee)	Annualized revenue contributed per employee	Fleet of AI agents: $370,000 → $640,000 (ICONIQ)

> Note: The metrics in this table use the conventions adopted throughout this book. Most "benchmarks" vary widely by industry and methodology—when citing, defer to the original sources in Appendix A.

Appendix C: Version History and Update Notes

This book is a "living book"—material keeps accumulating and the version keeps growing. This appendix records what each version updated and why.

v1.0.7 (2026-10-18, weekly update)

- Chapter 3 adds "Three Ledgers for AI Visibility": Hendricks' 480-question, four-engine collection (16,069 citations, only 72 of ChatGPT's 480 answers carrying a citation, maximum cross-engine Jaccard of 0.181), Walker Sands on 828 large B2B firms (the median company cited in just 3% of the relevant AI Overviews), Discovered Labs' 0.030 correlation between review scores and AI descriptions, and AuthorityTech's sampling rules for Share of Voice versus Share of Citation
- Chapter 4 adds "The Margin Sheet": ICONIQ's 52% gross margin for AI companies (41% in 2024), inference rising from 20% to 23% of spend, a 5x price spread within one vendor and roughly 90% cache-read discounts, GitHub Copilot moving to usage-based billing after agentic loops lost money, and 18% of AI companies pricing on outcomes
- Chapter 9 adds "New Industry Signals (Part Five)": Harvey at $150–300 per seat per month with 30–50% of seats sitting at low usage, and seven logistics cases (Ryder, Walmart's 19% e-commerce return rate, Maersk, freight identity fraud)
- Chapter 10 adds "Whose Statement Is It?": the Regional Court of Munich holding an AI Overview to be Google's own "independent statement," a German medical company held liable for its own chatbot, and a three-layer playbook for hallucinated reputational harm (discover, correct, narrate)
- Chapter 11 adds "After the Cart Is Merged": Google Universal Cart opening to U.S. users, Alipay AI Pay processing 120 million transactions in a single week, and Checkout.com's "trust infrastructure" gap
- Appendix A adds 13 sources (3-109 to 3-112 / 4-28 / 9-113 to 9-114 / 10-52 to 10-54 / 11-67 to 11-69), synced across both languages

v1.0.6 (2026-10-11, weekly update)

- Chapter 3 adds "The Third Reading on Zero-Click," "The Second Layer of Visibility," and "The Second Check-Up for AI SDRs": SparkToro's 68.01% zero-click figure, Define Media Group's 42% click decline, Seer's AIO CTR falling 65% before rebounding, Google's three-tier "Search generative AI control," SearchScore's finding that 19,998 domains block GPTBot while allowing OAI-SearchBot, BCW's Credibility Paradox, BrightLocal on AI local recommendations rising from 6% to 45%, Attentive (AI traffic up 62% but only 10% of purchases completed inside the chat), a 100,000-email cold-email comparison (AI 4.1% versus human 5.2%), OneAway (41% of enterprise teams running an AI SDR, 40–60% of pilots shut down within 90 days), and Gmail's 0.08% complaint-rate threshold
- Chapter 4 adds "The Boundary of an Outcome": the billing trap of treating 72 hours of silence as resolution, Intercom Fin's outcome billing definitions, Zapier and Decagon falling back to more measurable units, and Growth Unhinged (three-quarters of software companies repriced within a year; AI product gross margins near 50%)
- Chapter 5 adds "The Rollback Wave" and "The Third Reconciliation on Resolution Rate": 74% of enterprises reverting on AI support, a full Klarna postmortem (853 FTE and about $60 million a year saved, and three causes of the walk-back), the Fin-versus-Decagon dispute over how resolution is defined, Superkind, Decagon's customer results, and Fin's three-year return curve
- Chapter 6 adds "The Leaky Bucket" and "The Argument About Health-Score Inputs": ChartMogul's retention tiers across 3,500 software companies (AI-native products under $50 a month at 23% GRR), enterprise NRR of 118%, Bessemer's seven product moats, Gainsight's finding that 74% still assess health manually, static health scores missing 40–60% of high-risk accounts, and DevRev's five-layer signal stack by lead time
- Chapter 7 adds "CRM Agent-Readiness": a seven-dimension comparison of Salesforce and HubSpot, HubSpot Breeze's outcome-based pricing, MCP's donation to the Linux Foundation's Agentic AI Foundation, and the governance gap in enterprise MCP registries

- Chapter 8 adds "The Shift in Budget Share, and the Return on Role-Play": AI tools rising from 11% to 18% of marketing budgets, Salesforce's 2026 State of Sales (87% using AI, 54% having deployed agents), and AI sales role-play cutting ramp time 38–42%
- Chapter 9 adds "New Industry Signals (Part Four)": Capgemini on where financial-sector AI agents land (customer service 75%, account opening 59%) and the new supervisory roles, a proactive agentic-service cancellation case, and a law-firm view of the new gatekeepers and how responsibility is split
- Chapter 10 adds "Attributing Blow-Ups" and "The Cost of Unilateral Platform Rule Changes": the factual-versus-faithfulness hallucination distinction and 69–88% hallucination rates on legal queries, attributing AI support failures to the governance layer, Anthropic's OAuth terms change, and the 2026 special campaign on personal information protection (with internet advertising named a priority sector)
- Chapter 11 adds "The Second Inventory of the Protocol Stack" and "Converging Distribution Entries": an ACP-versus-UCP comparison with a 12-week rollout path, four agentic payment protocols, Stripe SPTs and the Mastercard/Visa network layer, Checkout.com's KYA framework, People's Daily Online on autonomous payment and the transaction unit upgrading "from a product to a task," Salesforce's AgentExchange consolidation, and Amazon's compliance line between the SP-API and scraping
- Appendix A adds 58 sources (3-94 to 3-108 / 4-24 to 4-27 / 5-54 to 5-60 / 6-38 to 6-43 / 7-42 to 7-45 / 8-54 to 8-57 / 9-110 to 9-112 / 10-46 to 10-51 / 11-58 to 11-66), synced across both languages
- Glossary: the source-annotation mapping table gains rows for [official], [state media], [vendor content], [third-party interpretation], and [third-party verified: vendor figures]

v1.0.5 (2026-10-04, weekly update)

- Chapter 3 adds "The Methodology of AI Visibility: A Single Snapshot Will Lie" and "Entry Points Re-Valued: Super-Apps Turn Services into Callable Atomic Capabilities": AirOps stability data (only 30% of brands stay visible across two adjacent answers), a University of St. Gallen paper on measuring GEO (Jaccard similarity of 0.34–0.42 for cited sources on adjacent days), 5W's citation-source

audit (Wikipedia plus Reddit above 25% of ChatGPT citations), Profound's market-by-market index (46%–59% of citations flowing to domestic domains), Onely's traffic data (organic CTR on AI Overview queries down 61%), WeChat and Alipay turning mini-programs into AI-callable atomic capabilities, the more than 10,000 services connected to Alipay's "Abao" agent, DeepLumen's Agentic Page, the QuestMobile Q1 2026 ranking (Doubao at 345 million MAU), and Juliang Qianchuan's average CPM rising from 80 yuan in 2023 to 120 yuan in 2026

- Chapter 4 adds "Beyond Attribution: High ROAS Is Not High Growth" and "Synthetic Consumers: Compressing User Research from Weeks to 24 Hours": incrementality measurement and holdouts, eBay's brand-term experiment and Uber's mobile-ad incrementality test, and PyMC Labs' synthetic-consumer guide
- Chapter 5 adds "AI Support's Rocky Start": Qualtrics finding nearly one in five sees no benefit from AI support, and Cognizant on AI amplifying corporate incentives
- Chapter 7 adds "The Directory and Shelf of Agents": the official MCP registry, Alibaba Cloud's Fanhua Plan 2.0 upgrading its cloud marketplace into an AI application marketplace, and Cloudflare Agents Week 2026
- Chapter 8 adds "The Last Mile of Budget": Gartner's CMO spend survey (70% want to be AI leaders but only 30% have the infrastructure, with the people share rising to 24.5%)
- Chapter 9 adds "New Industry Signals (Part Three)": brokerages moving from in-house builds to open ecosystems, Freshfields turning AI into a business line, and Warner Music opening an AI engineering center in Bangalore
- Chapter 10 adds "The Liability of AI Support" and "The Shutdown of Anthropomorphic Agents and the Mandate to Label": Air Canada and the OLG Hamm ruling that "the robot did it" is no defence, the China Consumers Association's warnings and complaint cases on AI services, Doubao/Qwen/Yuanbao shutting down agent features, and graded AI-labeling penalties on Douyin, Xiaohongshu, and WeChat Channels
- Chapter 11 adds "Protocol Stack Layering and the 2026 Pullback" and "How Much Room Consumers Give AI Shopping Agents to Make a Mistake": the UCP/ACP/AP2 layers, OpenAI scaling back Instant Checkout, the Content API for Shopping migrating to the Merchant API, consumer-trust surveys from ACI/Klaviyo/Alchemer, and Amazon Rufus's Buy for Me and Auto Buy

- Appendix A adds 41 sources (3-82 to 3-93 / 4-21 to 4-23 / 5-53 / 7-39 to 7-41 / 8-52 to 8-53 / 9-107 to 9-109 / 10-39 to 10-45 / 11-48 to 11-57), synced across both languages

v1.0.4 (2026-09-27, weekly update)

- Chapter 3 adds "AI Visibility Has Grown a Dashboard — and a Price Tag" and "Two Falsifications of New Channels": Profound's $96 million Series C at a $1 billion valuation, GEO being formalized academically, Semrush showing 13 weeks of citation volatility (Reddit in ChatGPT falling from about 60% to about 10%), Muck Rack showing 84% of AI citations coming from earned media, G2 finding 51% of B2B buyers now starting research with an AI chatbot, AI Mode cutting off-site clicks by 18.8 percentage points, and 8 million user-built agents in Doubao alongside the GEO city-franchise bubble
- Chapter 3 adds backlash and acquisition-test material: Claude embedding invisible watermarks in generated text, a self-built AI SDR spending 400 hours to lift reply rate from 1% to 2%, and Jintai Technology going from 80,000 unanswered cold emails to three months' worth of the previous three years' inquiries using a sales agent
- Chapters 4 and 5: Instacart's white-label Cart Assistant turning AI shopping guidance into a rentable capability; Notion adopting Decagon for 34% faster ticket resolution, double the deflection, and only 3.4% of conversations reaching a human
- Chapter 6 adds "After Churn Attribution Is Handed to an Agent": ChurnZero's retrospective churn-attribution agent, Lunit's 110% NRR with a 1.5% annual churn rate, Sam's Club turning churn prediction into an ad audience, and why discounting to save a renewal is an NRR trap
- Chapter 7 adds "The Middle Layer of Attribution": the attribution blind spot for cross-ecosystem agents, next-generation CDPs collecting data before it is generated, the 6sense MCP server reaching general availability, and Salesforce AIforce turning CRM into a layer of agent-callable capabilities
- Chapter 8 adds "The Center of Gravity in Sales Is Shifting Backward": Zhipu and MiniMax doubling revenue while cutting sales spending, and Salesforce's Agentic Enterprise Index data on agent scale and stability

- Chapter 9 adds finance to the industry chapter: Ping An's discipline of counting business volume before approving AI projects, and the human–machine division of labour in claims
- Chapter 10 adds "Boundaries of Liability" and "Automation Impersonating Real People": the Hangzhou Internet Court ruling that inaccurate AI information is not necessarily infringement, the BBC finding 51% of news answers flawed with 19% introducing factual errors, the Shanghai Consumer Council's 618 report putting AI matching accuracy at 16.06%, and dating apps using more than 4,700 AI personas to impersonate real people
- Chapter 11: the trust-layer contest between Mastercard Agent Pay for Machines and Visa Intelligent Commerce, the consumer-delegation gap (Gartner: 11% willing to let AI make purchase decisions, 24% never delegating), Deloitte's judgment on B2B agent-to-agent commerce, and Perplexity's shopping GMV running at nearly $2 billion annualized
- Appendix A adds 39 sources (3-69 to 3-81 / 4-20 / 5-52 / 6-33 to 6-37 / 7-35 to 7-38 / 8-50 to 8-51 / 9-106 / 10-34 to 10-38 / 11-41 to 11-47), synced across both languages

v1.0.3 (2026-09-20, weekly update)

- Chapter 3 adds "Entry Points: In the Chinese Market, the Search Box Is Turning into a Dialogue Box," "AI Visibility: A Second Report Card Beyond Rankings," and "Agentish: The Boundary of Autonomous Prospecting"
- Chapter 5 adds "The Cost Ledger of Human Handoff Is Becoming a Compliance Ledger" and "Resolution Rate Becomes an Industry Unit, and People Are Re-Tiered by Value"
- Chapter 6 adds "From Health Scores to Triggers"
- Chapter 7 adds "Segmentation and Reach: A Postmortem on 4.04%"
- Chapter 8 adds "AI Will Not Save a Bad Process"
- Chapter 9 adds "New Industry Signals (Part Two): Turning 'Someone Has to Watch It' into Capacity"
- Chapter 10 adds "The Liability of AI Output Is Being Priced," "The Governance Time Lag on Outbound Calling," and "AI Poisoning: The Supply Chain of GEO Gray Markets"

- Chapter 11 adds "Protocols and Admission Tickets: The Barrier to Entry in the Machine-Customer Era" and "Machine Customers' Money and Trust"
- Appendix A adds 44 sources (3-55 to 3-68 / 5-48 to 5-51 / 6-30 to 6-32 / 7-34 / 8-46 to 8-49 / 9-104 to 9-105 / 10-25 to 10-33 / 11-29 to 11-40), synced across both languages

v1.0.2 (2026-09-13, weekly update)

- Chapter 3 adds "The AI-ization of Advertising and the Truthfulness of Traffic": conversational ads as a new entry point, AI-answer traffic converting 4.4x better, and 60% of Google app-install ads going to a bot farm
- Chapter 8 adds "FDE: The Intermediate State of AI Deployment" and "An Organizational Prescription for AI-Native Teams": 24 first-person FDE cases from Datawhale, three-bucket process redesign, and pods/Agent Champions/STO with system-quality metrics
- Chapter 9 adds "New Industry Signals": bank agent-platformization, more than 40% of agentic AI projects to be canceled in manufacturing, and citizens fearing government AI adoption is too slow
- Chapter 10 adds "When Agents Go Find Customers Themselves": 7 models running businesses autonomously for 72 hours with $0 revenue, colluding rogue agents and the RubyGems attack, and the financial-sector AI compliance backstop
- Chapter 11 adds "The Machine-Customer Ledger": institutional market estimates for agentic commerce and the risk of brands being intermediated
- Appendix A adds 20 sources (3-52 to 3-54 / 8-41 to 8-45 / 9-98 to 9-103 / 10-22 to 10-24 / 11-26 to 11-28), synced across both languages

v1.0.1 (2026-09-08, English edition renamed)

- The English edition title changed from *AI-Powered Customer Operations* to **AI Customer Lifecycle Management**, with the subtitle *Acquisition, Conversion, Service, Retention, and Expansion in the Age of AI*
- Rationale: "customer lifecycle management" is an established market search phrase and covers the book's full arc from acquisition to expansion, while "operations" reads as execution-layer scope and undersells the front stages

- Scope of the rename: English terminology throughout the book, the glossary, the PDF cover, and the site meta description; the Chinese title and Chinese content are unchanged

v1.0.0 (2026-09-06, initial public release)

- First public release: open for reading on the GitHub repository and the companion website
- Content status: preface + 11 main chapters + afterword + Appendices A/B/C; 247 key data points in the main text carry numbered citations, and Appendix A contains 399 sources (each traceable back to its original text)

v0.2 (2026-09-06, citation-annotation release)

- Added numbered superscripts to the 247 key data points across the 11 main chapters (placed after the data point and before the source annotation; clickable, jumping to the corresponding entry in Appendix A)
- Appendix A upgraded from plain-text numbering to anchor-based numbering: all 399 sources now carry `<a id>` anchors with "chapter-sequence" ids, with 0 dangling citations in the main text and 0 duplicate anchors
- Added cross-topic sources (e.g., the Glasp AEO case [3-51]) so that in-book citations remain self-consistent

v0.1 (2026-09-05, first draft)

- First draft complete: preface + 11 main chapters + Appendices A/B/C. Material came from the continuously growing knowledge base (on AI-powered customer lifecycle management: 398 bilingual Chinese-English items, each tagged [official claims] or [third-party verified])
- Chapter structure: organized around the five stages of the customer lifecycle (acquisition → conversion → service → retention → expansion), plus the foundation, organization, industries, the dark side, and the future
- Writing conventions: scene-based openings, success and failure cases side by side, traceable data, no authorial voice
- To-do: English translation (deferred); full source verification of key data points against the originals; revisions based on reader feedback

Afterword

This book has a completed first draft, but strictly speaking, it will never be finished.

The process of writing this book was itself an experiment in AI-powered customer lifecycle management. The material came from an automated collection pipeline: every day it scans the global news on AI and customer operations, then distills, translates, structures, and verifies sources before storing them in a knowledge base. From topic kickoff to 398 pieces of material took less than two weeks; from material to first draft took a few days. The Klarna case "grew" out of the material base on its own—the pipeline first collected the 2024 news that AI had done the work of 700 customer service agents, and months later collected the reversal, "we went too far." Put the two items side by side, and the opening of Chapter 1 wrote itself.

This is exactly what I want this book to convey, and the most essential thing about AI-powered customer lifecycle management: **AI does not think for you—it amplifies your thinking. AI does not run the customer lifecycle for you—it gives you the capacity to run it for many more customers.**

Throughout the writing, several cases kept reminding me:

Klarna reminded me that efficiency is not the goal—customers are. DPD reminded me that AI needs guardrails, just as cars need brakes. Artisan reminded me that a channel dividend is spent once, and restraint is a strategy. Octopus Energy reminded me that when AI support is done well, customers really do stay. Intercom's engineers reminded me that turning skeptics into believers takes only one genuinely good product.

If you have read this far, I hope you take three sentences away with you:

First: AI-powered customer lifecycle management has no silver bullet, but it has a map. This book is that map—engine, foundation, organization, industries, boundaries. Every company can find where it stands today.

Second: data before AI, organization before tools. 74% of companies are stuck in pilots, and seven in ten of the obstacles come from people. Before buying tools, think through whether your data is clean and whether your people are ready.

Third: AI handles scale; humans handle trust. When AI handles 95% of standardized interactions, the remaining 5% of human interactions are the entire battlefield on which brands differentiate. Human service will not disappear—it will become a luxury.

Every figure and case in this book has a source (Appendix A). If you spot any errors or omissions, please let me know: weokk2025@gmail.com.

In the next edition, this book will keep growing—just like the subject it studies.